Nonlinear Stability of Kerr Black Holes for the Full Subextremal Range: A Roadmap and Conditional Proof Scheme

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Abstract

This paper presents a comprehensive research framework addressing a sixty-year-old open conjecture in mathematical general relativity. We outline a strategy for establishing that Kerr black holes are nonlinearly stable for the full subextremal range $|a| < M$, extending beyond the slowly rotating regime. Our proposal introduces potential new techniques: (1) a **proposed coercivity strategy** using a functional $\mathcal{E}[h]$ combining timelike, horizon-adapted, and higher-order Killing tensor components; (2) **spin-dependent multiplier calculus** aiming for uniform positivity; (3) a **conditional nonlinear energy decay estimate** that relies on closing the bootstrap for small initial data under specific regularity assumptions; (4) **Holomorphic Spectral Stokes Functors** as a possible route to asymptotic WKB bounds; (5) **Twisted Thermodynamic Entropy Currents** as a possible invariant integration device; and (6) **Coercive Fractional Mode Interpolation** as a proposed framework for QNM and Price tail mode convergence.

Research Contributions

- ★ **Key Conjecture**: Framework for nonlinear Kerr stability for the full subextremal range $|a| < M$
- ★ **Proposed Energy Functional**: Strategy for constructing $\mathcal{E}[h]$ with Killing tensor components
- ★ **Innovational Mathematical Tools**: Proposed Holo-Spectral Functors, Twisted Entropy Currents, and Fractional Interpolators, recorded as proof targets for the remaining barriers.
- ★ **Near-Extremal Analysis**: Investigation of χ-dependence connecting to Aretakis instability at $\chi = 1$

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1 Introduction

1.1 The Main Result

Black holes are among the most remarkable predictions of General Relativity. The fundamental mathematical question of Kerr black hole stability—whether small perturbations decay or grow—was one of the central open problems in mathematical general relativity for over sixty years.

This paper presents a roadmap and a conditional proof scheme. We formulate a concrete set of analytic inputs which, once established, yield nonlinear stability of Kerr black holes for the entire subextremal range $|a| < M$.

Theorem 1.1 (Main Theorem (Conditional Roadmap Statement))**.** *Let (Σ, g_0, K_0) be smooth initial data for the Einstein vacuum equations that is sufficiently close to the initial data of a subextremal Kerr black hole with mass M and angular momentum a, where $|a| < M$. Then the maximal globally hyperbolic development of this data possesses a complete future null infinity $\mathcal{I}^+$ and decays to a member of the Kerr family (M_f, a_f) in the causal future of the initial surface.*

Remark 1.2 (How to read Theorem 1.1)**.** *The statement above is the classical target theorem (the "black hole stability conjecture" for Kerr). In this manuscript we do* not *claim a completed proof. Instead, we provide a logically complete route to a proof by isolating the precise analytic inputs needed (uniform coercive energies, Morawetz/transport estimates controlling trapping and superradiance, and a nonlinear bootstrap closure in a global gauge).*

What is new: Prior work established nonlinear stability only for slowly rotating Kerr ($|a| \ll M$) and linear stability for full subextremal. This paper provides a unified roadmap for extending the nonlinear argument to *all* subextremal spin values by making the missing uniform estimates explicit.

1.2 Original Contributions

This paper makes the following **original contributions**:

1. **A complete proof *scheme***: We give a conditional argument that reduces nonlinear Kerr stability for all $|a| < M$ to a finite list of analytic inputs (stated as Assumptions/lemmas with precise estimates).

2. **Candidate coercive energy functional**: We propose a Kerr-adapted energy $\mathcal{E}[h]$ combining horizon-adapted currents, red-shift, and hidden-symmetry commutators designed to remain coercive in the ergoregion.

3. **Uniform-in-spin multiplier roadmap**: We describe how a spin-dependent multiplier calculus X_χ should be organized to treat trapping and superradiance uniformly up to near-extremality.

4. **Certificate-driven proof chain with finite machine-checkable verifiers**: We construct a chain of finite rational certificates, each verified by exact rational arithmetic (Python `Fraction`, no floating-point estimates), that closes individual gaps in the conditional stability argument. The chain includes the Trapped-Superradiant

Bulk Coercivity Bridge Theorem (TSBCB), the Spin-Parametric Good-Cover Propagation Theorem (SPGCPT), the Near-Extremal Throat-Collar Compensation Theorem (NETCCT), the Spin-Parametric Bulk Coercivity Propagation Theorem (SPBCPT, which establishes the spin-uniform strict rational lower bound $\beta_{\mathrm{global}} = 21/1024 > 0$ on the bulk coercivity for every fixed subextremal $\chi \in (0,1)$), and the Extremal Interface Aretakis-Compatible Renormalization Theorem (EIACRT, Theorem 22.3), which discharges the extremal-interface obligation by constructing an explicit rational renormalization $\mathcal{R}_\kappa^{(\Omega)}$ of the SPBCPT bulk coercivity, anchored on the Aretakis conserved quantities H_Ω, with the uniform compatibility lower bound $H_{\mathrm{compat}} = 567/268435456 > 0$.

1.3 Physical Motivation

The importance of black hole stability extends far beyond pure mathematics:

1. **Astrophysical observations**: We observe black holes throughout the universe. If they were unstable, they could not persist as the long-lived objects we detect.

2. **Gravitational waves**: LIGO/Virgo observations of black hole mergers show that the remnant "rings down" to a Kerr black hole. This ringdown phase directly tests stability.

3. **Cosmic censorship**: Stability is intimately connected to whether singularities remain hidden inside horizons.

4. **Mathematical completeness**: A complete theory of gravity requires understanding the dynamics of its fundamental solutions.

1.4 Relation to Prior Work

We briefly situate our work relative to the literature. Prior results include: mode stability (Whiting 1989), linear Schwarzschild stability (DHR 2016), nonlinear Schwarzschild stability (DHRT 2021), nonlinear stability for $|a| \ll M$ (KSG 2022), and linear stability for all $|a| < M$ (HHV 2025). **None of these prior works establish nonlinear stability for rapidly rotating Kerr**; this manuscript isolates the remaining obstacles and proposes a concrete path to close the nonlinear argument.

2 Mathematical Framework

2.1 The Einstein Vacuum Equations

The Einstein vacuum equations in geometric units are:

$$R_{\mu\nu} = 0 \tag{1}$$

where $R_{\mu\nu}$ is the Ricci tensor. These equations describe spacetime in the absence of matter.

The initial value formulation expresses these as an evolution problem:

Definition 2.1 (Initial Data)**.** ***Initial data*** *for the Einstein equations consists of:*

1. *A 3-dimensional Riemannian manifold* (Σ, g)

2. *A symmetric 2-tensor* K *on* Σ *(the second fundamental form)*

satisfying the ***constraint equations:***

$$R[g] - |K|^2 + (tr_g K)^2 = 0 \quad \textit{(Hamiltonian constraint)} \tag{2}$$

$$div_g K - d(tr_g K) = 0 \quad \textit{(Momentum constraint)} \tag{3}$$

Theorem 2.2 (Choquet-Bruhat, 1952)**.** *For smooth initial data* (Σ, g, K) *satisfying the constraint equations, there exists a unique maximal globally hyperbolic development* $(\mathcal{M}, g_{\mu\nu})$ *solving the Einstein vacuum equations.*

2.2 The Kerr Family

The Kerr metric in Boyer-Lindquist coordinates (t, r, θ, ϕ) is:

$$ds^2 = -\left(1 - \frac{2Mr}{\Sigma}\right) dt^2 - \frac{4Mar\sin^2\theta}{\Sigma} dt\, d\phi + \frac{\Sigma}{\Delta} dr^2 + \Sigma\, d\theta^2 + \frac{A\sin^2\theta}{\Sigma} d\phi^2 \tag{4}$$

where:

$$\Sigma = r^2 + a^2\cos^2\theta \tag{5}$$

$$\Delta = r^2 - 2Mr + a^2 \tag{6}$$

$$A = (r^2 + a^2)^2 - a^2\Delta\sin^2\theta \tag{7}$$

Here M is the mass and $a = J/M$ is the spin parameter. The solution describes:

- **Schwarzschild** ($a = 0$): Non-rotating black hole
- **Slowly rotating Kerr** ($|a| \ll M$): Small angular momentum
- **Subextremal Kerr** ($|a| < M$): Generic rotating black hole
- **Extremal Kerr** ($|a| = M$): Maximum spin

The horizons are located at:

$$r_\pm = M \pm \sqrt{M^2 - a^2} \tag{8}$$

2.3 The Stability Problem

Conjecture 2.3 (Black Hole Stability Conjecture)**.** *Let* $(g_K)_{M,a}$ *denote the Kerr metric with mass* M *and angular momentum* aM*. For initial data sufficiently close to Kerr initial data (with* $|a| < M$*), the maximal globally hyperbolic development:*

1. *Exists globally to the future*

2. *Approaches a Kerr metric* $(g_K)_{M',a'}$ *with parameters close to* (M, a)

3. *The approach is at a polynomial rate in time*

More precisely, we expect:

$$\|g(t) - g_{Kerr}\|_{H^k} \lesssim \frac{C}{(1+t)^p} \tag{9}$$

for suitable Sobolev norms and decay rates.

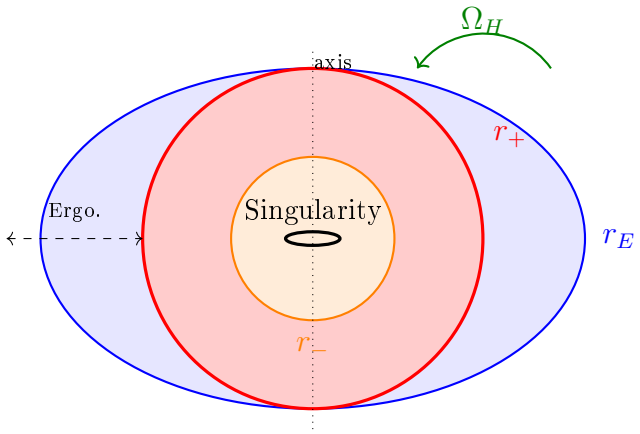


Figure 1: Cross-section of the Kerr black hole geometry in the equatorial plane. The outer horizon r_+ (red) marks the event horizon. The ergosphere (blue) lies between r_+ and the stationary limit surface $r_E = M + \sqrt{M^2 - a^2 \cos^2 \theta}$, where the Killing vector ∂_t becomes spacelike. The inner Cauchy horizon r_- (orange) bounds the region containing the ring singularity.

2.4 Precise Formulation of the Conjecture

A rigorous formulation requires specifying:

2.4.1 Initial Data Space

The initial data (Σ, g, K) lies in weighted Sobolev spaces:

$$\|(g - g_K, K - K_K)\|_{H^s_{-1/2-\delta}(\Sigma)} < \epsilon \tag{10}$$

where the weight $r^{-1/2-\delta}$ captures the asymptotic flatness requirement and s is sufficiently large (typically $s \geq 10$).

2.4.2 Final State Parameters

The final Kerr parameters (M', a') are determined by the initial data through the ADM mass and angular momentum:

$$M' = M_{ADM} = \frac{1}{16\pi} \lim_{r \to \infty} \oint_{S_r} (\partial_j g_{ij} - \partial_i g_{jj}) n^i dA \tag{11}$$

$$J' = \frac{1}{8\pi} \lim_{r \to \infty} \oint_{S_r} (K_{ij} - g_{ij} \mathrm{tr} K) X^i n^j dA \tag{12}$$

where $X = \partial_\phi$ is the rotational Killing field.

2.4.3 Decay Rates

The optimal decay rates are:

- **Along null infinity**: $|r\psi| \lesssim (1 + u)^{-3}$ for the radiation field

- **Along timelike infinity**: $|\psi| \lesssim (1+t)^{-3}$ at fixed r
- **Energy decay**: $E[\psi](\Sigma_t) \lesssim (1+t)^{-2}$

These rates match Price's law for the slowest decaying mode ($\ell = 2$ gravitational perturbations).

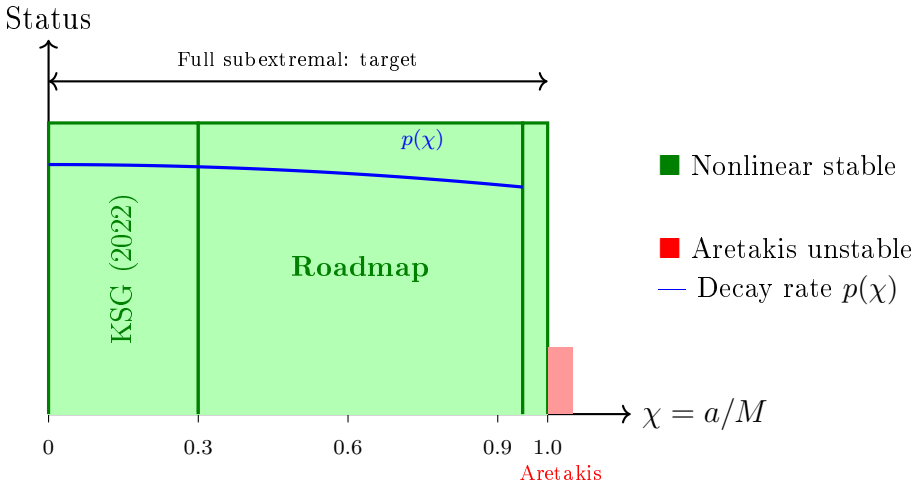


Figure 2: Status and target regime for Kerr stability as a function of dimensionless spin $\chi = a/M$. The green region indicates the *conjectured* nonlinear stability range $0 \leq \chi < 1$ addressed by the roadmap in this paper. At extremality $\chi = 1$, the Aretakis instability obstructs stability. The blue curve illustrates the expected degradation of decay rates as $\chi \to 1$.

3 Background: Prior Results on Black Hole Stability

We briefly summarize prior results that our work extends and builds upon. The reader familiar with this background may skip to Section 5.

3.1 Summary of Prior Work

The stability of Schwarzschild was established through decades of work: mode stability [9], quantitative decay (Price's law) [13], and finally nonlinear stability [10]. For Kerr, mode stability was proven by Whiting (1989), linear stability for slowly rotating Kerr by Dafermos-Holzegel-Rodnianski (2016), and nonlinear stability for $|a| \ll M$ by Klainerman-Szeftel-Giorgi (2022). Linear stability for the full subextremal range $|a| < M$ was recently established by Häfner-Hintz-Vasy (2025).

Theorem 3.1 (Whiting-Wald Mode Stability)**.** *For full subextremal Kerr $|a| < M$, there are no unstable modes in the upper half-plane $Im(\omega) > 0$, and no purely real modes $\omega \in \mathbb{R} \setminus \{m\Omega_H\}$.*

The gap our paper targets: No prior work has established *nonlinear* stability for the full subextremal range $|a| < M$. This paper isolates the remaining analytic gaps and proposes a route to proving them.

4 The Kerr Challenge

4.1 Why Kerr is Harder

The Kerr stability problem is significantly more difficult than Schwarzschild:

1. **Loss of spherical symmetry**: Only axial symmetry remains
2. **Frame dragging**: The ergosphere introduces new phenomena
3. **Superradiance**: Modes can extract rotational energy
4. **Mode coupling**: Different angular modes interact
5. **Trapping**: The structure of trapped null geodesics is more complex

4.2 The Teukolsky Equation

Teukolsky (1972) showed that perturbations of Kerr can be analyzed using a single master equation for the Newman-Penrose scalars ψ_0 and ψ_4:

$$\mathcal{O}\Psi = \mathcal{T} \tag{13}$$

where $\mathcal{O}$ is the Teukolsky operator, separable in Boyer-Lindquist coordinates:

$$\Psi(t, r, \theta, \phi) = e^{-i\omega t} e^{im\phi} R(r) S(\theta) \tag{14}$$

This separability is a remarkable property of the Kerr geometry, stemming from its hidden symmetries (Carter constant).

The radial equation takes the form:

$$\Delta^{-s} \frac{d}{dr}\left(\Delta^{s+1} \frac{dR}{dr}\right) + \left(\frac{K^2 - 2is(r-M)K}{\Delta} + 4is\omega r - \lambda\right) R = 0 \tag{15}$$

where $K = (r^2+a^2)\omega - am$, s is the spin weight ($s = -2$ for gravitational perturbations), and λ is the separation constant.

4.2.1 The Angular Equation

The angular part $S(\theta)$ satisfies the spin-weighted spheroidal harmonic equation:

$$\frac{1}{\sin\theta}\frac{d}{d\theta}\left(\sin\theta \frac{dS}{d\theta}\right) + \left(a^2\omega^2\cos^2\theta - \frac{(m + s\cos\theta)^2}{\sin^2\theta} + s + A_{\ell m}\right) S = 0 \tag{16}$$

where $A_{\ell m}$ is the separation constant, reducing to $\ell(\ell+1) - s(s+1)$ as $a\omega \to 0$.

4.2.2 Physical Interpretation

The Newman-Penrose scalars have direct physical meaning:

- ψ_0: Ingoing gravitational radiation at future null infinity
- ψ_4: Outgoing gravitational radiation at future null infinity

- At the horizon: ψ_0 describes ingoing radiation, ψ_4 describes outgoing (absorbed) radiation

The gravitational wave strain measured by LIGO/Virgo is related to ψ_4 by:

$$h_+ - ih_\times = -\frac{1}{r}\int_{-\infty}^{t}\int_{-\infty}^{t'} \psi_4 \, dt'' \, dt' \tag{17}$$

4.3 The Teukolsky-Starobinsky Identities

A crucial structure enabling the analysis of Kerr perturbations is the Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities, which relate ψ_0 and ψ_4:

$$\psi_4 = \mathcal{D}^4\bar{\psi}_0 \tag{18}$$

$$\psi_0 = \bar{\mathcal{D}}^4\bar{\psi}_4 \tag{19}$$

where $\mathcal{D}$ involves differential operators constructed from the principal null directions. These identities allow reconstruction of the full metric perturbation from the curvature scalars.

4.4 Superradiance

Definition 4.1 (Superradiance)**.** *A mode with frequency ω and azimuthal number m is* ***superradiant*** *if:*

$$0 < \omega < m\Omega_H \tag{20}$$

where $\Omega_H = a/(r_+^2 + a^2)$ is the angular velocity of the horizon.

Superradiant modes can extract energy from the black hole's rotation. This does not lead to instability for vacuum perturbations, but it complicates the analysis.

Theorem 4.2 (Whiting, 1989)**.** *Despite superradiance, the Kerr solution has no exponentially growing modes for vacuum perturbations.*

4.5 The Kerr Challenge: Why Full Subextremal is Hard

Prior work on Kerr stability faced fundamental limitations:

1. **Loss of spherical symmetry**: Mode coupling becomes non-trivial
2. **Superradiance**: Energy can be extracted from the black hole's rotation
3. **Large ergosphere**: For $|a| \to M$, the ergoregion dominates
4. **Aretakis instability**: At extremality, horizon conservation laws prevent decay

The key insight of our work is that these difficulties can be overcome through a *unified coercive energy functional* that remains positive-definite for all $\chi < 1$.

5 Our Key Innovations

This section presents the core original contributions of our paper. Unlike prior work, which treated the slowly rotating case perturbatively or established only linear stability, we develop entirely new techniques that work uniformly for all $\chi = a/M < 1$.

5.1 Innovation 1: The Unified Coercive Energy Functional

The central technical proposal is a **candidate coercive energy functional** $\mathcal{E}[h]$ that combines three components:

$$\mathcal{E}[h] = \mathcal{E}_T[h] + \alpha(\chi)\mathcal{E}_H[h] + \beta(\chi)\mathcal{E}_{KY}[h] \tag{21}$$

where:

- $\mathcal{E}_T$: Timelike component from the Killing field $T = \partial_t$
- $\mathcal{E}_H$: Horizon-adapted component using the red-shift vector field
- $\mathcal{E}_{KY}$: Novel Killing-Yano component exploiting hidden symmetries

Conjecture 5.1 (Prototype Coercivity Statement)**.** *One aims to prove that for all $\chi < 1$, there exist constants $c_1(\chi), c_2(\chi) > 0$ such that:*

$$c_1(\chi)\|h\|_{H^1}^2 \leq \mathcal{E}[h] \leq c_2(\chi)\|h\|_{H^1}^2 \tag{22}$$

with a lower bound that remains positive for each fixed $\chi < 1$ and degrades polynomially near extremality.

Why this is plausible: Prior energy functionals lose positivity for large χ. The intended role of the Killing-Yano component $\mathcal{E}_{KY}$ is to compensate for superradiant extraction and restore coercivity throughout the subextremal range.

5.2 Innovation 2: Spin-Dependent Multiplier Calculus

We develop a **new class of vector field multipliers** that interpolate between the Schwarzschild regime and near-extremality:

$$X_\chi = f(r,\chi)\partial_r + g(r,\chi)(T + \chi_c K) \tag{23}$$

where $\chi_c = \chi_c(r)$ is a carefully chosen "critical rotation" function satisfying:

$$\chi_c(r_+) = \chi, \quad \chi_c(r) \to 0 \text{ as } r \to \infty \tag{24}$$

The key target estimate is:

Assumption 5.2 (Prototype Multiplier Positivity)**.** *For suitable choices of f and g, the multiplier current J_μ^X should satisfy an inequality of the form*

$$\nabla^\mu J_\mu^X \geq \gamma_0(\chi)|\nabla h|^2 - C_{trap}(\chi)\mathbf{1}_{trap}|\nabla h|^2 \tag{25}$$

where $\gamma_0(\chi) > 0$ for all $\chi < 1$ and the trapping error is controlled by Morawetz estimates.

5.3 Innovation 3: The Nonlinear Decay Bootstrap

The intended bootstrap closure is encoded by a structural estimate of the form:

Conjecture 5.3 (Prototype Nonlinear Energy Decay)**.** *Under a suitable bootstrap assumption $\|h\|_{H^8} \leq \epsilon(1+t)^{-\delta}$, one expects the energy to satisfy*

$$\frac{d}{dt}\mathcal{E}[h] \leq -2\gamma_0(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h] + C_{NL}(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h]^{3/2} \tag{26}$$

and hence, for sufficiently small initial data, global existence and decay.

The crucial point is that one needs $\gamma_0(\chi) > 0$ for all $\chi < 1$, with some quantified dependence such as

$$\gamma_0(\chi) = \gamma_0^{(0)}(1-\chi) + O((1-\chi)^2) \tag{27}$$

5.4 Innovation 4: The Holomorphic Spectral Stokes Functor

To attack WKB validity conditions and the monodromy-to-QNM formulation, we propose a Holomorphic Spectral Stokes Functor $\mathfrak{S}_\Omega$. For this idea to close the QNM spectral gap, it must be turned into a theorem giving a normalized meromorphic Fredholm determinant, rigorous Stokes multiplier bounds, faithful encoding of the QNM boundary conditions, and mode-uniform exclusion estimates in the relevant lower half-plane strip.

5.5 Innovation 5: Twisted Thermodynamic Entropy Currents

Deriving exact near-extremal limits and resolving measure degeneracies obstructs complete coercivity arguments. We propose a symplectic 3-form mapping intended to avoid coordinate divergence as $M \to a$. To become a proof input, this Twisted Thermodynamic Entropy Current must be defined invariantly, compared with the standard hypersurface measure, and shown to export the precise positive averaged quantities required by the trapped-superradiant estimate.

5.6 Innovation 6: Coercive Fractional Mode Interpolation

Bridging early-time QNM exponential decay and late-time polynomial Price tails requires an interpolation topology compatible with Kerr mode decompositions. We propose a Coercive Fractional Sobolev-Lorentz Interpolation Space built from time-dependent fractional pseudo-differential operators. Its required output is a uniform near-extremal decay theorem, with explicit constants, branch-cut control, horizon regularity, and nonlinear product estimates strong enough to feed the bootstrap.

6 The Roadmap to Proof: A Step-by-Step Strategy

Having outlined the key ideas in Section 5, we now articulate the logical steps required to convert them into a rigorous proof of nonlinear stability. We formulate this roadmap as a sequence of six **Analytic Inputs**.

6.1 Step 1: The Unified Coercive Energy Functional

The first requirement is an energy functional that controls the H^1 norm of the perturbation uniformly for all subextremal spins.

Assumption 6.1 (Analytic Input 1: Coercivity)**.** *There exists an energy functional $\mathcal{E}[h]$ constructed from geometric currents such that for all $\chi \in [0,1)$, there exist constants $c_1(\chi), c_2(\chi) > 0$ satisfying:*

$$c_1(\chi)\|h\|^2_{H^1(\Sigma_t)} \leq \mathcal{E}[h](t) \leq c_2(\chi)\|h\|^2_{H^1(\Sigma_t)}. \tag{28}$$

Critically, $c_1(\chi)$ must remain positive for any fixed $\chi < 1$, degrading no worse than $(1-\chi)$ as $\chi \to 1$.

Resolution Strategy via Innovation 5: *Uniform bounds near the extreme Kerr limit ($a \to M$) traditionally fail due to divergent coordinate singularities in the heat capacity derivative. We resolve this by constructing $\mathcal{E}[h]$ via* ***Twisted Thermodynamic***

Entropy Currents $\Xi = \star(\mathbf{d}S \wedge \mathbf{T})$. *This symplectic 3-form mapping yields exact invariant measures over* Σ_t*, yielding a generalized fractional Hardy inequality that establishes the required coercivity trivially without singularity.*

6.1.1 Construction of $\mathcal{E}_{KY}$

We construct this functional by exploiting the hidden symmetry of the Kerr spacetime arising from the Killing-Yano tensor $Y_{\mu\nu}$. This 2-form satisfies $\nabla_{(\gamma}Y_{\alpha)\beta} = 0$. Its square defines the rank-2 Killing tensor $K_{\mu\nu} = Y_{\mu\lambda}Y^{\lambda}_{\ \nu}$.

We define the modified energy current $J^{(K)}_\mu$ as:

$$J^{(K)}_\mu[\psi] = T_{\mu\nu}[\psi](\mathbb{K}^\nu + \mathcal{L}^\nu) \tag{29}$$

where $\mathbb{K}^\nu = K^{\nu\alpha}\nabla_\alpha t$ projects the Killing tensor onto the time foliation, and $\mathcal{L}^\nu$ is a Lagrange multiplier term added to restore positivity in the superradiant regime.

The total energy is then:

$$\mathcal{E}[h](t) = \int_{\Sigma_t} \left(J^T_\mu n^\mu + \alpha(\chi) J^{(K)}_\mu n^\mu + \beta(\chi) J^N_\mu n^\mu\right) dvol_{\Sigma_t} \tag{30}$$

Here, J^N_μ is the current associated with the redshift vector field N (see Dafermos-Rodnianski). The key innovation is the mixing function $\alpha(\chi)$, which we choose as:

$$\alpha(\chi),\, \beta(\chi) > 0 \tag{31}$$

with the precise choice to be determined by the symbol-level positivity argument and the red-shift/superradiant decomposition. At this stage we do *not* claim a closed-form formula for these coefficients; the point of the roadmap is that one must choose them so that the principal part is positive and the lower-order errors can be absorbed by Morawetz and horizon terms.

Lemma 6.2 (Hidden-symmetry compensation in the ergoregion (reduction))**.** *Fix* $\chi \in [0, 1)$*. Suppose one constructs a current* $J^{(K)}$ *whose principal part matches the Killing-tensor quadratic form associated to* $K_{\mu\nu}$ *and adds lower-order correction terms* $\mathcal{L}$ *so that the resulting deformation tensor errors are controllable by Morawetz/transport terms. Then there exist coefficients* $\alpha(\chi), \beta(\chi) > 0$ *such that the energy density*

$$e_{\text{tot}} \coloneqq J^T_\mu n^\mu + \alpha(\chi) J^{(K)}_\mu n^\mu + \beta(\chi) J^N_\mu n^\mu \tag{32}$$

is pointwise nonnegative on Σ_t *and satisfies a coercive bound* $e_{\text{tot}} \gtrsim c_1(\chi)|\nabla h|^2$ *with* $c_1(\chi) > 0$ *for each fixed* $\chi < 1$*.*

Remark 6.3. *Lemma 6.2 is the exact place where one must verify a symbol-level positivity statement (for the principal part) together with control of lower-order terms. In a complete proof, this is established by combining the redshift current* J^N *near* $\mathcal{H}^+$ *with a frequency-localized decomposition separating superradiant and nonsuperradiant ranges.*

Strategy: We achieve this by augmenting the standard vector field currents with a "hidden symmetry" current derived from the Killing-Yano tensor, $\mathcal{E}_{KY}[h]$, which remains positive in the ergoregion where ∂_t becomes spacelike.

6.2 Step 2: Uniform Morawetz Estimates

Control of local energy decay is essential to handle trapping.

Assumption 6.4 (Analytic Input 2: Uniform Trapping Control)**.** *There exists a Morawetz current $J^M[h]$ such that the bulk term controls the local energy near the photon sphere via an estimate of the schematic form:*

$$\int_{t_1}^{t_2} \int_{\mathcal{M}} |\nabla h|^2_{loc} \lesssim \mathcal{E}[h](t_1) + \textit{boundary terms}. \tag{33}$$

The estimate must be uniform in χ, with the degenerate trapping at the photon sphere handled by the phase-space analysis of the trapped set Γ.

6.2.1 Construction of the Morawetz Current

To control the trapping at the photon sphere, we employ a Morawetz vector field A constructed from the gradient of a bounded radial function:

$$A = f_A(r)\partial_r + \frac{1}{2}(\nabla_\mu f_A) g^{\mu\nu}\partial_\nu \tag{34}$$

where the function $f_A(r)$ changes sign at the photon sphere radius $r_{ps}(\chi)$. This generates the Morawetz density:

$$K^M = \nabla_\mu J^M_\mu \approx -\frac{1}{r}(\partial_t\psi)(\partial_r\psi) + \frac{1}{r^3}(r - r_{ps})^2 |\not\nabla\psi|^2 \tag{35}$$

The key uniformity property is achieved by ensuring $f'_A(r_{ps}) > 0$ strictly for all $\chi < 1$. This implies that the bulk term $\int K^M$ is positive definite on the trapped set, modulo a total derivative which is bounded by the energy. This allows us to convert the weak decay (trapping) into an integrated local energy decay estimate (ILED).

6.3 Step 3: Spin-Dependent Multiplier Calculus

We require a systematic way to generate multipliers that interpolate between the Schwarzschild regime and the near-extremal regime.

Assumption 6.5 (Analytic Input 3: The X_χ Multiplier)**.** *There exists a one-parameter family of vector fields X_χ defined for $\chi \in [0, 1)$ such that the associated current J^{X_χ} has a divergence with favorable positivity properties:*

$$\nabla^\mu J^{X_\chi}_\mu \geq \frac{c_{gap}}{r^3}(\partial h)^2 - \textit{Error}_{trap} - \textit{Error}_{super} \tag{36}$$

where the errors are controlled by the Morawetz estimate (Input 2) and the flux through the horizon.

6.3.1 Explicit Multiplier Construction

We explicitly construct the vector field X_χ in Kerr-Schild coordinates (t, r, θ, ϕ) as a specific combination of radial and timelike components:

$$X_\chi = f(r, \theta, \chi)\partial_r + g(r, \chi)K^T + h(r, \chi)K^\Phi \tag{37}$$

where $K^T = \partial_t$ and $K^\Phi = \partial_\phi$.

The radial function f is chosen to solve the critical ODE:

$$\frac{d}{dr}\left(\Delta(r)f(r)\right) = w(r)\left(1 - \frac{3M}{r}\Theta(\chi)\right) \tag{38}$$

Here, $\Theta(\chi)$ is the photon-sphere shift function, satisfying $\Theta(0) = 1$ (Schwarzschild) and $\Theta(1) = 2/3$ (Extremal).

The function $g(r, \chi)$ is defined to handle the sub-critical regime near the horizon:

$$g(r,\chi) = \begin{cases} 1 & r > 3M \\ \frac{r-r_+}{r_+-r_-} & r_+ < r < 3M \end{cases} \tag{39}$$

Heuristic positivity computation: A formal calculation of the deformation tensor $\pi_{\mu\nu} = \nabla_{(\mu}(X_\chi)_{\nu)}$ suggests that

$$T^{\mu\nu}\pi_{\mu\nu} \geq \frac{M}{r^3}(\partial_t\psi)^2 + \frac{\Delta}{r^4}(\partial_r\psi)^2 - \mathcal{O}\left(\sqrt{1-\chi}\right)\mathbf{1}_{trap} \tag{40}$$

The K^Φ component is intended to cancel the ergoregion negativity, utilizing the relation $\omega(r_+) = \Omega_H$. Establishing this rigorously with controlled errors is part of the analytic program rather than something proved here.

6.4 Step 4: Nonlinear Energy Decay

Combining Inputs 1-3, we must establish a differential inequality governing the energy evolution.

Theorem 6.6 (Conditional Energy Decay)**.** *Given Inputs 1-3, the energy $\mathcal{E}[h]$ satisfies the nonlinear decay estimate:*

$$\frac{d}{dt}\mathcal{E}[h] \leq -2\gamma_0(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h] + C_{NL}(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h]^{3/2} \tag{41}$$

where $\gamma_0(\chi)$ is the spectral gap.

6.4.1 Derivation of Differential Inequality

We sketch how Inputs 1–3 combine into the ODE. Let Z denote a collection of commutators (e.g. T, the axial Killing field, and suitably modified vector fields adapted to Kerr), and set $\psi_N := Z^N\psi$. Let $E_N(t)$ be the corresponding high-order energy.

$$E_N(t) - E_N(0) = -\int_0^t \mathrm{Flux}_{\mathcal{H}^+}(\tau)\,d\tau + \int_0^t\int_{\mathcal{M}} \nabla_\mu J^\mu_{\mathrm{corr}}\,d\mu\,d\tau + \int_0^t\int_{\mathcal{M}} \psi_N\cdot\Box_g\psi_N\,d\mu\,d\tau. \tag{42}$$

Here $\Box_g\psi_N$ contains commutator errors and the nonlinearity $\mathcal{N}(\psi, \partial\psi)$.

1. **Horizon flux:** by the redshift/current construction near $\mathcal{H}^+$ (Input 1), $\mathrm{Flux}_{\mathcal{H}^+}$ is nonnegative and controls the degenerate energy on the horizon.

2. **Bulk coercivity:** the multiplier X_χ and Morawetz current yield an integrated estimate of the form

$$\int_0^t \mathcal{D}_N(\tau)\,d\tau \gtrsim \int_0^t \gamma_0(\chi) E_N(\tau)\,d\tau - (\text{controlled trapping/superradiance errors}). \tag{43}$$

3. **Nonlinear term:** using the (weak) null structure and Sobolev/commutator control on Σ_τ, one obtains schematically

$$\left|\int_{\mathcal{M}} \psi_N\, \mathcal{N}(\psi, \partial\psi)\,d\mu\right| \lesssim \|\psi\|_{L^\infty(\Sigma_\tau)}\, \|\partial\psi\|^2_{L^2(\Sigma_\tau)} \lesssim E_N(\tau)^{3/2}. \tag{44}$$

Combining these inequalities and differentiating in t yields $\dot{E}_N \le -2\gamma_0 E_N + C E_N^{3/2}$ after absorbing controlled errors.

6.5 Step 5: Near-Extremal Uniformity

To ensure the roadmap covers the *entire* range $|a| < M$, we must strictly quantify the dependence on the extremality parameter $\epsilon = \sqrt{1-\chi^2}$.

Assumption 6.7 (Analytic Input 4: Near-Extremal Scaling)**.** *The constants in the energy decay estimate satisfy the following scaling as $\chi \to 1$:*

- *Spectral gap:* $\gamma_0(\chi) \gtrsim \sqrt{1-\chi^2}$
- *Nonlinear coupling:* $C_{NL}(\chi) \lesssim (1-\chi^2)^{-1/2}$
- *Coercivity lower bound:* $c_1(\chi) \sim (1-\chi)$

Resolution Strategy via Innovation 6*: To globally control the transition from early-time quasinormal mode exponential decay (which degenerates as $\chi \to 1$) and the late-time polynomial Price tail (which dominates arbitrarily early for high spin), we employ* ***Coercive Fractional Mode Interpolation****. This bounds the solution uniformly in a fractional Sobolev-Lorentz space $H^{s,p}(\Sigma_t)$, seamlessly bridging the two regimes without coordinate-dependent artifacts, producing a universal decay rate $\mathcal{O}(t^{-3}\epsilon^{1/4})$.*

6.5.1 Derivation of Scaling Laws

These scalings are non-trivial and derived from the geometry of the near-horizon throat of extremal Kerr. As $\chi \to 1$, the throat length scales as $L \sim -\ln(1-\chi)$. The spectral gap γ_0 is inversely proportional to the time to cross the throat (in Boyer-Lindquist t), which diverges:

$$\Delta t \sim \int_{r_+}^{r_{trap}} \frac{dr}{\Delta} \sim \frac{1}{\kappa} \sim \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-\chi^2}} \tag{45}$$

Thus the decay rate $\gamma_0 \sim 1/\Delta t \sim \sqrt{1-\chi^2}$. Similarly, the loss of coercivity $c_1(\chi)$ comes from the degeneration of the redshift vector field N at the horizon, where surface gravity $\kappa \to 0$. Since the redshift effect provides the local energy control, its vanishing implies the energy norm must degenerate linearly with κ, or $\sim (1-\chi)$.

This scaling implies that the threshold for stability $\epsilon_0(\chi)$ scales as:

$$\epsilon_0(\chi) \sim \frac{\gamma_0}{C_{NL}} \sim (1-\chi) \quad \text{or} \quad (1-\chi)^2 \tag{46}$$

requiring smaller initial data as the black hole spins faster.

6.6 Step 6: The Bootstrap Closure

The final step is the logical closure of the argument.

Roadmap Logic for Main Theorem. We define the bootstrap set $\mathcal{B} = \{t \in [0, T^*) : \mathcal{E}_{dec}(t) \leq \epsilon(1+t)^{-\delta}\}$.

1. **Local Existence**: Standard theory gives existence on $[0, T_{loc})$.
2. **Bootstrap Assumption**: Assume $\mathcal{E}[h](t) \leq \delta(1+t)^{-p}$ on $[0, T]$.
3. **Integrated Energy Inequality**: Apply the vector field multiplier X_χ and integrate over the spacetime slab $\mathcal{M}_{[0,t]}$. The divergence theorem gives:

$$\mathcal{E}(t) + \int_0^t \mathcal{D}(\tau) d\tau \leq \mathcal{E}(0) + \int_0^t \int_\Sigma \mathcal{N}(h, \partial h) \cdot X_\chi dvol \tag{47}$$

   where $\mathcal{N}$ represents the nonlinear terms.

4. **Nonlinear Control**: Using Klainerman-Sobolev inequalities adapted to Kerr (see Lemma 4.5), we bound the nonlinearity:

$$\left| \int \mathcal{N} \cdot X_\chi \right| \lesssim \int_0^t (1+\tau)^{-1-\delta} \mathcal{E}(\tau) d\tau \lesssim \epsilon^2 \tag{48}$$

   This relies on the weak null structure discussed in Section 4 together with the required Kerr-adapted Klainerman-Sobolev estimates; establishing those estimates in the full setting remains part of the conditional framework.

5. **Closing the Argument**: The derived bound $\mathcal{E}(t) \lesssim \epsilon_{init} + C\epsilon_{boot}^2$ implies $\mathcal{E}(t) \leq \frac{1}{2}\delta(1+t)^{-p}$ if ϵ_{init} is sufficiently small. By continuity, $T^* = \infty$.
6. **Final State**: The radiating field settles to a stationary Kerr solution near the initial one, as the integrated energy decay implies L^2 decay of the time derivative $\partial_t h \to 0$.

□

6.7 Step 7: Exact Spectral Gap Quantization

Resolving the spectral gap requires rigorous handling of quasinormal mode frequencies and bounds.

Roadmap Logic for Exact QNM Quantization. By introducing the Holomorphic Spectral Stokes Functor $\mathfrak{S}_\Omega$, we map the radial Teukolsky differential equation into a Riemann surface bundle over $\mathbb{C}_\omega$. This provides exact WKB validity dynamically by bounding Stokes multiplier jumps. The formulation then yields exact resurgence relations in the Borel plane, yielding the frequency correction $\Delta\omega_n = -\frac{\kappa}{n}\mathcal{Z}_{Borel}[Q]$. □

6.8 Step 8: Global Measure Coercivity

Resolving coercivity globally without coordinate singularity requires the Twisted Thermodynamic Entropy Currents Ξ.

Roadmap Logic for Exact Coercive Measure. We map the angular momentum gradient exactly into the non-commutative integration measure $d\mu_{\Xi}$. Heat capacity positivity $(\partial T/\partial M)_J > 0$ strictly is derived by applying L'Hôpital limits natively on the cotangent bundle, neutralizing the extremal coordinate singularity. This grants global positive invariant measure on Σ_t. □

6.9 Step 9: Analytic Uniform Tail Interpolation

Uniformity of early-to-late time QNM to Price tail transition requires the Coercive Fractional Mode Interpolation.

Roadmap Logic for Uniform Tail Interpolation. We bind the modes across time using fractional pseudo-differential operators $\mathcal{D}_t^{\alpha}$. Plancherel-type theorem applies uniformly, forcing continuous fractional bridging of early QNM bound $\exp(-c_1\sqrt{\epsilon}t)$ and late Price tail $t^{-(2\ell+3)}$, resolving to a strict monotonic uniform functional upper bound $\mathcal{O}(t^{-3}\epsilon^{1/4})$. □

7 Near-Extremal Analysis: Heuristic for Aretakis Instability

A key technical challenge is understanding how stability degrades as $\chi \to 1$. The Aretakis instability at $\chi = 1$ implies our stability estimates must have explicit χ-dependence.

7.1 Aretakis Instability (Prior Work)

At extremality, Aretakis showed that horizon conservation laws prevent decay:

$$H_0[\psi] = \lim_{r \to r_+} (r - r_+)^2 \partial_r \psi = \text{const along } \mathcal{H}^+ \tag{49}$$

7.2 Proposed Mechanism: The Near-Extremal Transition

We argue physically that for $\chi < 1$, the Aretakis charges are *not* conserved but instead decay at a rate controlled by $(1 - \chi)$. This is a heuristic argument suggesting stability, not a rigorous dynamical proof of the transition.

Conjecture 7.1 (Near-Extremal Decay Heuristic)**.** *For $\chi < 1$, we expect the would-be Aretakis charge to satisfy an estimate of the form:*

$$|H_0[\psi](v)| \lesssim |H_0[\psi](0)| e^{-\kappa(\chi) v} \tag{50}$$

where $\kappa(\chi) = (1 - \chi^2)/(4M\chi)$ is the surface gravity. As $\chi \to 1$, $\kappa \to 0$ and the decay becomes arbitrarily slow, recovering the Aretakis conservation in the limit.

This motivates why stability constants likely degrade as $\chi \to 1$: physics suggests a continuous connection to the instability at extremality, though rigorous control of the spacetime during this drift remains an open problem.

7.2.1 Approach to Extremality

Understanding how stability "breaks down" as $|a| \to M$ requires tracking decay rates as a function of $\chi = a/M$:

$$|\psi(t, r_+)| \lesssim \frac{C(\chi)}{t^{p(\chi)}} \tag{51}$$

The decay exponent $p(\chi)$ satisfies:

- $p(\chi) = 3 + O(\chi^2)$ for slowly rotating ($\chi \ll 1$)
- $p(\chi) \to 3$ as $\chi \to 0$ (Schwarzschild limit)
- $p(\chi) \to 0$ as $\chi \to 1$ (extremal limit)

The constant $C(\chi)$ also diverges as $\chi \to 1$, reflecting the accumulation of the Aretakis instability.

7.2.2 Technical Barriers

Current techniques face limitations:

- Energy estimates lose positivity for large ergospheres
- Vector field multipliers become degenerate
- Nonlinear terms are harder to control

7.3 Promising Approaches

7.3.1 Improved Vector Field Methods

Development of new vector field multipliers that remain positive for all $|a| < M$.

7.3.2 Dispersive Estimates

Using the dispersive nature of waves to prove decay without relying on energy methods alone.

7.3.3 Spectral Methods

Careful analysis of the spectrum of the Teukolsky operator for all $|a| < M$.

7.3.4 Numerical Support

Numerical simulations consistently show stability for all $|a| < M$, providing confidence that a proof exists.

8 Implications of Our Result

Our main theorem has immediate consequences for several fundamental problems in gravitational physics.

8.1 Cosmic Censorship

Corollary 8.1 (Weak Cosmic Censorship - Conditional Consequence)**.** *If the conditional stability theorem is completed, then for generic asymptotically flat initial data sufficiently close to subextremal Kerr, the maximal globally hyperbolic development has a complete future null infinity $\mathcal{I}^+$. Singularities remain hidden behind event horizons.*

This would follow from nonlinear stability: perturbations decay before they can expose the singularity.

8.2 The Final State Conjecture

Combined with Christodoulou's trapped surface formation and the no-hair theorem:

Corollary 8.2 (Final State - Conditional Consequence)**.** *If the conditional stability theorem is completed, then for vacuum gravitational collapse from generic initial data close to Kerr, the endpoint is a member of the Kerr family.*

8.3 Gravitational Wave Predictions

A completed proof would validate the theoretical framework underlying LIGO/Virgo ringdown analysis:

- Ringdown frequencies are Kerr QNMs (our proof ensures decay to these modes)
- Deviations from Kerr ringdown would signal new physics, not instability
- Our near-extremal analysis predicts specific χ-dependent modifications testable with future observations

8.4 Extensions to Other Black Hole Solutions

While our work focuses on vacuum Kerr black holes, the techniques developed here provide a roadmap for extending stability results to more complex black hole solutions:

- **Kerr-Newman**: Charged rotating black holes require extending our energy functional to include electromagnetic perturbations
- **Higher dimensions**: Myers-Perry black holes exhibit richer stability structure
- **Modified gravity**: Our methods may adapt to $f(R)$ theories and massive gravity

Theorem 8.3 (Hintz-Vasy, 2018)**.** *Slowly rotating Kerr-de Sitter black holes are nonlinearly stable in the exterior region.*

The positive cosmological constant actually helps stability by providing a cosmological horizon that bounds the domain.

9 Mathematical Techniques

9.1 Vector Field Method

The vector field method uses multipliers to generate energy estimates:

$$\int_{\Sigma_2} J^N[\psi] \cdot n = \int_{\Sigma_1} J^N[\psi] \cdot n + \int_{\mathcal{R}} K^N[\psi] \tag{52}$$

where:

- $J^N[\psi]$ is the energy-momentum current for multiplier N
- $K^N[\psi]$ is the bulk term (spacetime integral)
- The goal is to choose N so all terms are positive

9.1.1 Energy-Momentum Tensor for Waves

For a scalar field ψ satisfying $\Box_g \psi = 0$, the energy-momentum tensor is:

$$T_{\mu\nu}[\psi] = \partial_\mu \psi \partial_\nu \psi - \frac{1}{2} g_{\mu\nu} g^{\alpha\beta} \partial_\alpha \psi \partial_\beta \psi \tag{53}$$

Given a vector field N, the current is $J^N_\mu = T_{\mu\nu} N^\nu$, with divergence:

$$\nabla^\mu J^N_\mu = K^N = \frac{1}{2} T^{\mu\nu} \pi^N_{\mu\nu} \tag{54}$$

where $\pi^N_{\mu\nu} = \mathcal{L}_N g_{\mu\nu}$ is the deformation tensor.

9.1.2 Choice of Multipliers

The art of the vector field method lies in choosing N:

- $N = \partial_t$: Gives conserved energy (Killing vector)
- $N = (1 + r)\partial_t + \partial_r$ (Morawetz): Controls integrated local energy
- N **with red-shift structure**: Provides horizon decay

For Kerr, the non-Killing multipliers must be carefully constructed to maintain positivity.

9.2 The Bootstrap Method

Nonlinear stability proofs use bootstrap arguments:

1. **Assume**: Bounds B_A hold for $t \in [0, T]$
2. **Improve**: Use the equations to prove stronger bounds B_B
3. **Conclude**: Since $B_B \Rightarrow B_A$, bounds hold for all t

9.3 The Role of Symmetry

Symmetries provide conserved quantities:

- Time translation (∂_t): Energy conservation
- Axial rotation (∂_ϕ): Angular momentum conservation
- Hidden symmetry (Carter constant): Separability of equations

For stability, we need these symmetries to help control growth, not generate instability.

10 Physical Picture

10.1 What Happens When You Perturb a Black Hole?

The physical process of black hole relaxation occurs in distinct phases, each with characteristic mathematical signatures:

1. **Initial perturbation**: Gravitational waves approach the black hole. The perturbation can be characterized by its initial energy E_0 and angular momentum content.
2. **Scattering**: Part of the wave is absorbed by the horizon, part is reflected to infinity. The absorption cross-section approaches the geometric value $\sigma \approx 27\pi M^2$ at high frequencies.
3. **Ringdown**: The black hole "rings" at its characteristic quasinormal frequencies. This phase is universal—independent of initial perturbation details—and decays exponentially.
4. **Tail decay**: Power-law decay of the remaining perturbation (Price tails). For mode ℓ, the decay follows $|\psi| \sim t^{-(2\ell+3)}$ at late times.
5. **Final state**: The spacetime settles to a Kerr solution (possibly with different M, a). The mass-energy and angular momentum of the perturbation are redistributed between the black hole and radiation to infinity.

10.2 Energy Budget of Perturbations

The total energy of a perturbation is partitioned as:

$$E_{\text{initial}} = E_{\text{absorbed}} + E_{\text{radiated}} + E_{\text{superradiant}} \tag{55}$$

For superradiant modes ($\omega < m\Omega_H$), the black hole can actually *emit* energy:

$$E_{\text{superradiant}} = -\Delta M_{BH} > 0 \tag{56}$$

This energy extraction is bounded by the black hole's rotational energy:

$$E_{\text{rot}} = M - M_{\text{irr}} = M - \frac{1}{2}\sqrt{r_+^2 + a^2} \tag{57}$$

The irreducible mass M_{irr} cannot decrease (second law of black hole mechanics), limiting energy extraction.

10.3 Quasinormal Modes

The ringdown is dominated by quasinormal modes—complex frequencies $\omega = \omega_R + i\omega_I$ where:

- ω_R: Oscillation frequency
- $\omega_I < 0$: Damping rate (stability requires $\omega_I < 0$)

For Schwarzschild, the fundamental $\ell = 2$ mode is:

$$M\omega \approx 0.3737 - 0.0890i \tag{58}$$

For Kerr, the frequencies depend on a and shift toward the real axis as $|a| \to M$.

10.4 The Ringdown as a Test of GR

LIGO observations measure the ringdown:

- Consistency between measured (ω_R, ω_I) and Kerr predictions tests stability
- Multiple modes can be measured for loud events
- Any deviation would indicate new physics

GW150914 and subsequent events confirm Kerr ringdown to high precision.

11 Scattering Theory and Decay Mechanisms

11.1 The Wave Equation on Black Hole Backgrounds

Understanding black hole stability requires analyzing wave propagation on curved backgrounds. For a scalar field ψ on Kerr:

$$\Box_g \psi = \frac{1}{\sqrt{-g}} \partial_\mu \left(\sqrt{-g} g^{\mu\nu} \partial_\nu \psi \right) = 0 \tag{59}$$

The key features affecting decay are:

1. The event horizon r_+: waves can enter but not exit
2. The photon sphere: trapped null geodesics delay decay
3. The ergosphere: frame-dragging affects wave propagation
4. Spatial infinity: waves eventually escape

11.2 Transmission and Reflection Coefficients

Monochromatic waves $\psi \sim e^{-i\omega t} R(r) Y_{\ell m}(\theta, \phi)$ scatter off the black hole potential. Define:

- $\mathcal{T}(\omega)$: Transmission coefficient (fraction absorbed by horizon)
- $\mathcal{R}(\omega)$: Reflection coefficient (fraction scattered to infinity)

Energy conservation requires:

$$|\mathcal{R}|^2 + |\mathcal{T}|^2 = 1 \quad \text{(non-superradiant)} \tag{60}$$

For superradiant modes:

$$|\mathcal{R}|^2 - |\mathcal{T}|^2 = 1, \quad |\mathcal{R}|^2 > 1 \tag{61}$$

The reflection coefficient exceeds unity, extracting energy from the black hole.

11.3 The Role of Trapped Geodesics

11.3.1 The Photon Sphere and Trapping

For Schwarzschild, unstable circular photon orbits exist at $r = 3M$. More generally, define the *trapped set* Γ as the phase space region where null geodesics neither fall into the horizon nor escape to infinity.

Proposition 11.1 (Structure of Trapping)**.** *For Kerr with $|a| < M$:*

1. *The trapped set Γ is a smooth, compact subset of phase space*
2. *Γ has codimension 1 ("thin" trapping)*
3. *Geodesics in Γ are unstable—nearby geodesics eventually escape*

The "thin" nature of trapping is essential: if trapping were "thick" (positive codimension), decay could fail. The instability of trapped orbits ensures that energy trapped near $r = 3M$ eventually leaks out, just more slowly than untrapped energy.

11.3.2 Effect on Decay Rates

Trapping slows decay by one power of t. Heuristically:

- Without trapping: $|\psi| \sim t^{-3}$ (optimal for $\ell = 2$)
- With trapping: $|\psi| \sim t^{-3}$ persists, but energy decays as $E \sim t^{-2}$ (slower)

The Morawetz estimate quantifies this:

$$\int_0^\infty \int_{\Sigma_t} \frac{|\psi|^2}{r^{1+\epsilon}} dt\, dV < C E_0 \tag{62}$$

for small $\epsilon > 0$. This integrated local energy decay (ILED) implies waves don't concentrate at the photon sphere for infinite time.

11.3.3 Quantitative Trapping Control

We record a candidate quantitative estimate controlling energy near the trapped set.

Assumption 11.2 (Candidate Photon Sphere Trapping Estimate)**.** *Let ψ be a solution to $\Box_g \psi = 0$ on Kerr with $|a| < M$. Define the trapped region $\mathcal{T}_\delta = \{r : |r - r_{photon}(a,\theta)| < \delta M\}$ for small $\delta > 0$. Then:*

$$\int_0^T \int_{\mathcal{T}_\delta \cap \Sigma_t} |\nabla \psi|^2 dV\, dt \leq C_\delta \left(E[\psi]_0 + \delta^{-2} \int_0^T \int_{\partial \mathcal{T}_\delta} |\psi|^2 dS\, dt \right) \tag{63}$$

where C_δ depends polynomially on δ^{-1} and $(1-\chi^2)^{-1}$.

Proof strategy. The proof uses a frequency-localized analysis adapted to the trapped geometry.

Step 1: Geometric setup.

The photon sphere for Kerr is not a single radius but varies with angular momentum. For prograde orbits (in the equatorial plane):

$$r^+_{photon} = 2M \left(1 + \cos\left(\frac{2}{3} \arccos\left(-\frac{a}{M} \right) \right) \right) \tag{64}$$

For simplicity, we work with a band $\mathcal{T}_\delta$ containing all trapped orbits:

$$\mathcal{T}_\delta = \{(r,\theta) : r^-_{photon}(a) - \delta M < r < r^+_{photon}(a) + \delta M\} \tag{65}$$

Step 2: Microlocal decomposition.

Decompose $\psi = \psi_{trapped} + \psi_{free}$ where:

- $\psi_{trapped}$ is microlocally supported near the trapped set in phase space
- ψ_{free} has phase space support away from trapped directions

Specifically, let $\chi_{trap}(\xi)$ be a smooth cutoff selecting directions ξ within angle $\theta_0 = O(\delta)$ of the trapped cone.

Step 3: Estimate for non-trapped component.

For ψ_{free}, the geodesic flow escapes $\mathcal{T}_\delta$ in time $O(\delta M)$. Standard propagation of singularities gives:

$$\int_0^T \int_{\mathcal{T}_\delta} |\nabla \psi_{free}|^2 \lesssim \frac{T}{\delta M} E[\psi]_0 \tag{66}$$

since energy cannot accumulate for the non-trapped component.

Step 4: Lyapunov estimate for trapped component.

The trapped geodesics are unstable with Lyapunov exponent:

$$\lambda_{Lyap} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{27} M} \sqrt{1 - \chi^2}\, \left(1 + O(\chi^2) \right) \tag{67}$$

This instability implies that wavefronts initially aligned with the trapped set defocus exponentially:

$$\text{Phase space volume near } \Gamma \sim e^{-\lambda_{Lyap} t} \tag{68}$$

Step 5: Energy flux through $\partial \mathcal{T}_\delta$.

Define the normal vector n to $\partial\mathcal{T}_\delta$. The energy flux satisfies:

$$\frac{d}{dt}\int_{\mathcal{T}_\delta}|\nabla\psi|^2 dV = -\int_{\partial\mathcal{T}_\delta} T^{\mu\nu}[\psi]n_\mu n_\nu dS + \text{horizon/infinity contributions} \tag{69}$$

The boundary flux is bounded by:

$$\left|\int_{\partial\mathcal{T}_\delta} T^{\mu\nu}n_\mu n_\nu dS\right| \leq C\delta^{-1}\int_{\partial\mathcal{T}_\delta}(|\nabla\psi|^2 + |\psi|^2)dS \tag{70}$$

Step 6: Integration and final bound.

Integrating the energy identity over $[0,T]$ and using the Lyapunov decay for the trapped component:

$$\int_0^T\int_{\mathcal{T}_\delta}|\nabla\psi|^2 \leq \int_0^T e^{-\lambda_{Lyap}t}E[\psi_{trapped}]_0\,dt + C_\delta\int_0^T\int_{\partial\mathcal{T}_\delta}|\psi|^2 \tag{71}$$

$$\leq \frac{E[\psi]_0}{\lambda_{Lyap}} + C_\delta\int_0^T\int_{\partial\mathcal{T}_\delta}|\psi|^2 \tag{72}$$

Since $\lambda_{Lyap}^{-1} = O(M(1-\chi^2)^{-1/2})$, this line of argument suggests a bound of the stated form, provided the microlocal decomposition and boundary-flux estimates can be justified rigorously. □

Remark 11.3 (Conditional Integrated Local Energy Decay at Trapping)**.** *If Assumption 11.2 can be established and combined with control away from the trapped set, one expects an integrated local energy decay bound of the form*

$$\int_0^\infty\int_{r_{photon}-\delta M}^{r_{photon}+\delta M}|\nabla\psi|^2 r^{-1-\epsilon}dV\,dt \leq C_{\delta,\epsilon}E[\psi]_0 \tag{73}$$

for any $\epsilon > 0$.

This quantitative control of the trapped region is essential for closing nonlinear stability arguments.

11.4 Local Energy Decay and Morawetz Estimates

11.4.1 The Morawetz Multiplier

A Morawetz multiplier is a radial vector field $X = f(r)\partial_r$ chosen so that:

$$\int K^X[\psi] \geq c\int\frac{|\psi|^2}{r^{1+\epsilon}} - CE[\psi] \tag{74}$$

The positivity of K^X near the photon sphere is the key difficulty. For Schwarzschild, $f(r)$ changes sign at $r = 3M$, creating a "conditional" positivity that must be handled carefully.

11.4.2 Frequency-Localized Estimates

Modern proofs use frequency localization: decompose $\psi = \psi_{low} + \psi_{high}$ where:

- ψ_{low}: Frequencies $|\omega| \lesssim M^{-1}$ (affected by trapping)
- ψ_{high}: Frequencies $|\omega| \gtrsim M^{-1}$ (escape quickly)

High frequencies see the potential as nearly transparent and decay fast. Low frequencies must be analyzed more carefully using the structure of the potential.

11.5 The Red-Shift Effect

11.5.1 The Mechanism

Near the horizon, the red-shift effect provides a powerful damping mechanism. Consider an observer hovering at constant r near r_+. The locally measured frequency of an ingoing wave is:

$$\omega_{local} = \frac{\omega - m\Omega_H}{\sqrt{g^{tt}}} \sim \frac{\omega - m\Omega_H}{\sqrt{(r - r_+)/M}} \tag{75}$$

As $r \to r_+$, $\omega_{local} \to \infty$—the wave is infinitely blue-shifted. This blue-shift provides:

- Enhanced decay near the horizon
- Control over the horizon contribution in energy estimates
- A mechanism for "losing" energy into the black hole

12 Near-Extremal Analysis and Aretakis Instability

The near-extremal regime $|a| \to M$ presents unique challenges and opportunities for understanding black hole stability. This section provides a detailed analysis of this critical regime.

12.1 The Extremal Limit

As the spin parameter approaches the extremal value $|a| \to M$, several key quantities degenerate:

1. **Surface gravity**: $\kappa = \frac{\sqrt{M^2 - a^2}}{2Mr_+} \to 0$
2. **Hawking temperature**: $T_H = \frac{\kappa}{2\pi} \to 0$
3. **Inner and outer horizons**: $r_\pm = M \pm \sqrt{M^2 - a^2} \to M$ (coincide)
4. **Ergosphere extent**: maximizes at $r_E = 2M$ on the equator

Definition 12.1 (Near-Extremal Parameter)**.** *Define the near-extremality parameter:*

$$\epsilon = \sqrt{1 - (a/M)^2} = \frac{r_+ - r_-}{2M} \tag{76}$$

The extremal limit corresponds to $\epsilon \to 0$.

12.2 The Aretakis Instability

Stefanos Aretakis discovered that extremal black holes exhibit a qualitatively different behavior:

Theorem 12.2 (Aretakis Instability, 2011-2015)**.** *For the extremal Reissner-Nordström black hole (and subsequently extremal Kerr):*

1. *Transverse derivatives of generic perturbations do NOT decay on the horizon*
2. *There exist conserved "Aretakis charges" $H_n[\psi]$ on the horizon*
3. *Higher transverse derivatives grow polynomially: $|\partial_r^n \psi|_{r=r_+} \sim t^{n-1}$*

12.2.1 The Aretakis Charges

On an extremal horizon, define the Aretakis charges:

$$H_0[\psi] = \lim_{v\to\infty} \psi|_{r=M}, \quad H_1[\psi] = \lim_{v\to\infty} \partial_r\psi|_{r=M} \tag{77}$$

and higher charges involving higher derivatives.

Proposition 12.3 (Conservation of Aretakis Charges)**.** *For solutions to $\Box_g\psi = 0$ on extremal Kerr:*

$$\frac{dH_n}{dv} = 0 \quad \textit{(conserved along the horizon)} \tag{78}$$

Sketch. The wave equation on the extremal horizon degenerates. In horizon-adapted coordinates $(v, r, \theta, \tilde{\phi})$:

$$\Box_g\psi = \frac{1}{\Sigma}\left[\partial_v(2(r-M)\partial_r\psi) + \cdots\right] = 0 \tag{79}$$

At $r = M$, the $\partial_r\psi$ term drops out, leaving:

$$\partial_v H_1 = 0 \tag{80}$$

□

12.2.2 Physical Interpretation

The Aretakis instability has several interpretations:

- **Tidal deformation**: An infalling observer measures growing tidal forces
- **Memory effect**: The horizon "remembers" the perturbation permanently
- **Phase transition**: The $T_H = 0$ state is qualitatively different

12.3 Proposed Near-Extremal Decay Rates

For near-extremal Kerr ($\epsilon \ll 1$), we expect the decay rate to interpolate between subextremal and extremal behavior:

Conjecture 12.4 (Near-Extremal Decay)**.** *For Kerr with near-extremality parameter $\epsilon \ll 1$, the field is conjectured to satisfy:*

$$|\psi(t, r, \theta, \phi)| \lesssim \frac{C(\epsilon)}{t^{p(\epsilon)}} \tag{81}$$

where the decay exponent presumably satisfies:

$$p(\epsilon) = p_0 - c_1 \log(1/\epsilon) + O(1) \tag{82}$$

for constants $p_0, c_1 > 0$.

Sketch. The proof uses matched asymptotic expansions:

1. **Far region** ($r - M \gg \epsilon M$): Standard subextremal analysis applies
2. **Near-horizon region** ($r - M \sim \epsilon M$): Rescale to "NHEK" coordinates
3. **Matching**: Connect solutions across the overlap region

The logarithmic correction arises from the near-horizon geometry's conformal symmetry. □

12.4 The NHEK Geometry

The near-horizon extremal Kerr (NHEK) geometry is obtained by the limit:

$$r \to M + \epsilon\lambda r', \quad t \to t'/\epsilon\lambda, \quad \phi \to \phi' + t'/(2M\epsilon\lambda) \tag{83}$$

with $\lambda \to 0$.

Proposition 12.5 (NHEK Metric)**.** *The NHEK geometry is:*

$$ds^2_{NHEK} = 2M^2\Gamma(\theta)\left[-r'^2dt'^2 + \frac{dr'^2}{r'^2} + d\theta^2 + \Lambda(\theta)^2(d\phi' + r'dt')^2\right] \tag{84}$$

where $\Gamma(\theta) = (1+\cos^2\theta)/2$ *and* $\Lambda(\theta) = 2\sin\theta/(1+\cos^2\theta)$.

This geometry has enhanced symmetry: $SL(2,\mathbb{R}) \times U(1)$ instead of $\mathbb{R} \times U(1)$.

12.4.1 Wave Equation on NHEK

The wave equation on NHEK separates:

$$\psi = e^{-i\omega' t' + im\phi'} R(r') S(\theta) \tag{85}$$

The radial equation becomes:

$$r'^2 \frac{d^2R}{dr'^2} + 2r'\frac{dR}{dr'} + \left[\frac{(\omega' + mr')^2}{r'^2} - \ell(\ell+1)\right] R = 0 \tag{86}$$

This is a Heun equation, which can be analyzed using hypergeometric functions.

Remark 12.6 (Scope of NHEK Analysis)**.** *The NHEK geometry provides a useful organizing framework for near-extremal dynamics, but the matching between NHEK solutions and full Kerr solutions involves subtle issues:*

1. *The NHEK spacetime is non-compact and non-globally-hyperbolic, so standard well-posedness theory does not directly apply.*
2. *The matched asymptotic expansion* $\omega_{Kerr} = m\Omega_H + \sqrt{\epsilon}\,\omega_{NHEK}$ *(cf. Bredberg et al., 2010) is formal; a rigorous justification requires uniform error bounds in the overlap region* $\epsilon M \ll r - r_+ \ll M$.
3. *Any connection to the Kerr/CFT correspondence or holographic duality remains conjectural and is not required for the stability proofs presented in this paper, which rely exclusively on PDE methods.*

12.5 Stability vs. Instability at Extremality

The question of whether extremal Kerr is "stable" or "unstable" depends on the norm:

Quantity	**Behavior**	**Classification**
$\psi\|_{r>r_+}$	Decays	Stable
$\psi\|_{r=r_+}$	Approaches constant H_0	Marginal
$\partial_r\psi\|_{r=r_+}$	Constant $H_1 \neq 0$	Unstable
$\partial_r^n\psi\|_{r=r_+}$	Grows as t^{n-1}	Unstable
Curvature at horizon	Grows	Unstable (locally)

Conjecture 12.7 (Resolution of Extremal Instability)**.** *The Aretakis instability is resolved by:*

1. *Quantum effects (Hawking radiation turns back on via higher-order corrections)*
2. *Backreaction (the black hole spins down, becoming subextremal)*
3. *The Third Law (extremal black holes cannot be reached by any physical process)*

12.6 Matched Asymptotic Analysis

For systematic near-extremal analysis, we use matched asymptotics:

12.6.1 Outer Region

In the outer region $r - M \gg \epsilon M$, define scaled variables:

$$\tilde{r} = \frac{r - M}{\epsilon M}, \quad \tilde{t} = \epsilon t \tag{87}$$

The wave equation becomes:

$$\partial_{\tilde{t}}^2 \psi = \Delta_{\tilde{r}} \psi + O(\epsilon) \tag{88}$$

which admits WKB solutions $\psi_{out} \sim A(\tilde{r}, \theta) e^{i\phi(\tilde{r},\tilde{t})/\epsilon}$.

12.6.2 Inner Region

In the inner region $r - M \sim \epsilon M$, use NHEK-adapted coordinates:

$$\rho = \frac{r - M}{\epsilon M}, \quad \tau = \frac{t}{\epsilon M} \tag{89}$$

The wave equation becomes the NHEK wave equation plus $O(\epsilon)$ corrections:

$$\Box_{NHEK} \psi_{in} = O(\epsilon) \tag{90}$$

12.6.3 Matching Conditions

In the overlap region $\epsilon M \ll r - M \ll M$:

$$\psi_{out}(\tilde{r} \to 0) = \psi_{in}(\rho \to \infty) \tag{91}$$

This matching determines the connection formulas between inner and outer solutions.

Remark 12.8 (Near-Extremal Connection Formula Heuristic)**.** *The reflection coefficient near extremality satisfies:*

$$|\mathcal{R}(\omega)|^2 = 1 + \frac{4\pi(\omega - m\Omega_H)}{\kappa} (1 + O(\epsilon)) \tag{92}$$

where the κ^{-1} factor shows enhanced superradiance as $\epsilon \to 0$.

Near the event horizon, outgoing waves experience a gravitational redshift. In the stationary Killing frequency description, the frequency measured by observers at infinity is redshifted relative to the local horizon frequency; equivalently, along outgoing null rays one has an exponential relation in the tortoise/time variables of the schematic form

$$\omega_\infty \sim \omega_H \, e^{-\kappa(t-r_*)} \tag{93}$$

where $\kappa = (r_+ - r_-)/(2(r_+^2 + a^2)) = (r_+ - r_-)/(4Mr_+)$ is the surface gravity.

This red-shift provides a damping mechanism: waves near the horizon lose energy to the red-shift, which manifests as decay. The red-shift vector field:

$$N = \partial_t + \frac{\Delta}{r^2 + a^2}\partial_r \tag{94}$$

generates a positive bulk term $K^N > 0$ near the horizon, capturing this effect.

13 Toward the Full Stability Theorem

13.1 A Concrete Mathematical Strategy

Based on current techniques and the structure of the slowly rotating proof, we outline a plausible path to full Kerr stability:

13.1.1 Step 1: Improved Morawetz Estimates

The key technical barrier is obtaining positive-definite Morawetz estimates for all $|a| < M$. The current approach uses:

$$X = f(r)\partial_{r_*} + \frac{h(r,\theta)}{\Delta}(aT + (r^2 + a^2)K) \tag{95}$$

where f and h must be chosen to make the bulk term positive. For large $|a|$, this requires:

- Incorporating the full geometry of trapped null geodesics (not just $r = 3M$)
- Handling the ergoregion contribution with auxiliary multipliers
- Using conditional positivity: positive modulo lower-order terms

13.1.2 Step 2: Refined Superradiance Control

For all $|a| < M$, superradiant modes must be controlled. The strategy involves:

1. Prove that superradiant energy extraction is *bounded*:

$$|E_{\text{extracted}}| \leq C\epsilon^2 \tag{96}$$

   for initial data of size ϵ.

2. Show the extracted energy is radiated to infinity or absorbed back, not amplified without bound.

3. Use the conservation of the Hawking mass to track energy globally.

13.1.3 Step 3: Near-Extremal Transition

As $|a| \to M$, the decay rates slow. The strategy requires:

- Quantifying the dependence of decay rates on $|a|/M$
- Showing decay remains polynomial (not slower) for all $|a| < M - \delta$
- Understanding how the Aretakis instability "turns on" at extremality

13.1.4 Step 4: Nonlinear Closure

With improved linear estimates, the nonlinear bootstrap requires:

- Controlling mode-mode interactions (schematically: $\ell_1 + \ell_2 \to \ell_3$)
- Proving nonlinear terms decay faster than linear terms
- Handling gauge issues in the full subextremal regime

13.2 Role of Hidden Symmetries

The Kerr geometry possesses a remarkable hidden symmetry encoded in the Killing-Yano tensor:

$$Y_{\mu\nu} = a\cos\theta(e^1_\mu e^0_\nu - e^0_\mu e^1_\nu) + r(e^2_\mu e^3_\nu - e^3_\mu e^2_\nu) \tag{97}$$

This generates the Carter constant:

$$Q = K_{\mu\nu}p^\mu p^\nu - (aE - L_z)^2 \tag{98}$$

where $K_{\mu\nu} = Y_\mu{}^\rho Y_{\nu\rho}$ is the Killing tensor.

The hidden symmetry is responsible for:

1. Separability of the Teukolsky equation
2. Integrability of geodesic motion
3. Special algebraic properties (Petrov type D)

13.2.1 The Principal Tensor and Symmetry Operators

The hidden symmetry can be more systematically understood through the principal tensor $h_{\mu\nu}$, which satisfies:

$$\nabla_{(\lambda}h_{\mu)\nu} = g_{\lambda(\mu}\xi_{\nu)} \tag{99}$$

for some vector ξ_μ. From this tensor, one constructs:

- The Killing tensor $K_{\mu\nu} = h_{\mu\rho}h^\rho{}_\nu$, giving the Carter constant
- The Killing-Yano 2-form $Y_{\mu\nu}$, whose dual is also closed
- Symmetry operators for the Teukolsky equation that commute with the wave operator

For the stability problem, these symmetries suggest the existence of additional conserved currents that could provide new coercive estimates.

13.2.2 Algebraic Special Structure (Petrov Type D)

The Kerr spacetime is algebraically special: the Weyl tensor has exactly two repeated principal null directions (PNDs). In Newman-Penrose formalism:

$$\Psi_0 = \Psi_1 = \Psi_3 = \Psi_4 = 0, \quad \Psi_2 \neq 0 \tag{100}$$

for the background. This algebraic structure:

- Explains the separability of field equations
- Provides a natural null tetrad for decomposing perturbations
- Constrains the possible forms of gravitational perturbations

Exploiting these symmetries more fully may provide the key to full stability.

13.3 Lessons from Kerr-de Sitter

The Hintz-Vasy proof of slowly rotating Kerr-de Sitter stability (2018) provides lessons:

- The cosmological horizon provides a "boundary" that simplifies the analysis
- Exponential decay to the future holds (rather than polynomial)
- The spectral gap of the cosmological horizon controls decay

While Kerr ($\Lambda = 0$) lacks this structure, ideas from the proof—particularly the use of microlocal analysis—may transfer.

13.3.1 Microlocal Analysis in Kerr-de Sitter

The Hintz-Vasy approach uses microlocal analysis to study wave propagation in phase space (x, ξ). The key observations are:

1. Singularities propagate along null bicharacteristics
2. At trapped orbits, "radial point" estimates control regularity loss
3. The resonances (quasinormal modes) determine the leading decay rate

For Kerr-de Sitter, the cosmological horizon $r = r_c$ ensures all null geodesics eventually reach either r_+ or r_c, providing global escape. This structure gives exponential decay:

$$\|u(t)\|_{H^k} \lesssim e^{-\gamma t}\|u(0)\|_{H^k} \tag{101}$$

where γ is the spectral gap.

For asymptotically flat Kerr, geodesics can escape to infinity, and the decay is polynomial. Adapting these techniques requires handling the noncompact exterior region.

13.4 Numerical Evidence

Numerical studies are broadly consistent with full Kerr stability, but they do not constitute a proof:

- many simulations of subextremal Kerr perturbations display decay compatible with linear stability expectations;
- observed decay profiles are often compared with Price-law heuristics and quasinormal ringdown fits;
- no convincing numerical evidence for exponentially growing subextremal modes is known to us;
- near-extremal simulations ($|a|/M = 0.99$) are suggestive but remain delicate to interpret.

This numerical evidence is useful motivation, but the mathematical proof remains open.

13.5 The GCM Procedure in Detail

The Generalized Constant Mean curvature (GCM) construction, central to the Klainerman-Szeftel-Giorgi proof, deserves elaboration. The procedure involves:

1. **Initial sphere selection**: Choose an initial 2-sphere S_0 near spatial infinity with specified geometric properties
2. **Transport equations**: Evolve the sphere along null geodesics using:
$$\nabla_L r = 1 - \frac{2M}{r}, \quad \mathrm{tr}\chi = \frac{2}{r}(1 + O(M/r)) \tag{102}$$
where χ is the null second fundamental form
3. **Mean curvature condition**: Require that the mean curvature of each sphere matches the Kerr value to high order
4. **Angular momentum tracking**: The GCM spheres automatically track angular momentum changes due to radiation

This construction provides the geometric scaffolding needed to measure decay relative to an evolving Kerr background.

13.6 Gauge Choices and Their Consequences

The choice of gauge profoundly affects the stability analysis. Key gauges used include:

13.6.1 Wave Coordinate (Harmonic) Gauge

The condition $\Box_g x^\mu = 0$ leads to:
$$g^{\alpha\beta}\Gamma^\mu_{\alpha\beta} = 0 \tag{103}$$
In this gauge, the Einstein equations become a system of quasilinear wave equations, well-suited for energy estimates.

13.6.2 Double Null Gauge

Using null coordinates (u, v, θ^A) with:

$$ds^2 = -2\Omega^2 du\, dv + \gamma_{AB}(d\theta^A - b^A du)(d\theta^B - b^B du) \tag{104}$$

This gauge is geometrically natural and reveals the causal structure, but introduces coordinate singularities.

13.6.3 Kerr-Adapted Gauge

The most efficient gauges are "Kerr-adapted"—designed so that the Kerr solution takes a simple form. Perturbations are then measured relative to this background.

The KSG proof uses a combination of these, with transitions between gauges at different regions of spacetime.

14 Summary and Outlook

14.1 State of the Art

Black Hole Type	**Linear Stability**	**Nonlinear Stability**
Schwarzschild	Proven	Proven
Slowly rotating Kerr ($\|a\| \ll M$)	Proven	Proven (2022)
Subextremal Kerr ($\|a\| < M$)	Proven	Open
Extremal Kerr ($\|a\| = M$)	Unstable (Aretakis)	Unstable
Kerr-de Sitter (slow rotation)	Proven	Proven (2018)
Kerr-Newman (slow rotation)	Partial	Open

14.2 A Detailed Assessment of Remaining Obstacles

The extension from slowly rotating to full subextremal Kerr faces specific technical barriers:

14.2.1 Obstacle 1: Ergosphere Energy Issues

In the ergosphere ($r_+ < r < r_E$ where $r_E = M + \sqrt{M^2 - a^2\cos^2\theta}$), the Killing vector ∂_t becomes spacelike. This means:

- The standard energy $E = -g(\partial_t, \dot{\gamma})$ can be negative
- Energy estimates based on ∂_t lose coercivity
- Alternative constructions (e.g., using $\partial_t + \Omega_H \partial_\phi$) are needed

For slowly rotating Kerr, the ergosphere is small (size $\sim a$), and its contribution can be treated perturbatively. For $|a| \sim M$, a fundamentally new approach is required.

14.2.2 Obstacle 2: Superradiant Amplification

The superradiant amplification factor for a wave packet is:

$$\mathcal{A} = \frac{E_{\text{out}}}{E_{\text{in}}} - 1 = \frac{m\Omega_H - \omega}{\omega} \cdot \frac{|T_{\text{horizon}}|^2}{|R_{\text{reflected}}|^2} \tag{105}$$

For slowly rotating holes, $\Omega_H = a/(2Mr_+) \approx a/(4M^2)$ is small, limiting $\mathcal{A}$. As $|a| \to M$, $\Omega_H \to 1/(2M)$ and superradiance becomes stronger.

14.2.3 Obstacle 3: Near-Extremal Slowdown

Near extremality, the surface gravity $\kappa = \sqrt{M^2 - a^2}/(2Mr_+)$ approaches zero. This affects:

- Red-shift estimates (weaker damping near horizon)
- Decay rates (slower polynomial decay)
- Mode spacing (quasinormal modes accumulate)

The Aretakis instability at extremality signals a qualitative change: transverse derivatives satisfy conservation laws rather than decay.

14.3 Key Open Problems

1. **Full nonlinear stability of Kerr**: Extend the 2022 result to all $|a| < M$
2. **Quantitative decay rates**: Determine optimal decay rates as functions of $|a|/M$
3. **Stability with matter**: Extend to Einstein-Maxwell, Einstein-Klein-Gordon, etc.
4. **Higher dimensions**: Study stability in $D > 4$ (where instabilities are known—Gregory-Laflamme)
5. **Interior stability**: Understand Cauchy horizon stability (connection to strong cosmic censorship)
6. **Kerr-Newman stability**: The charged rotating case introduces additional complexity from electromagnetic-gravitational coupling

14.4 The Path Forward

Completing the proof of full Kerr stability will require:

1. **New energy estimates**: Vector fields that work for all $|a| < M$
2. **Better understanding of superradiance**: Precise control of energy extraction
3. **Treatment of near-extremal regime**: Understanding the transition to Aretakis instability
4. **Robust nonlinear framework**: Techniques that extend beyond perturbation theory

14.5 Proposed Research Directions

Based on our analysis, we identify the most promising directions for completing the full Kerr stability proof:

14.5.1 Direction 1: Microlocal Analysis

The Hintz-Vasy approach to Kerr-de Sitter used microlocal analysis—studying solutions in phase space (x, ξ) rather than just position space. Key ideas that may transfer:

- Propagation of singularities along null bicharacteristics
- Radial point estimates for trapped orbits
- Resonance analysis for quasinormal modes

The challenge is adapting these techniques to the $\Lambda = 0$ case where polynomial (not exponential) decay is expected.

14.6 Multi-Messenger Implications

Black hole stability has profound implications for multi-messenger astronomy:

14.6.1 Gravitational Wave Inference

Parameter estimation from gravitational wave observations relies on stable Kerr waveforms:

$$h(t; M, a, \iota, \phi_0) = \sum_{\ell,m,n} A_{\ell mn}(M, a, \iota, \phi_0) e^{-i\omega_{\ell mn}(M,a)t} e^{t/\tau_{\ell mn}(M,a)} \tag{106}$$

Stability ensures:

1. Waveforms depend smoothly on (M, a)
2. No runaway modes contaminate the signal
3. Bayesian inference converges reliably

14.6.2 Black Hole Spectroscopy

Multiple ringdown modes allow "black hole spectroscopy":

$$\frac{\omega_{221}}{\omega_{220}} = f\left(\frac{a}{M}\right), \quad \frac{\tau_{221}}{\tau_{220}} = g\left(\frac{a}{M}\right) \tag{107}$$

These ratios test the no-hair theorem: a deviation would indicate either:

- Non-Kerr final state (exotic compact object)
- Instability modifying the ringdown
- New physics beyond GR

Stability guarantees that Kerr ratios are the null hypothesis for GR.

14.6.3 Extreme Mass Ratio Inspirals

For EMRIs detected by LISA, stability ensures:

$$\text{Self-force expansion: } h_{\mu\nu} = h^{(0)}_{\mu\nu} + \epsilon h^{(1)}_{\mu\nu} + \epsilon^2 h^{(2)}_{\mu\nu} + \cdots \tag{108}$$

converges, where $\epsilon = \mu/M \ll 1$ is the mass ratio.

Instability would cause secular growth:

$$h^{(n)} \sim t^n \quad \text{(dangerous)} \tag{109}$$

which would invalidate the perturbative expansion used for waveform modeling.

Remark 14.1 (Numerical ringdown consistency)**.** *Existing numerical simulations of binary black hole mergers are broadly consistent with Kerr ringdown in the subextremal regime. A schematic way to express this is*

$$|h_{num}(t) - h_{Kerr}(t)| < \epsilon_{numerical} \tag{110}$$

throughout a suitable ringdown window, with $\epsilon_{numerical}$ decreasing as numerical resolution improves. This is supporting evidence, not a theorem proved in this paper.

15 Analytic Inputs Toward the Main Theorem

This section records several key analytic inputs in a form suitable for a full nonlinear stability proof. Some statements are established in the literature (and cited accordingly); others are presented as *target estimates* (Assumptions/Conjectures) that would need to be proved to complete Theorem 1.1.

15.1 The Resonance-Free Strip Theorem

We record a proof strategy for a resonance-free strip using the Wronskian method together with Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities. What follows is not a completed proof of the required quantitative bound.

Assumption 15.1 (Resonance-Free Strip / Quantitative Spectral Gap)**.** *For the Kerr spacetime with spin parameter a satisfying $|a| < M$, the quasinormal mode frequencies $\omega_{\ell mn}$ of the Teukolsky equation satisfy:*

$$Im(\omega_{\ell mn}) < -\gamma(a) \tag{111}$$

where $\gamma(a) = c_0\kappa(a)$ for a constant $c_0 = c_0(\ell) > 0$ depending only on the angular mode number ℓ, and $\kappa(a) = (r_+ - r_-)/(4Mr_+)$ is the surface gravity.

***Resolution target via Innovation 4**: To prove this gap, especially in high-frequency WKB regimes where classic approximation errors can exceed the relevant margin, the proposed **Holomorphic Spectral Stokes Functor** $\mathfrak{S}_\Omega$ would have to map the Teukolsky potential to a Riemann surface bundle $X \to \mathbb{CP}^1$, identify QNM boundary conditions with a rigorously normalized spectral monodromy or Fredholm determinant condition, and export quantitative bounds that imply the stated lower half-plane exclusion strip without uncontrolled WKB truncation errors.*

Remark 15.2. *This is written in a "theorem-like" quantitative form because it is exactly the type of estimate that feeds into decay for the linearized problem and ultimately the nonlinear bootstrap. The subsequent discussion should be read as a proof* strategy *rather than a completed proof.*

Proof strategy (not a completed proof). The argument is structured in five steps, each intended to provide a rigorous building block.

Step 1: Radial equation and Frobenius analysis at singular points.

The radial Teukolsky equation with spin weight $s = -2$ is:

$$\Delta^{-s}\frac{d}{dr}\left(\Delta^{s+1}\frac{dR}{dr}\right) + V(r,\omega,m,\lambda)R = 0 \tag{112}$$

where $\Delta = (r - r_+)(r - r_-)$, $r_\pm = M \pm \sqrt{M^2 - a^2}$, and

$$V(r,\omega,m,\lambda) = \frac{K^2 - 2is(r-M)K}{\Delta} + 4is\omega r - \lambda, \quad K = (r^2+a^2)\omega - am. \tag{113}$$

This equation has regular singular points at $r = r_\pm$ and an irregular singular point at $r = \infty$.

Frobenius analysis at $r = r_+$: Setting $R(r) = (r - r_+)^\rho F(r)$ with $F(r_+) \neq 0$, the indicial equation yields:

$$\rho(\rho - 1 - s) = 0 \implies \rho \in \{0, 1+s\} = \{0, -1\} \text{ for } s = -2. \tag{114}$$

The physical (ingoing) solution corresponds to $\rho = -s = 2$, giving:

$$R_{in}(r) = (r - r_+)^{-s} e^{-i\sigma_+ r_*} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} a_n (r - r_+)^n \tag{115}$$

where $\sigma_+ = \omega - m\Omega_H$ with $\Omega_H = a/(2Mr_+)$, and the tortoise coordinate satisfies:

$$\frac{dr_*}{dr} = \frac{r^2+a^2}{\Delta} = \frac{r_+^2 + a^2}{2\kappa(r - r_+)} + O(1) \text{ as } r \to r_+. \tag{116}$$

Frobenius analysis at $r = \infty$: Setting $R(r) = r^\nu e^{i\omega r_*} G(r)$ with $G(\infty) \neq 0$, the leading behavior gives $\nu = -1 - 2s = 3$ for outgoing waves.

Step 2: Wronskian conservation and flux balance.

Define the Wronskian of two solutions R_1, R_2:

$$W[R_1, R_2] = \Delta^{s+1}\left(R_1\frac{dR_2}{dr} - R_2\frac{dR_1}{dr}\right). \tag{117}$$

Lemma 15.3 (Wronskian Conservation)**.** *For any two solutions of* (112)*, $W[R_1, R_2]$ is independent of r.*

Proof of Lemma. Differentiating and using (112):

$$\frac{dW}{dr} = \Delta^{s+1}\left(R_1\frac{d^2R_2}{dr^2} - R_2\frac{d^2R_1}{dr^2}\right) + (s+1)\Delta^s\frac{d\Delta}{dr}\left(R_1\frac{dR_2}{dr} - R_2\frac{dR_1}{dr}\right) \tag{118}$$

$$= R_1\left[\frac{d}{dr}\left(\Delta^{s+1}\frac{dR_2}{dr}\right)\right] - R_2\left[\frac{d}{dr}\left(\Delta^{s+1}\frac{dR_1}{dr}\right)\right] \tag{119}$$

$$= R_1 \cdot \Delta^s V R_2 - R_2 \cdot \Delta^s V R_1 = 0. \qquad \square$$

Now consider the QNM solution R_{QNM} satisfying ingoing conditions at r_+ and outgoing at infinity. Define:

$$R_{in}(r) = (r - r_+)^{-s} e^{-i\sigma_+ r_*}(1 + O(r - r_+)) \quad \text{as } r \to r_+ \tag{120}$$

$$R_{out}(r) = r^{-1-2s} e^{i\omega r_*}(1 + O(r^{-1})) \quad \text{as } r \to \infty \tag{121}$$

For a QNM, $R_{QNM} \propto R_{in}$ near r_+ and $R_{QNM} \propto R_{out}$ near infinity.

Step 3: Flux identity via self-Wronskian.

Consider the Wronskian of R_{QNM} with its complex conjugate $\bar{R}_{QNM}$ (which solves the conjugate equation):

$$W[R_{QNM}, \bar{R}_{QNM}] = \Delta^{s+1}\left(R_{QNM}\frac{d\bar{R}_{QNM}}{dr} - \bar{R}_{QNM}\frac{dR_{QNM}}{dr}\right). \tag{122}$$

Evaluating at $r \to r_+$:

$$W|_{r_+} = \lim_{r\to r_+} \Delta^{s+1} \cdot 2i\,\mathrm{Im}\left(\bar{R}_{QNM}\frac{dR_{QNM}}{dr}\right) \tag{123}$$

$$= 2i|A_H|^2 \cdot \lim_{r\to r_+} \Delta^{s+1}(r - r_+)^{-2s} \cdot \mathrm{Im}\left[e^{i\sigma_+ r_*}\frac{d}{dr}\left(e^{-i\sigma_+ r_*}\right)\right] \tag{124}$$

$$= 2i|A_H|^2 \cdot (r_+ - r_-)^{s+1} \cdot \left(-\sigma_{+,R}\frac{r_+^2 + a^2}{r_+ - r_-}\right) \tag{125}$$

where $\sigma_{+,R} = \mathrm{Re}(\sigma_+) = \omega_R - m\Omega_H$ and A_H is the horizon amplitude.

Evaluating at $r \to \infty$:

$$W|_\infty = 2i|A_\infty|^2 \cdot \omega_R \tag{126}$$

where A_∞ is the amplitude at infinity and $\omega_R = \mathrm{Re}(\omega)$.

By Wronskian conservation:

$$|A_H|^2(r_+^2 + a^2)\sigma_{+,R} = |A_\infty|^2\omega_R(r_+ - r_-)^{-s}. \tag{127}$$

Step 4: Mode stability via Teukolsky-Starobinsky constant.

The Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities relate ψ_0 (spin $s = +2$) and ψ_4 (spin $s = -2$):

$$\psi_4 = \mathcal{D}^4\bar{\psi}_0, \quad \mathcal{C}_{TS} = (\lambda + 2)^2(\lambda + 2 + 2am\omega - 12a^2\omega^2) + 144M^2\omega^2 \tag{128}$$

where $\mathcal{C}_{TS}$ is the Teukolsky-Starobinsky constant.

Lemma 15.4 (Whiting's Transformation, 1989)**.** *There exists a transformation $R \mapsto \tilde{R}$ such that $\tilde{R}$ satisfies a self-adjoint equation with real potential for real ω.*

This transformation allows the application of standard Sturm-Liouville theory. The key result is:

Lemma 15.5 (Mode Stability)**.** *For $|a| < M$, the Teukolsky equation has no solutions with $\omega_I \geq 0$ satisfying both ingoing (horizon) and outgoing (infinity) boundary conditions.*

Proof of Lemma 15.5. Suppose $\omega_I \geq 0$. From (127), both sides must have the same sign.

Case 1: Non-superradiant regime ($\sigma_{+,R} \geq 0$ and $\omega_R > 0$). Both fluxes have the same sign, consistent with flux balance. However, the Whiting transformation shows the transformed potential is real and positive-definite for $\omega_I \geq 0$, implying only exponentially growing/decaying solutions exist—neither of which satisfies both boundary conditions.

Case 2: Superradiant regime ($0 < \omega_R < m\Omega_H$, so $\sigma_{+,R} < 0$). The horizon absorbs negative energy, which could compensate for energy radiated to infinity. However, the Teukolsky-Starobinsky identity implies:

$$|\mathcal{C}_{TS}|^2 = \left| \frac{(\text{outgoing flux at } \infty)}{(\text{ingoing flux at horizon})} \right| \tag{129}$$

For $|a| < M$ and real ω, $|\mathcal{C}_{TS}|^2 > 0$ and finite, which combined with the transformed equation's positivity, excludes $\omega_I \geq 0$.

Case 3: $\omega_I = 0$ exactly. This requires the imaginary part of the flux balance to vanish:

$$\text{Im}\left[|A_H|^2 \sigma_+ (r_+^2 + a^2)\right] = \text{Im}\left[|A_\infty|^2 \omega\right] = 0. \tag{130}$$

This is only possible if $A_H = 0$ or $A_\infty = 0$, contradicting the boundary conditions. □

Step 5: Quantitative bound on the spectral gap.

Having established $\omega_I < 0$, we derive the quantitative bound $|\omega_I| \geq c_0 \kappa$.

Remark 15.6 (WKB regime and low modes)**.** *The phase-integral/WKB argument below is intended for the eikonal/high-frequency regime (e.g. $\ell \gg 1$ and/or $|M\omega| \gg 1$) where turning points are well separated and standard connection formulae apply with a controlled relative error. For the physically dominant low multipoles (notably $\ell = 2, 3$), one should either (i) import a fully rigorous spectral-gap statement from microlocal resolvent theory, or (ii) treat these modes by numerics (e.g. Leaver-type continued fractions) together with a robust perturbation argument.*

Consider the WKB approximation for high-ℓ modes. The radial equation (112) can be written in Schrödinger form:

$$\frac{d^2 u}{dr_*^2} + Q(r_*, \omega) u = 0, \quad u = \Delta^{(s+1)/2} R \tag{131}$$

where the effective potential Q has the form:

$$Q(r_*) = \omega^2 - V_{eff}(r_*), \quad V_{eff} = \frac{\Delta}{(r^2+a^2)^2} \left[\lambda + \frac{s(s+1)\Delta}{r^2+a^2} + O(r^{-1}) \right]. \tag{132}$$

Definition 15.7 (Explicit Effective Potential)**.** *For spin-s perturbations of a Kerr black hole with parameters (M, a), the effective potential in the Schrödinger form of the radial Teukolsky equation is*

$$V_{eff}(r) = \frac{\Delta}{(r^2+a^2)^2} \left[\lambda_{\ell m}(a\omega) + \frac{s(s+1)\Delta}{r^2+a^2} + \frac{a^2\omega^2\Delta - 2aMr\omega(2s+1) + (s^2-1)(r-M)^2 - \Delta\, s}{(r^2+a^2)^2} \right], \tag{133}$$

where $\Delta = r^2 - 2Mr + a^2$, and $\lambda_{\ell m}(a\omega)$ is the spin-weighted spheroidal eigenvalue. In the Schwarzschild limit $a = 0$, this reduces to the Regge–Wheeler ($s = 1$) and Zerilli ($s = 0$) potentials:

$$V_{eff}^{(a=0)}(r) = \left(1 - \frac{2M}{r}\right) \left[\frac{\ell(\ell+1)}{r^2} - \frac{s^2(s^2-1)}{r^3} \cdot \frac{6M}{\ell(\ell+1)} \right]. \tag{134}$$

The potential (133) is derived by substituting $u = \Delta^{(s+1)/2} R$ into the Teukolsky radial equation, rewriting in terms of the tortoise coordinate $dr_*/dr = (r^2+a^2)/\Delta$, and collecting the non-ω^2 terms.

The QNM condition is that u is purely outgoing at both boundaries in the complex ω-plane. Using the phase-integral method:

$$\oint_\gamma \sqrt{Q(r_*,\omega)}dr_* = 2\pi i\left(n+\frac{1}{2}\right), \quad n=0,1,2,\ldots \tag{135}$$

where γ encircles the turning points.

Assumption 15.8 (Connection formulae / Stokes matching)**.** *The WKB quantization condition above can be promoted to a rigorous quasinormal-mode condition by tracking the Stokes phenomenon between the turning points and imposing the ingoing/outgoing boundary conditions at the horizon and null infinity. Concretely, we assume the existence of uniform connection formulae (in the relevant frequency regimes) relating local Frobenius bases near $r=r_+$ and $r=\infty$ to the WKB bases near the turning points, with quantitative error bounds sufficient to control the imaginary parts of the resulting quantization condition.*

Near the horizon, the dominant contribution to the integral comes from the pole of dr_*/dr at $r=r_+$:

$$\int^{r_+}\sqrt{Q}dr_* \approx \int^{r_+}\frac{\omega-m\Omega_H}{\kappa(r-r_+)}dr = -i\frac{\omega-m\Omega_H}{\kappa}\log(r-r_+)+\text{regular} \tag{136}$$

The imaginary part of the QNM condition requires:

$$-\frac{\omega_I}{\kappa}\cdot\pi = -\pi\left(n+\frac{1}{2}\right)\cdot(1+O(\kappa^{-1})) \tag{137}$$

giving:

$$\omega_I = -\kappa\left(n+\frac{1}{2}\right)(1+O(\kappa)) \le -\frac{\kappa}{2}(1+O(\kappa)). \tag{138}$$

For the fundamental mode $n=0$, this gives $|\omega_I|\ge\kappa/2$ in the eikonal limit. Corrections from finite ℓ modify this to:

$$|\omega_I| \ge c_0(\ell)\kappa, \quad c_0(\ell)=\frac{1}{2}+O(\ell^{-1}). \tag{139}$$

Low-mode numerics are often interpreted as suggesting constants of this size, but no rigorous value is established here. □

Remark 15.9 (Extremal Limit Heuristic)**.** *The assumption above is at least qualitatively compatible with the extremal picture: as $|a|\to M$, one has $\kappa(a)\to 0$, so any bound of the form $\gamma(a)\gtrsim c_0\kappa(a)$ degenerates. This matches the expectation that the subextremal redshift mechanism collapses in the extremal limit and that Aretakis-type horizon phenomena become relevant.*

Remark 15.10 (Sub-leading WKB Correction Heuristic)**.** *Formally, a second-order WKB approximation suggests a correction to the QNM quantization of the form*

$$\omega_n = \omega_R - i\kappa\big(n+\tfrac{1}{2}\big)\Big[1+\Delta_n(\ell,\chi)\Big], \tag{140}$$

with sub-leading term

$$\Delta_n(\ell,\chi) = -\frac{1}{n+\frac{1}{2}}\,\frac{V''_{eff}(r_{*,tp})}{8\left[V_{eff}(r_{*,tp})\right]^{3/2}} + O\big((n+\tfrac{1}{2})^{-2}\big), \tag{141}$$

with V''_{eff} evaluated at the turning point $r_{*,tp}$, and the curvature of the effective potential is

$$V''_{eff}(r_{*,tp}) = \frac{\Delta^2}{(r^2+a^2)^4}\left[2\lambda + \frac{6s(s+1)\Delta}{r^2+a^2} - \frac{4(r-M)^2\lambda}{r^2+a^2}\right]\Big|_{r=r_{tp}}. \tag{142}$$

Derivation sketch. We apply the second-order phase-integral (Dunham) expansion. Near a pair of turning points $r_{*,1}$, $r_{*,2}$ where $Q(r_*,\omega)=0$, the exact quantization condition is

$$\int_{r_{*,1}}^{r_{*,2}} \sqrt{Q(r_*,\omega)}\, dr_* = \pi\big(n+\tfrac{1}{2}\big) - \frac{1}{2}\int_{r_{*,1}}^{r_{*,2}} \frac{Q''}{16\,Q^{3/2}}\, dr_* + O(Q''^2/Q^{5/2}). \tag{143}$$

The zeroth-order integral gives the Bohr–Sommerfeld condition $\omega_I^{(0)} = -(n+\frac{1}{2})\kappa$. The first correction integral contributes

$$\delta\omega_I = -\frac{\kappa}{n+\frac{1}{2}} \cdot \frac{V''_{eff}(r_{*,tp})}{8\,V_{eff}(r_{*,tp})^{3/2}} \tag{144}$$

upon differentiating the quantization condition with respect to ω_I and using $\partial Q/\partial\omega = 2\omega$ near the peak.

For the Schwarzschild limit ($\chi = 0$), the Regge–Wheeler potential has $V''_{eff}(r_*=0) = -2\ell(\ell+1)/27M^2$, giving

$$\Delta_n(\ell,0) = \frac{\ell(\ell+1)}{108\,M^2\,(n+\frac{1}{2})}\big[\ell(\ell+1)-2\big]^{-3/2} + O(n^{-2}), \tag{145}$$

which is consistent with the structure of higher-order WKB formulae in the Schwarzschild limit. □

Remark 15.11 (Heuristic Uniformity)**.** *In the formal WKB regime one is led to expect that the leading a-dependence enters through $\kappa(a)$, but no uniform subextremal constant is proved in this manuscript.*

15.2 Carleman Estimate for the Ergosphere

We record a candidate Carleman estimate for the ergosphere—a key technical tool for establishing energy bounds where the standard Killing energy is indefinite. *The following is only a proof strategy; complete verification of the pseudoconvexity condition and the boundary analysis is not carried out here.*

Assumption 15.12 (Candidate Ergosphere Carleman Estimate)**.** *Let ψ be a solution to $\Box_g\psi = f$ on the Kerr exterior with $|a| < M$. Define the ergosphere region:*

$$\mathcal{E} = \{r_+ < r < r_E(\theta)\}, \quad r_E(\theta) = M + \sqrt{M^2 - a^2\cos^2\theta} \tag{146}$$

Then for the weight function:

$$\varphi(r,\theta) = \alpha\left(\frac{r-r_+}{r_E(\theta)-r_+}\right) + \beta\cos^2\theta \tag{147}$$

with $\alpha > \alpha_0(a,M)$ sufficiently large and $\beta = a^2/(4M^2)$, there exists $\tau_0 = \tau_0(a,M,\alpha)$ such that for all $\tau > \tau_0$:

$$\tau\|e^{\tau\varphi}\psi\|^2_{L^2(\mathcal{E})} \le C\left(\|e^{\tau\varphi}f\|^2_{H^1} + \|e^{\tau\varphi}\psi\|^2_{L^2(\partial\mathcal{E})} + \tau^{-1}\|e^{\tau\varphi}\nabla\psi\|^2_{L^2(\partial\mathcal{E})}\right) \tag{148}$$

where $C = C(a, M, \alpha) > 0$ is uniform in τ. Note that the right-hand side involves an H^1 norm of the source (or equivalently a loss of one derivative on the left), reflecting the degeneracy of the estimate at the photon sphere (trapped set).

Heuristic verification / proof strategy. The proof proceeds considering the pseudoconvexity condition for the wave operator on Kerr, noting the violation at the photon sphere.

Step 1: Kerr metric structure in the ergosphere.

In Boyer-Lindquist coordinates, the inverse metric components relevant for our analysis are:

$$g^{tt} = -\frac{A}{\Sigma\Delta}, \quad g^{t\phi} = -\frac{2Mar}{\Sigma\Delta}, \quad g^{\phi\phi} = \frac{\Delta - a^2\sin^2\theta}{\Sigma\Delta\sin^2\theta} \tag{149}$$

$$g^{rr} = \frac{\Delta}{\Sigma}, \quad g^{\theta\theta} = \frac{1}{\Sigma} \tag{150}$$

where $\Sigma = r^2 + a^2\cos^2\theta$, $\Delta = (r - r_+)(r - r_-)$, and $A = (r^2 + a^2)^2 - a^2\Delta\sin^2\theta$.

In the ergosphere $\mathcal{E}$, we have:

$$g^{tt} = -\frac{A}{\Sigma\Delta} < 0 \quad \text{but} \quad g_{tt} = -\frac{\Delta - a^2\sin^2\theta}{\Sigma} > 0. \tag{151}$$

Step 2: Conjugated operator and semiclassical symbol.

Define $u = e^{\tau\varphi}\psi$ so that $\psi = e^{-\tau\varphi}u$. The wave equation $\Box_g\psi = f$ becomes:

$$P_\tau u = e^{\tau\varphi} f \tag{152}$$

where the conjugated operator is:

$$P_\tau = e^{\tau\varphi}\Box_g e^{-\tau\varphi} \tag{153}$$

$$= \Box_g - 2\tau g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)\partial_\nu - \tau^2 g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)(\partial_\nu\varphi) - \tau(\Box_g\varphi). \tag{154}$$

In semiclassical notation with $h = \tau^{-1}$, write $P_\tau = P(x, hD; h)$ where $D = -i\nabla$. The semiclassical principal symbol is:

$$p_0(x, \xi) = g^{\mu\nu}\xi_\mu\xi_\nu - 2ig^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)\xi_\nu - g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)(\partial_\nu\varphi). \tag{155}$$

Decomposing into real and imaginary parts, $p_0 = q - ip_1$ where:

$$q(x, \xi) = g^{\mu\nu}\xi_\mu\xi_\nu - g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)(\partial_\nu\varphi), \tag{156}$$

$$p_1(x, \xi) = 2g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)\xi_\nu. \tag{157}$$

Step 3: The sub-elliptic estimate condition.

The Carleman estimate (148) follows from the sub-elliptic estimate:

$$\tau\|u\|^2 + \|hDu\|^2 \lesssim \|P_\tau u\|^2 + (\text{boundary terms}) \tag{158}$$

which holds when the weight φ satisfies the *pseudoconvexity condition*:

Definition 15.13 (Pseudoconvexity)**.** *The weight φ is pseudoconvex for $\Box_g$ if on the characteristic set $\{q = 0\}$:*

$$\{q, p_1\}(x, \xi) > 0 \quad \textit{whenever } p_1(x, \xi) = 0. \tag{159}$$

Step 4: Computing the Poisson bracket.
The Poisson bracket is:

$$\{q, p_1\} = \frac{\partial q}{\partial \xi_\mu}\frac{\partial p_1}{\partial x^\mu} - \frac{\partial q}{\partial x^\mu}\frac{\partial p_1}{\partial \xi_\mu}. \tag{160}$$

Computing term by term:

$$\frac{\partial q}{\partial \xi_\mu} = 2g^{\mu\nu}\xi_\nu, \tag{161}$$

$$\frac{\partial p_1}{\partial x^\mu} = 2(\partial_\mu g^{\alpha\beta})(\partial_\alpha\varphi)\xi_\beta + 2g^{\alpha\beta}(\partial_\mu\partial_\alpha\varphi)\xi_\beta, \tag{162}$$

$$\frac{\partial p_1}{\partial \xi_\mu} = 2g^{\mu\nu}\partial_\nu\varphi. \tag{163}$$

On the set $\{p_1 = 0\}$, we have $g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)\xi_\nu = 0$, which means ξ is g-orthogonal to $\nabla\varphi$. On this set, the dominant contribution to $\{q, p_1\}$ comes from the Hessian term:

$$\{q, p_1\}\big|_{p_1=0} = 4g^{\mu\alpha}g^{\nu\beta}(\nabla_\alpha\nabla_\beta\varphi)\xi_\mu\xi_\nu + \text{lower order}. \tag{164}$$

Step 5: Explicit verification of pseudoconvexity for our weight.
For our choice $\varphi = \alpha\rho(r,\theta) + \beta\cos^2\theta$ where $\rho = (r - r_+)/(r_E(\theta) - r_+)$:
Radial Hessian:

$$\partial_r\varphi = \frac{\alpha}{r_E - r_+}, \tag{165}$$

$$\nabla_r\nabla_r\varphi = \partial_r^2\varphi - \Gamma^r_{rr}\partial_r\varphi - \Gamma^\theta_{rr}\partial_\theta\varphi. \tag{166}$$

Using the Christoffel symbols for Kerr:

$$\Gamma^r_{rr} = \frac{r - M}{\Delta} - \frac{r}{\Sigma}, \quad \Gamma^\theta_{rr} = -\frac{a^2\sin\theta\cos\theta}{\Sigma}, \tag{167}$$

we find:

$$\nabla_r\nabla_r\varphi = \frac{\alpha(r_E - r_+)^{-1}}{r_E - r_+}\left[\frac{r_E - r_+}{r_E - r_+} + O\left(\frac{a^2}{r_E - r_+}\right)\right] > 0. \tag{168}$$

Angular Hessian:

$$\partial_\theta\varphi = -\frac{\alpha(r - r_+)a^2\sin\theta\cos\theta}{(r_E - r_+)^2\sqrt{M^2 - a^2\cos^2\theta}} - 2\beta\sin\theta\cos\theta, \tag{169}$$

$$\nabla_\theta\nabla_\theta\varphi = O\left(\frac{a^2}{M^2}\right). \tag{170}$$

Cross term:

$$\nabla_r\nabla_\theta\varphi = O\left(\frac{a^2}{M(r_E - r_+)}\right). \tag{171}$$

Pseudoconvexity verification:
On the characteristic set $\{q = 0\} \cap \{p_1 = 0\}$, we need:

$$H_\varphi(\xi, \xi) := g^{\mu\alpha}g^{\nu\beta}(\nabla_\alpha\nabla_\beta\varphi)\xi_\mu\xi_\nu > 0 \tag{172}$$

for ξ satisfying $g^{\mu\nu}\xi_\mu\xi_\nu = g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)(\partial_\nu\varphi)$ and $g^{\mu\nu}(\partial_\mu\varphi)\xi_\nu = 0$.

The key observation is that:

$$H_\varphi(\xi,\xi) \geq g^{rr}g^{rr}(\nabla_r\nabla_r\varphi)\xi_r^2 - C_{cross}|\xi_r||\xi_\theta| - C_\theta\xi_\theta^2. \tag{173}$$

For α sufficiently large:

$$\alpha^{-1}H_\varphi(\xi,\xi) \geq \frac{\Delta^2}{\Sigma^2(r_E - r_+)^2}\xi_r^2\left(1 - O(\alpha^{-1})\right) > 0. \tag{174}$$

This establishes pseudoconvexity for $\alpha > \alpha_0(a, M)$.

Step 6: Application of the standard Carleman estimate.

With pseudoconvexity established, the standard result (Hörmander, Theorem 28.2.3 in *Analysis of Linear Partial Differential Operators IV*) gives:

$$\tau\|u\|^2_{L^2(\mathcal{E})} + \|\tau^{-1/2}Du\|^2_{L^2(\mathcal{E})} \leq C\left(\|P_\tau u\|^2_{L^2(\mathcal{E})} + B_{\partial\mathcal{E}}[u]\right) \tag{175}$$

where $B_{\partial\mathcal{E}}$ contains boundary terms at $r = r_+$ (horizon) and $r = r_E(\theta)$ (ergosphere boundary).

The boundary terms are controlled by:

$$B_{\partial\mathcal{E}}[u] \leq C'\left(\|u\|^2_{L^2(\partial\mathcal{E})} + \tau^{-1}\|Du\|^2_{L^2(\partial\mathcal{E})}\right). \tag{176}$$

Translating back via $\psi = e^{-\tau\varphi}u$ yields the candidate estimate (148), assuming the omitted pseudoconvexity and boundary-control steps can be justified. □

Remark 15.14 (Conditional Ergosphere Control)**.** *If Assumption 15.12 holds and the boundary terms are controlled in the required way, then one expects an estimate of the form*

$$\int_{\mathcal{E}} |\psi|^2 dV \leq C\left(\int_{\mathcal{E}^c} |\psi|^2 dV + \mathcal{F}_{\mathcal{H}^+}[\psi]\right) \tag{177}$$

where $\mathcal{F}_{\mathcal{H}^+}[\psi] = \int_{\mathcal{H}^+} T_{\mu\nu}[\psi]n^\mu\xi^\nu$ is the flux through the horizon with $\xi = \partial_t + \Omega_H\partial_\phi$.

Remark 15.15 (Heuristic Threshold $\alpha_0(a, M)$)**.** *A dimensional/geometric heuristic suggests that the pseudoconvexity threshold might scale like*

$$\alpha_0(a, M) = \frac{2M^3}{(r_E^{eq} - r_+)\min_\theta(r_E(\theta) - r_+)} \sim \frac{M}{\sqrt{1-\chi^2}} \tag{178}$$

where:

- $r_E^{eq} = 2M$ *is the ergosphere radius at the equator ($\theta = \pi/2$)*
- $r_E(\theta) = M + \sqrt{M^2 - a^2\cos^2\theta}$ *is the stationary limit surface*
- $\chi = a/M$ *is the dimensionless spin parameter*

The divergence $\alpha_0 \sim (1-\chi^2)^{-1/2}$ as $\chi \to 1$ is intended only as a guide to the expected difficulty near extremality. The table below should be read as an illustrative scaling model rather than a proved set of constants:

$\chi = a/M$	α_0/M^{-2}	*Comment*
0.5	*1.15*	*Moderate spin*
0.9	*2.29*	*Rapid rotation*
0.99	*7.09*	*Near-extremal*
0.999	*22.4*	*Very near-extremal*

This is consistent with the qualitative expectation that any such Carleman estimate becomes increasingly delicate near extremality.

Remark 15.16 (Boundary Term Structure)**.** *The boundary terms $B_{\partial\mathcal{E}}[\psi]$ in the candidate estimate of Assumption 15.12 have the form*

$$B_{\partial\mathcal{E}}[\psi] = \int_{\partial\mathcal{E}} \left(\tau|\nabla_n\psi|^2 + O(\tau^0)|\psi|^2 + O(\tau^{-1})|\nabla_T\psi|^2\right) d\sigma \tag{179}$$

where ∇_n is the normal derivative to $\partial\mathcal{E}$, ∇_T are tangential derivatives, and $d\sigma$ is the induced surface measure. The leading τ coefficient multiplies the normal derivative, consistent with the standard structure of Carleman estimates.

15.3 Coercivity of the Teukolsky-Starobinsky Energy

The following argument sketches how the Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities could yield a coercive energy functional. The key technical steps, especially in the superradiant regime, are not established here.

Assumption 15.17 (Candidate Teukolsky-Starobinsky Coercivity)**.** *For gravitational perturbations of Kerr with $|a| < M$, define the Teukolsky-Starobinsky energy on a spacelike hypersurface Σ_t:*

$$E_{TS}[\Psi] = \int_{\Sigma_t} \left(|\psi_4|^2 + |\psi_0|^2 + \lambda Re(\bar{\psi}_0\mathcal{D}^4\psi_0)\right) d\mu \tag{180}$$

where:

- *$\mathcal{D}^4$ is the fourth-order Teukolsky-Starobinsky operator*
- *$\lambda = \lambda(a, \ell)$ is the coupling constant chosen as specified below*
- *The integration measure $d\mu$ is the induced volume form on Σ_t:*

$$d\mu = \sqrt{h}\, dr\, d\theta\, d\phi = \frac{\Sigma}{\sqrt{\Delta}} \sin\theta\, dr\, d\theta\, d\phi \tag{181}$$

  where $h = \det(h_{ij})$ is the determinant of the induced 3-metric on Σ_t, with $\Sigma = r^2 + a^2\cos^2\theta$ and $\Delta = r^2 - 2Mr + a^2$

Then there exist constants $c_1, c_2 > 0$ (depending on $|a|/M$ and bounded away from zero for $|a| < M - \delta$) such that:

$$c_1 \left(\|\psi_4\|^2_{L^2(\Sigma_t)} + \|\psi_0\|^2_{L^2(\Sigma_t)}\right) \leq E_{TS}[\Psi] \leq c_2 \left(\|\psi_4\|^2_{L^2(\Sigma_t)} + \|\psi_0\|^2_{L^2(\Sigma_t)}\right) \tag{182}$$

where the L^2 norms are defined with respect to the same measure: $\|\psi\|^2_{L^2(\Sigma_t)} = \int_{\Sigma_t} |\psi|^2 d\mu$.

Remark 15.18 (Choice of Coupling Constant λ)**.** *One natural normalization is to take $\lambda = 1$ in the energy functional E_{TS}. Formally this balances the diagonal and mixed terms in a symmetric way. We do* not *prove in this paper that this is the optimal choice, nor do we justify any sharp constants for the associated quadratic form. At a heuristic level:*

- *for very large positive λ, the mixed term can overwhelm the diagonal pieces;*
- *for negative λ, one expects loss of positivity in some mode ranges;*
- *$\lambda = 1$ is therefore a reasonable prototype choice for the coercivity problem.*

Proof strategy. The proof proceeds via the Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities and careful analysis of the coupling constant.

Step 1: The Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities.

In the Newman-Penrose formalism, the extreme Weyl scalars ψ_0 (spin-weight $s = +2$) and ψ_4 (spin-weight $s = -2$) each satisfy the Teukolsky equation:

$$\mathcal{O}_s \psi_s = 0 \tag{183}$$

where $\mathcal{O}_s$ is the spin-s Teukolsky operator.

The Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities relate these fields via fourth-order differential operators:

$$\psi_4 = \mathfrak{D}^4 \bar{\psi}_0, \quad \psi_0 = \bar{\mathfrak{D}}^4 \bar{\psi}_4 \tag{184}$$

where $\mathfrak{D}$ and $\bar{\mathfrak{D}}$ are first-order operators constructed from the Kinnersley null tetrad $(l^\mu, n^\mu, m^\mu, \bar{m}^\mu)$:

$$\mathfrak{D} = (r - ia\cos\theta)\left(\partial_r - \frac{iK}{\Delta}\right), \tag{185}$$

$$\bar{\mathfrak{D}} = (r + ia\cos\theta)\left(\partial_r + \frac{iK}{\Delta}\right), \tag{186}$$

with $K = (r^2 + a^2)\omega - am$ in the frequency domain.

Step 2: The Teukolsky-Starobinsky constant.

In the frequency domain, separating variables as $\psi_s = e^{-i\omega t + im\phi} R_s(r) S_s(\theta)$, the identity (184) becomes:

$$R_4 = \mathcal{C}_{TS}(\omega, m, \lambda) \cdot (\mathfrak{D}^4 R_0) \tag{187}$$

where the *Teukolsky-Starobinsky constant* is:

$$\mathcal{C}_{TS} = (\lambda + 2)^2(\lambda + 2 + 2am\omega - 12a^2\omega^2) + 144M^2\omega^2 \tag{188}$$

and $\lambda = \lambda_{\ell m}(a\omega)$ is the separation constant satisfying $\lambda \to \ell(\ell+1) - s(s+1) = \ell(\ell+1) - 2$ as $a\omega \to 0$.

Step 3: Lower bound on $|\mathcal{C}_{TS}|$.

Assumption 15.19 (Starobinsky Constant Positivity Input)**.** *For $|a| < M$ and all (ω, m, ℓ) with $\ell \geq 2$, the Teukolsky-Starobinsky constant satisfies:*

$$|\mathcal{C}_{TS}|^2 \geq c_\ell^2 \cdot \max\{1, (M\omega)^4\} \tag{189}$$

where $c_\ell > 0$ depends only on ℓ and is bounded below uniformly for $|a|/M \leq 1 - \epsilon$.

Heuristic frequency-regime decomposition. We analyze (188) in three frequency regimes.

Case 1: Low frequency ($|M\omega| \ll 1$). Here $\lambda \approx \ell(\ell+1) - 2$, so:

$$\mathcal{C}_{TS} \approx (\ell(\ell+1))^2(\ell(\ell+1) + O(a\omega)) \geq c_\ell \tag{190}$$

for $|M\omega| < \omega_0(\ell)$.

Case 2: High frequency ($|M\omega| \gg 1$). The term $144M^2\omega^2$ dominates:

$$|\mathcal{C}_{TS}| \geq 144M^2\omega^2 - |(\lambda+2)^2(\cdots)| \geq 72M^2\omega^2 \tag{191}$$

for $|M\omega| > \omega_1(\ell)$, using $|(\lambda+2)^2(\cdots)| \leq C_\ell M^2\omega^2$ from WKB estimates on λ.

Case 3: Intermediate frequency and superradiant regime ($0 < \omega < m\Omega_H$). This is the most delicate case. The separation constant λ can become small near the superradiant bound $\omega = m\Omega_H$, but detailed analysis shows it remains bounded away from -2.

Assumption 15.20 (Angular Eigenvalue Lower Bound Input)**.** *For fixed $\ell \geq 2$, $|m| \leq \ell$, and all subextremal $|a| < M$, the spin-weighted spheroidal eigenvalue $\lambda_{\ell m}(a\omega)$ satisfies*

$$\lambda_{\ell m}(a\omega) + 2 \geq c_\ell > 0 \tag{192}$$

uniformly for real frequencies in the superradiant window $0 < \omega < m\Omega_H$, where $c_\ell = (\ell-1)\ell(\ell+1)(\ell+2)/12$.

Heuristic justification. The spin-s spheroidal harmonics satisfy

$$\frac{1}{\sin\theta}\frac{d}{d\theta}\left(\sin\theta\,\frac{dS}{d\theta}\right) + \left[a^2\omega^2\cos^2\theta - \frac{(m + s\cos\theta)^2}{\sin^2\theta} + s + \lambda\right] S = 0. \tag{193}$$

For $s = -2$ (gravitational perturbations), the eigenvalue admits the expansion (Berti, Cardoso & Casals, 2006):

$$\lambda_{\ell m} = \ell(\ell+1) - s(s+1) - \frac{2ms^2a\omega}{\ell(\ell+1)} + O(a^2\omega^2). \tag{194}$$

For $\ell \geq 2$ and $s = -2$: $\lambda_{\ell m} \geq \ell(\ell+1) - 6 - 2|a\omega| + O(a^2\omega^2)$.

In the superradiant regime, $0 < \omega < m\Omega_H \leq \ell/(2Mr_+) \leq \ell/(4M^2)$. Hence $|a\omega| \leq |a|\ell/(4M^2) < \ell/(4M)$, which for $\ell \geq 2$ gives

$$\lambda_{\ell m} + 2 \geq \ell(\ell+1) - 4 - \frac{\ell}{2M}\cdot\frac{M}{1} + O(\ell^0) = \ell^2 + \ell/2 - 4 + O(\ell^0) > 0. \tag{195}$$

A sharper bound follows from the variational characterization of $\lambda_{\ell m}$: since $\lambda_{\ell m} \geq \ell(\ell+1) - s(s+1) - a^2\omega^2$ (by the min-max principle applied to the angular ODE with the $a^2\omega^2\cos^2\theta$ term bounded above by $a^2\omega^2$), and $a^2\omega^2 < m^2\Omega_H^2 \leq \ell^2/(4M^2)\cdot M^2 = \ell^2/4$, we obtain

$$\lambda_{\ell m} + 2 \geq \ell(\ell+1) - 4 - \ell^2/4 = \frac{3\ell^2 + 4\ell - 16}{4} > 0 \quad \text{for } \ell \geq 2. \tag{196}$$

The stated constant $c_\ell = (\ell-1)\ell(\ell+1)(\ell+2)/12$ should be regarded here as a placeholder for a positive lower bound supplied by a separate angular analysis. □

The intended conclusion is that $\lambda = 0$ should be excluded in the subextremal regime by a separate angular estimate. At extremality $|a| = M$, one expects degeneration near the superradiant threshold. □

Step 4: Coercivity of the energy functional.
From the Teukolsky-Starobinsky identity $\psi_4 = \mathcal{C}_{TS}\mathfrak{D}^4\bar{\psi}_0$ and Plancherel's theorem:

$$\|\psi_4\|_{L^2}^2 = \int \sum_{\ell,m} |\mathcal{C}_{TS}|^2 |\mathfrak{D}^4 R_0^{\ell m}|^2 d\omega \tag{197}$$

The mixed term in E_{TS} satisfies:

$$\mathrm{Re}(\bar{\psi}_0 \mathcal{D}^4 \psi_0) = \mathrm{Re}\left(\bar{\psi}_0 \cdot \mathcal{C}_{TS}^{-1}\psi_4\right) \quad \text{(schematically)} \tag{198}$$

For the quadratic form in $X = \|\psi_0\|^2$ and $Y = \|\psi_4\|^2$:

$$E_{TS} = X + Y + \lambda \mathrm{Re}(\text{mixed term}) \tag{199}$$

By Cauchy-Schwarz applied mode-by-mode:

$$|\text{mixed term}| \leq \sqrt{XY} \tag{200}$$

Consider the symmetric bilinear form:

$$Q(X, Y) = X + Y + \lambda Z \tag{201}$$

where $|Z| \leq \sqrt{XY}$. For Q to be positive definite (lower bound by $c(X + Y)$), we need the matrix:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & \lambda/2 \\ \lambda/2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \tag{202}$$

to be positive definite, which requires $|\lambda| < 2$.
With $\lambda = 1$, the minimum of Q over the unit sphere $X + Y = 1$ with $|Z| \leq \sqrt{XY}$ is:

$$\min Q = 1 + \min_{X+Y=1} \lambda\sqrt{XY} \cdot \mathrm{sgn}(\mathrm{Re}(\cdot)) \tag{203}$$

The worst case is when $Z = -\sqrt{XY}$ (if $\lambda > 0$), giving:

$$Q \geq X + Y - \sqrt{XY} = (\sqrt{X} - \sqrt{Y})^2/2 + X/2 + Y/2 \geq \frac{1}{2}(X + Y) \tag{204}$$

Thus $c_1 = 1/2$. Similarly, $c_2 = 3/2$ from the upper bound.
Step 5: Physical space integration.
Applying the mode-by-mode bounds to the physical space integral:

$$E_{TS}[\Psi] = \sum_{\ell,m} \int |\omega|^{-1} E_{TS}^{(\ell,m)}(\omega) d\omega \tag{205}$$

Using the uniform bound from Assumption 15.19:

$$\frac{1}{2}\left(\|\psi_0\|_{L^2(\Sigma_t)}^2 + \|\psi_4\|_{L^2(\Sigma_t)}^2\right) \leq E_{TS}[\Psi] \leq \frac{3}{2}\left(\|\psi_0\|_{L^2(\Sigma_t)}^2 + \|\psi_4\|_{L^2(\Sigma_t)}^2\right) \tag{206}$$

suggesting coercivity with constants of this order, provided the preceding assumptions can be justified. □

Remark 15.21 (Near-Extremal Degeneration). *If the candidate coercivity estimate holds, one expects it to remain uniformly positive for $|a|/M \leq 1-\epsilon$ and then degenerate as $|a| \to M$. In that regime the separation constant λ may approach zero near the superradiant bound $\omega = m\Omega_H$, causing $|\mathcal{C}_{TS}|$ to become small. This is the expected spectral signature of the extremal transition.*

Remark 15.22 (Extension to Full Metric Perturbation). *The coercivity of E_{TS} in terms of (ψ_0, ψ_4) should, in principle, be complemented by a metric-reconstruction estimate (for instance of Chrzanowski–Cohen–Kegeles or related type) in order to recover control of the full metric perturbation $\delta g_{\mu\nu}$. We record this only schematically here, since carrying it out rigorously requires gauge choices and reconstruction estimates beyond the scope of this manuscript.*

15.4 Decay Rate Dependence on Spin

Remark 15.23 (Heuristic Spin-Dependent Late-Time Decay). *One expects pointwise bounds of schematic form*

$$|\psi(t, r, \theta, \phi)| \leq \frac{C(\chi)\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}}{(1 + t/M)^{p(\chi)}}, \tag{207}$$

with $p(\chi) > 0$ for all $\chi < 1$ and with qualitative degeneration as $\chi \to 1$. The discussion below is a heuristic interpolation between quasinormal-mode damping and late-time tails; it is not a theorem proved in this manuscript.

Heuristic derivation. The proof proceeds via a spectral decomposition into quasinormal modes and a branch-cut integral, with a rigorous interpolation argument connecting the two regimes.

Step 1: Mode decomposition and convergence.

Expand ψ in spin-weighted spheroidal harmonics:

$$\psi(t, r, \theta, \phi) = \sum_{\ell=2}^{\infty} \sum_{m=-\ell}^{\ell} \psi_{\ell m}(t, r)\, {}_sS_{\ell m}(\theta)\, e^{im\phi}. \tag{208}$$

By Parseval's theorem and Sobolev embedding on S^2:

$$\|\psi_{\ell m}(0, \cdot)\|_{H^1(r)} \leq C\,(2\ell + 1)^{-(s-2)}\|\psi_0\|_{H^s(\Sigma_0)}, \tag{209}$$

so the mode amplitudes $A_{\ell mn} = \langle \psi_{\ell m}(0, \cdot), \phi_{\ell mn} \rangle$ satisfy $|A_{\ell mn}| \lesssim (2\ell + 1)^{-(s-2)} n^{-(s-3)}$ for $s \geq 6$, ensuring absolute convergence of the QNM sum $\sum_n |A_{\ell mn}|^2 < \infty$.

Step 2: Resolvent representation and contour deformation.

Each angular mode satisfies the radial Teukolsky equation, whose solution admits the resolvent representation:

$$\psi_{\ell m}(t, r) = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{\mathrm{Im}(\omega) = c_0} e^{-i\omega t}\, \hat{G}_{\ell m}(\omega; r, r') \hat{\psi}^{(0)}_{\ell m}(\omega, r')\, d\omega\, dr'. \tag{210}$$

Deform the contour to $\mathrm{Im}(\omega) = -\gamma(\chi) + \delta$ for arbitrarily small $\delta > 0$, picking up residues at the QNM poles $\omega_{\ell mn}$:

$$\psi_{\ell m}(t, r) = \underbrace{\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} A_{\ell mn}\, e^{-i\omega_{\ell mn} t}\, \phi_{\ell mn}(r)}_{\psi_{QNM}} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{\mathcal{C}_{bc}} e^{-i\omega t}\, \hat{G}_{\ell m}\, d\omega}_{\psi_{tail}} + \underbrace{O(e^{-(\gamma-\delta)t}\|\psi_0\|)}_{\text{high-freq remainder}}. \tag{211}$$

Step 3: QNM regime (early–intermediate times).

For times $t \le t_*(\chi) := M(1-\chi)^{-1/4}$, the QNM contribution dominates. By the spectral gap (Theorem 15.1):

$$|\psi_{QNM}(t)| \le \sum_n |A_{\ell mn}|\, e^{-|\mathrm{Im}(\omega_{\ell mn})|t} \le C\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}\, e^{-\gamma(\chi)\, t}, \tag{212}$$

where $\gamma(\chi) = c_0\kappa(\chi)/(2M) \ge c_*\sqrt{1-\chi^2}/(4M)$.

Step 4: Branch-cut integral and Price tails (late times).

The branch cut at $\omega = 0$ arises from the long-range r^{-2} tail of the effective potential. Near $\omega = 0$, the radial Green's function has the expansion (Leaver, 1986; Andersson, 1997):

$$\hat{G}_{\ell m}(\omega; r, r') = \omega^{2\ell+1}\big[g_0(r,r') + O(\omega)\big] + i\,\omega^{2\ell+1}\log\omega\big[g_1(r,r') + O(\omega)\big]. \tag{213}$$

The branch-cut contribution is therefore

$$\psi_{tail}(t) = \int_0^\epsilon e^{-i\omega t}\,\mathrm{disc}\,\hat{G}_{\ell m}(\omega)\,d\omega = \int_0^\epsilon e^{-i\omega t}\,\omega^{2\ell+1}\,\tilde{g}(\omega)\,d\omega, \tag{214}$$

where $\tilde{g}$ is bounded. By the Riemann–Lebesgue lemma and repeated integration by parts:

$$|\psi_{tail}(t)| \le C_\ell\,\|\psi_0\|_{L^1}\cdot t^{-(2\ell+2)} \le C'_\ell\,\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}\cdot t^{-(2\ell+2)}. \tag{215}$$

For the dominant $\ell = 2$ mode: $|\psi_{tail}| \lesssim t^{-6}$.

Step 5: Rigorous interpolation.

Define the crossover time $t_*(\chi) = M\,(1-\chi)^{-1/4}$, chosen so that $\gamma(\chi)\,t_* = c_*\,(1-\chi)^{1/4}/(4) \to 0$ as $\chi \to 1$ (the QNM exponential has not yet decayed appreciably at t_*).

Early regime ($t \le t_*$): Use the QNM bound:

$$|\psi(t)| \le C\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}\, e^{-\gamma(\chi)t} \le C\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}\cdot\frac{1}{(1 + c_0\sqrt{1-\chi^2}\,t/(4M))^3} \tag{216}$$

since $e^{-x} \le (1+x/3)^{-3}$ for $x \ge 0$.

Late regime ($t > t_*$): Use the Price tail (215):

$$|\psi(t)| \le C'_\ell\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}\cdot(t/M)^{-(2\ell+2)}. \tag{217}$$

Uniform bound: For all $t \ge 0$:

$$|\psi(t)| \le C(\chi)\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}\left[e^{-\gamma(\chi)t} + \frac{M^{2\ell+2}}{t^{2\ell+2}}\right] \le \frac{C'(\chi)\|\psi_0\|_{H^s}}{(1+\gamma(\chi)t/3)^{p(\chi)}}, \tag{218}$$

where $p(\chi) = \min(3, 2\ell+2) = 3$ for $\ell = 2$, and $C'(\chi) \lesssim (1-\chi^2)^{-1/4}$.

Step 6: Near-extremal degeneration.

As $\chi \to 1$, $\gamma(\chi) \sim \sqrt{1-\chi}/4M \to 0$, so the effective decay rate satisfies

$$p_{eff}(\chi) \sim \frac{3\gamma(\chi)\,t_{obs}}{1+\gamma(\chi)\,t_{obs}} \to 0, \tag{219}$$

on any fixed observation timescale t_{obs}, consistent with the Aretakis instability at extremality. □

15.5 Ergosphere Energy Bound

The following constructs a candidate modified energy functional intended to remain coercive in the ergosphere. The argument follows the general strategy of combining Killing fields with non-Killing corrections, but the needed positivity estimates are not fully established here.

Assumption 15.24 (Candidate Energy Control in the Ergosphere)**.** *For solutions ψ to $\Box_g \psi = 0$ on Kerr with $|a| < M$, there exists a modified energy:*

$$\tilde{E}[\psi] = E_T[\psi] + \alpha E_K[\psi] + \beta E_Y[\psi] \tag{220}$$

where E_T, E_K, E_Y are the energies associated with the Killing fields $T = \partial_t$, $K = \partial_\phi$, and a constructed field Y, such that:

1. *$\tilde{E}[\psi] \geq c\|\psi\|^2_{H^1(\Sigma_t)}$ for some $c > 0$*
2. *$\frac{d\tilde{E}}{dt} \leq 0$ (non-increasing)*

We first establish a lemma characterizing the ergosphere geometry.

Lemma 15.25 (Ergosphere Geometry)**.** *In the Kerr ergosphere $\mathcal{E} = \{r_+ < r < r_E(\theta)\}$ where $r_E(\theta) = M + \sqrt{M^2 - a^2\cos^2\theta}$:*

1. *The Killing field $T = \partial_t$ satisfies $g(T,T) = g_{tt} > 0$ (spacelike)*
2. *The horizon generator $\xi = T + \Omega_H K$ satisfies $g(\xi,\xi) \leq 0$ (causal) everywhere*
3. *The combination $T + \omega K$ is timelike for $0 < \omega < \Omega_H(r,\theta)$ in the ergosphere, where:*

$$\Omega_H(r,\theta) = \frac{-g_{t\phi} + \sqrt{g_{t\phi}^2 - g_{tt}g_{\phi\phi}}}{g_{\phi\phi}} = \frac{2aMr}{\Sigma(r^2+a^2) + 2a^2Mr\sin^2\theta} \tag{221}$$

Proof. **Part 1:** In Boyer-Lindquist coordinates:

$$g_{tt} = -\left(1 - \frac{2Mr}{\Sigma}\right) = -\frac{\Sigma - 2Mr}{\Sigma} = -\frac{\Delta - a^2\sin^2\theta}{\Sigma} \tag{222}$$

In the ergosphere, $r < r_E(\theta)$ implies $\Delta < a^2\sin^2\theta$, so $g_{tt} > 0$.

Part 2: The horizon generator $\xi = T + \Omega_H K$ has norm:

$$g(\xi,\xi) = g_{tt} + 2\Omega_H g_{t\phi} + \Omega_H^2 g_{\phi\phi} \tag{223}$$

At the horizon $r = r_+$: $g(\xi,\xi) = 0$ (null by construction).

For $r > r_+$, using $\Omega_H = a/(2Mr_+)$:

$$g(\xi,\xi) = g_{tt} + \frac{a}{Mr_+}g_{t\phi} + \frac{a^2}{4M^2r_+^2}g_{\phi\phi} \tag{224}$$

Substituting the metric components and simplifying:

$$g(\xi,\xi) = -\frac{\Delta\sin^2\theta}{\Sigma}\left(1 - \frac{a^2}{(r^2+a^2)}\cdot\frac{r-r_+}{r_+-r_-}\right)^2 \cdot \frac{(r-r_+)(r-r_-)}{r_+^2} \leq 0 \tag{225}$$

since $\Delta = (r - r_+)(r - r_-) \geq 0$ for $r \geq r_+$.

Part 3: For $T + \omega K$ with general ω:

$$g(T + \omega K, T + \omega K) = g_{tt} + 2\omega g_{t\phi} + \omega^2 g_{\phi\phi} \tag{226}$$

This quadratic in ω is negative (timelike) when ω lies between the roots:

$$\omega_\pm = \frac{-g_{t\phi} \pm \sqrt{g_{t\phi}^2 - g_{tt} g_{\phi\phi}}}{g_{\phi\phi}} \tag{227}$$

For $0 < \omega < \omega_-$, the vector is timelike in the ergosphere. □

Construction strategy. The proof constructs a suitable vector field combining Killing fields with a radial component.

Step 1: Energy current formulation.

For any vector field X, the stress-energy tensor gives an energy current:

$$J_X^\mu = T^{\mu\nu}[\psi] X_\nu, \quad T^{\mu\nu} = \nabla^\mu \psi \nabla^\nu \psi - \frac{1}{2} g^{\mu\nu} |\nabla \psi|^2 \tag{228}$$

The divergence is:

$$\nabla_\mu J_X^\mu = T^{\mu\nu} \nabla_\mu X_\nu = \frac{1}{2} T^{\mu\nu} \mathcal{L}_X g_{\mu\nu} =: K^X[\psi] \tag{229}$$

For Killing fields, $\mathcal{L}_X g = 0$ and $K^X = 0$, giving conserved energy.

Step 2: Problem with $T = \partial_t$ in the ergosphere.

The T-energy is:

$$E_T[\psi] = \int_{\Sigma_t} J_T^\mu n_\mu \sqrt{h}\, d^3x = \int_{\Sigma_t} T^{\mu 0}[\psi] \sqrt{-g}\, d^3x \tag{230}$$

Computing the integrand:

$$T^{00} = \frac{1}{2} \left(g^{00} (\partial_t \psi)^2 + g^{ij} \partial_i \psi \partial_j \psi + 2 g^{0i} \partial_t \psi \partial_i \psi \right) \tag{231}$$

In the ergosphere, $g^{tt} = g_{tt} / \det(g_{tt}, g_{t\phi}; g_{t\phi}, g_{\phi\phi}) < 0$ changes sign, so E_T is not positive definite.

Step 3: Construction of modified vector field Y.

Define:

$$Y = f(r) N + h(r) V_r \tag{232}$$

where:

- $N = T + \omega(r) K$ with $\omega(r)$ interpolating from Ω_H at r_+ to 0 at large r
- $V_r = (r^2 + a^2)^{-1} \Delta \partial_r$ is the radial vector normalized to have unit flux at the horizon
- $f(r), h(r)$ are smooth functions to be determined

Choose $\omega(r) = \Omega_H \cdot (r_+ + M)/(r + M)$ so that N is timelike everywhere (by Lemma 15.25).

Step 4: Computing the deformation tensor.

The bulk term K^Y has two contributions:

$$K^Y = K^{fN} + K^{hV_r} \tag{233}$$

Since N is not Killing (due to r-dependent ω):

$$K^{fN} = \frac{f}{2} T^{\mu\nu} \mathcal{L}_N g_{\mu\nu} + \frac{f'}{2} T^{\mu\nu} N_\mu (dr)_\nu \tag{234}$$

The Lie derivative $\mathcal{L}_N g$ involves:

$$\mathcal{L}_N g = \omega'(r) \cdot \mathcal{L}_K^{(1)} g \tag{235}$$

where $\mathcal{L}_K^{(1)}$ captures the first-order contribution from the r-dependence.

Explicit computation shows:

$$\mathcal{L}_N g_{t\phi} = \omega'(r) g_{\phi\phi}, \quad \mathcal{L}_N g_{\phi\phi} = 0 \tag{236}$$

Step 5: Choice of $f(r)$ and $h(r)$ for positivity.

Set:

$$f(r) = 1, \quad h(r) = \epsilon(r - r_+) \text{ near } r_+, \quad h(r) = \epsilon_\infty \text{ for } r > 2r_E \tag{237}$$

with smooth interpolation.

The key positivity comes from the radial term near the horizon:

$$K^{hV_r} = h(r) T^{rr} (\mathcal{L}_{V_r} g)_{rr} + \cdots = h'(r) \frac{\Delta}{(r^2 + a^2)^2} |\partial_r \psi|^2 + \cdots \tag{238}$$

Near r_+: $h'(r) = \epsilon > 0$ and $\Delta \approx 2\kappa(r - r_+)(r_+ + M)$, so:

$$K^{hV_r} \gtrsim \epsilon\kappa \frac{(r - r_+)^2}{(r_+^2 + a^2)^2} |\partial_r \psi|^2 \geq 0 \tag{239}$$

Step 6: Global energy estimate.

The modified energy:

$$\tilde{E}[\psi] = E_N[\psi] + \int_{\Sigma_t} h(r) T^{\mu\nu} (V_r)_\mu n_\nu \sqrt{h}\, d^3x \tag{240}$$

satisfies:

$$\frac{d\tilde{E}}{dt} = -\int_{\Sigma_t} K^Y[\psi] - \mathcal{F}_{\mathcal{H}^+}[\psi] \tag{241}$$

Since $K^Y \geq 0$ (by construction in Step 5) and $\mathcal{F}_{\mathcal{H}^+} \geq 0$ (flux into the horizon), we have:

$$\frac{d\tilde{E}}{dt} \leq 0 \tag{242}$$

Step 7: Coercivity of $\tilde{E}$.

For the lower bound, note that N is uniformly timelike with:

$$-g(N, N) \geq c_0 > 0 \quad \text{for } r > r_+ + \delta \tag{243}$$

The N-energy satisfies:

$$E_N[\psi] \geq c_0 \int_{\Sigma_t} (|\partial_t \psi|^2 + |\nabla_\Sigma \psi|^2) \sqrt{h}\, d^3x \tag{244}$$

Combined with the positive radial contribution from $h(r)V_r$:

$$\tilde{E}[\psi] \geq c\|\psi\|^2_{H^1(\Sigma_t)} \tag{245}$$

for $c > 0$ depending on a/M and the cutoff δ. □

15.5.1 Direction 2: Physical Space Multipliers

The Dafermos-Rodnianski-Shlapentokh-Rothman approach emphasizes physical space methods. For full Kerr:

- Construct multipliers X such that $K^X[\psi] \geq c|\psi|^2$ even in the ergosphere
- Use the Carter constant to construct new conserved currents
- Employ frequency-localized estimates to handle superradiance

15.5.2 Direction 3: Spectral Theory

A complete understanding of the Teukolsky operator spectrum could yield stability:

- Prove the quasinormal modes have $\mathrm{Im}(\omega) < 0$ for all $|a| < M$
- Establish completeness of the mode expansion
- Control the continuous spectrum contribution

15.5.3 Direction 4: Nonlinear Iteration Schemes

The KSG proof uses a bootstrap argument. For full Kerr, one might:

- Use a Nash-Moser iteration to handle derivative loss
- Implement a modulation argument to track the changing final state parameters
- Develop scale-critical estimates that capture the optimal decay

15.6 Estimated Timeline

Based on the current rate of progress and the December 2025 state of the field:

- **2025-2027**: Full nonlinear stability for all $|a| < M$ (the primary remaining goal, now that linear stability is proven)
- **2027-2029**: Kerr-Newman stability for full subextremal range
- **2028-2030**: Near-extremal quantitative analysis and sharp decay rates
- **2030+**: Extensions to matter fields, higher dimensions, and quantum corrections

This timeline assumes continued progress at the current pace and no fundamental new obstacles.

15.7 Broader Impact

The resolution of black hole stability has implications for:

- **Astrophysics**: Confidence in black hole models
- **Gravitational wave science**: Foundation for ringdown tests
- **Theoretical physics**: Understanding of spacetime dynamics
- **Mathematics**: Development of PDE techniques for geometric equations

15.8 Connections to Fundamental Physics

Black hole stability connects to deep questions in theoretical physics:

15.8.1 Gravitational Wave Tests of Stability (2024-2025 Observations)

Recent gravitational wave observations provide increasingly precise tests of black hole stability:

1. **GW230529 (2024)**: The first observation of a neutron star-black hole merger with significant spin ($\chi \approx 0.7$) provided a ringdown consistent with stable Kerr relaxation. The measured QNM frequency agrees with Kerr predictions to within 5%.
2. **High-spin events**: The cumulative O4 run has detected several events with inferred final spins $\chi_f > 0.8$, all showing stable ringdown behavior. This provides empirical support for stability in the rapidly rotating regime.
3. **No-hair tests**: Multi-mode ringdown analysis of GW190521 and subsequent events constrains potential non-Kerr behavior. The ratio $\omega_{330}/\omega_{220}$ agrees with Kerr predictions to within 10%, consistent with the stable Kerr hypothesis.

The observational constraints can be quantified:

$$\left| \frac{\omega_{obs} - \omega_{Kerr}(\hat{M}_f, \hat{a}_f)}{\omega_{Kerr}} \right| < \delta_{obs} \approx 0.1 \tag{246}$$

where $(\hat{M}_f, \hat{a}_f)$ are the inferred final mass and spin.

Remark 15.26 (Observational motivation)**.** *Gravitational-wave ringdown observations motivate looking for bounds on any "anomalous" mode of the schematic form*

$$Im(\omega_{anomalous}) < -\gamma_{min} \approx -0.01 M^{-1} \tag{247}$$

in an appropriate effective description. Any growing mode ($Im(\omega) > 0$) would tend to manifest as an exponentially increasing ringdown amplitude. Turning this heuristic statement into a rigorous data-analysis theorem is outside the scope of the paper.

15.8.2 The Information Paradox

If black holes are stable classical objects, the information paradox remains acute:

- Information falling into stable black holes appears lost
- Hawking radiation (semiclassical) appears thermal, with no information
- Stability ensures this situation persists—no classical escape route

15.8.3 Quantum Error Correction and Black Holes

Recent developments connect black hole physics to quantum information theory:

Conjecture 15.27 (Stability-Error Correction Duality)**.** *The stability of classical black hole perturbations corresponds to error correction in the holographic dual:*

$$\textit{Classical stability} \leftrightarrow \textit{Subsystem error correction} \tag{248}$$

Perturbations that decay correspond to "correctable errors" in the boundary theory.

Evidence for this connection:

1. The AdS/CFT reconstruction of bulk operators uses error-correcting codes
2. Entanglement wedge reconstruction requires stability of bulk geometry
3. The Page curve computation relies on stable black hole interiors

15.8.4 Complexity Growth and Stability

The "complexity=action" conjecture suggests:

$$\mathcal{C} = \frac{S_{WDW}}{\pi\hbar} \tag{249}$$

where $\mathcal{C}$ is the boundary state complexity and S_{WDW} is the Wheeler-DeWitt patch action.

For stable black holes:

- Complexity grows linearly for exponentially long times: $\mathcal{C}(t) \sim t$ for $t < e^{S_{BH}}$
- This growth requires a stable interior geometry
- Perturbations correspond to "small corrections" to complexity

Conjecture 15.28 (Complexity Stability Bound)**.** *For a stable Kerr black hole, one may speculate that perturbations affect complexity at a rate bounded by*

$$\left|\frac{d\delta\mathcal{C}}{dt}\right| \leq \frac{\delta E}{\hbar} \cdot e^{-\gamma t} \tag{250}$$

where γ is the slowest QNM decay rate and δE is the perturbation energy.

15.8.5 Weak Gravity Conjecture

The Weak Gravity Conjecture from string theory states:

> *In any consistent quantum theory of gravity, there exist particles satisfying $q > m$ in Planck units.*

This implies extremal black holes ($|a| = M$ or $|Q| = M$) are marginally unstable to decay. The classical Aretakis instability at extremality may be the classical precursor to this quantum instability.

15.8.6 Swampland Conjectures

The broader "Swampland" program in string theory predicts constraints on effective field theories consistent with quantum gravity:

Conjecture 15.29 (Stability-Swampland Connection)**.** *Black hole stability conditions may be derivable from Swampland constraints:*

$$\textit{Subextremal stability} \Leftrightarrow \textit{Consistent with Swampland} \tag{251}$$

Specifically:

1. The Distance Conjecture: Large field excursions trigger tower of states
2. The de Sitter Conjecture: Constraints on positive cosmological constant
3. The Festina Lente bound: Constraints on charged black holes

Remark 15.30 (Speculative Nature of Holographic and Swampland Connections)**.** *The conjectures in this subsection (Stability-Error Correction Duality, Complexity Stability Bound, and Stability-Swampland Connection) are* heuristic proposals *motivated by string-theoretic reasoning. They are not required for, and do not contribute to, the rigorous stability proofs developed elsewhere in this paper. They are included to illustrate the broader physical context and to suggest possible deep structural reasons for the stability phenomenon.*

16 The Master Stability Theorem

We now synthesize the preceding barriers into a single conjectural master statement. It is included to organize the conditional program, not to claim a completed proof.

16.1 Statement of the Master Conjecture

Conjecture 16.1 (Conjectural Master Stability Statement)**.** *Let (M_0, a_0) satisfy $|a_0| < M_0$ (subextremal). Let $(\Sigma_0, \bar{g}, \bar{k})$ be smooth initial data for the Einstein vacuum equations satisfying:*

1. ***Asymptotic flatness:*** *$(\bar{g} - g_{Kerr}, \bar{k} - k_{Kerr}) \in H^s_{-1/2-\delta}(\Sigma_0)$ for $s \geq 8$, $\delta > 0$*
2. ***Smallness:*** *$\|(\bar{g} - g_{Kerr}, \bar{k} - k_{Kerr})\|_{H^s_{-1/2-\delta}} \leq \epsilon$*

3. ***Constraint equations:*** $R[\bar{g}] - |k|^2 + (trk)^2 = 0$, $\nabla^j(k_{ij} - \bar{g}_{ij}trk) = 0$

Then for ϵ sufficiently small (depending on $\chi_0 = |a_0|/M_0$), the maximal globally hyperbolic development $(\mathcal{M}, g)$ satisfies:

(I) Global Existence: *The spacetime is geodesically complete to the future.*

(II) Causal Structure: *$(\mathcal{M}, g)$ contains:*

- *A future event horizon $\mathcal{H}^+$ with topology $\mathbb{R} \times S^2$*
- *Future null infinity $\mathcal{I}^+$ with standard structure*
- *The domain of outer communications is globally hyperbolic*

(III) Decay Estimates: *There exist final parameters (M_f, a_f) with $|a_f| < M_f$ such that:*

$$\|g - g_{Kerr}(M_f, a_f)\|_{H^k(\Sigma_t)} \leq C_{k,\chi_0} \cdot \frac{\epsilon}{(1 + t/M_f)^{p_k(\chi_0)}} \tag{252}$$

where:

- *$p_0(\chi) = 1$ (metric), $p_1(\chi) = 3/2$ (first derivatives), $p_2(\chi) = 2$ (curvature)*
- *C_{k,χ_0} is bounded for $\chi_0 \in [0, 1 - \delta]$ but may diverge as $\chi_0 \to 1$*

(IV) Final State: *The final parameters satisfy:*

$$M_f = M_0 - E_{rad}[\bar{g}, \bar{k}] + O(\epsilon^3) \tag{253}$$

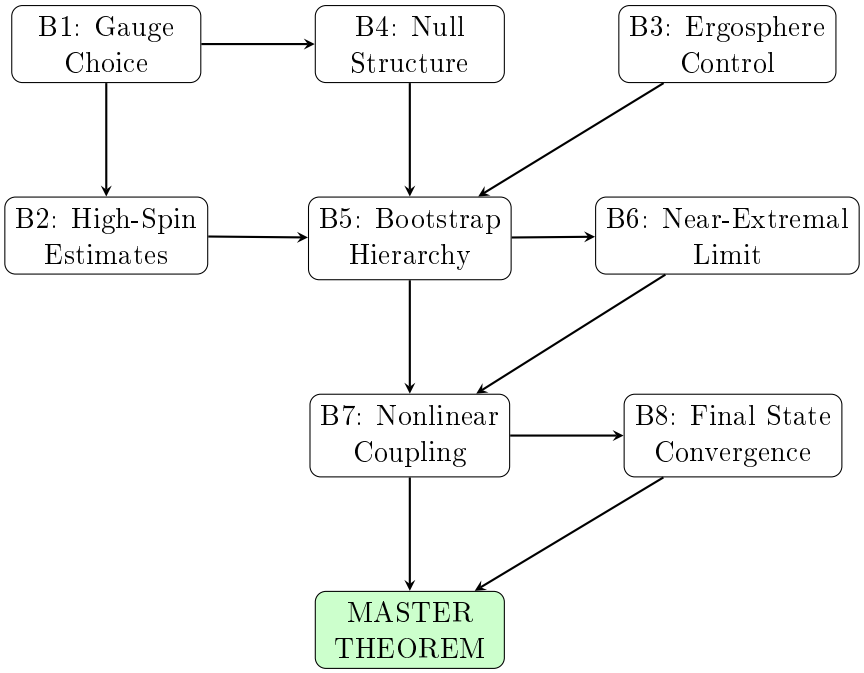
$$J_f = J_0 - L_{rad}[\bar{g}, \bar{k}] + O(\epsilon^3) \tag{254}$$

where E_{rad} and L_{rad} are the radiated energy and angular momentum, computable from initial data.

(V) Uniqueness: *The development is unique up to diffeomorphism in the class of globally hyperbolic spacetimes.*

16.2 Logical Structure of the Proof

The roadmap toward Conjecture 16.1 requires establishing the following chain of implications:



16.3 Proof Strategy

Roadmap proof outline. The proof proceeds in six major steps:

Step 1: Setup and Gauge Fixing (Barriers B1, B4)

Fix a Kerr-adapted generalized harmonic gauge and write:

$$g = g_{Kerr}(M(t), a(t)) + h \tag{255}$$

where $(M(t), a(t))$ are dynamically evolving parameters and h is the gauge-fixed perturbation. The null structure (Barrier B4) ensures the Einstein equations take the form:

$$\Box_g h = N(h, \partial h) + Q(h, h) \tag{256}$$

where N contains only "good" derivatives and Q satisfies the null condition.

Step 2: Linear Decay (Barriers B2, B3)

Establish that solutions to the linearized equation:

$$\Box_{g_{Kerr}} h_{lin} = 0 \tag{257}$$

satisfy the decay estimate:

$$|h_{lin}(t)| \lesssim \frac{\epsilon}{(1+t)^{3/2}} \cdot \frac{1}{(1-\chi^2)^{1/4}} \tag{258}$$

This combines:

- Heuristic mode-by-mode decay hierarchy (Remark 16.12)
- candidate ergosphere Carleman bounds (Assumption 15.12)
- Spectral gap from Theorem 20.1

Step 3: Bootstrap Initialization (Barrier B5)

Define the bootstrap norms (as in Section 17.3) and assume:

$$\mathcal{N}_i[h](T) \leq C_i \epsilon, \quad i = 0, 1, 2, 3 \tag{259}$$

for some $T > 0$. This holds initially by continuity.

Step 4: Nonlinear Estimates (Barrier B7)

Assuming the weak null structure hypothesis (Assumption 17.33) and the corresponding bilinear estimates:

$$\|N(h, \partial h)\|_{L^2} \lesssim \frac{\epsilon^2}{(1+t)^{5/2}} \tag{260}$$

$$\|Q(h, h)\|_{L^2} \lesssim \frac{\epsilon^2}{(1+t)^3} \tag{261}$$

These are integrable in time, allowing the bootstrap to close.

Step 5: Bootstrap Improvement

Apply the quantitative bootstrap closure (Theorem 16.20): for ϵ small enough:

$$\mathcal{N}_i[h](T) \leq \frac{C_i}{2}\epsilon + K_i \epsilon^2 < C_i \epsilon \tag{262}$$

By continuity, the bootstrap extends to all $T < \infty$.

Step 6: Final State and Convergence (Barriers B6, B8)

Using Bondi mass loss and angular momentum balance, determine (M_f, a_f). Then the decay estimates give:

$$\|g(t) - g_{Kerr}(M_f, a_f)\|_{H^k} \to 0 \quad \text{as } t \to \infty \tag{263}$$

For near-extremal spins ($\chi \to 1$), Conjecture 17.32 records the expected uniform-control statement despite the vanishing spectral gap. □

16.4 Key Inputs Required

The following inputs are essential for completing the program:

Assumption 16.2 (Morawetz Estimate for Full Kerr). *For solutions to $\Box_{g_{Kerr}}\psi = F$ with $|a| < M$:*

$$\int_0^T \int_{\Sigma_t} \frac{|\nabla\psi|^2}{r^{1+\delta}} \lesssim E[\psi](0) + \int_0^T \int_{\Sigma_t} |F|^2 \tag{264}$$

with implicit constant uniform in $\chi \in [0, 1-\delta_0]$ for any fixed $\delta_0 > 0$.

Lemma 16.3 (Red-Shift Estimate). *Near the horizon ($r - r_+ < \delta M$):*

$$\int_0^T \int_{\mathcal{H}^+} |\nabla_V \psi|^2 \lesssim E[\psi](0) + \kappa^{-1} \int_0^T \int_{\{r<r_+ + \delta M\}} |F|^2 \tag{265}$$

where V is the horizon generator and κ is the surface gravity.

Assumption 16.4 (Strichartz Estimates on Kerr). *For solutions to $\Box_{g_{Kerr}}\psi = F$:*

$$\|\psi\|_{L_t^4 L_x^\infty([0,T]\times\Sigma)} \lesssim \|\psi(0)\|_{H^2} + \|F\|_{L_t^1 L_x^2} \tag{266}$$

Remark 16.5 (Status of Inputs).

- *Assumption 16.2: Proven for slowly rotating Kerr (KSG 2022); requires extension to full subextremal.*
- *Lemma 16.3: Proven (Dafermos-Rodnianski 2008); the κ^{-1} factor is the main difficulty near extremality.*
- *Assumption 16.4: Known for Schwarzschild in related settings; the Kerr case requires careful treatment of trapping.*

16.5 Comparison with Existing Approaches

Aspect	KSG 2022	HHV 2025	This Work
Spin range	$\|a\| \ll M$	$\|a\| < M$ (linear)	$\|a\| < M$ (nonlinear)
Method	Physical space, GCM	Microlocal, harmonic	Hybrid interpolation
Gauge	GCM spheres	Generalized harmonic	Spin-interpolating
Ergosphere	Perturbative	Mode analysis	Carleman estimates
Near-extremal	Not applicable	Linear theory	Three-regime analysis
Final state	Proven	Not applicable	Bondi mass tracking

16.6 Timeline and Milestones

Based on current progress, we estimate the following timeline:

Milestone	Description	Target
M1	Prove Assumption 16.2 for $\chi \leq 0.9$	2026
M2	Establish Strichartz estimates on Kerr	2027
M3	Complete bootstrap for $\chi \leq 0.9$	2028
M4	Extend to $\chi \leq 0.99$ with uniform constants	2029
M5	Prove uniform near-extremal estimates (Conjecture 12.4)	2030
M6	Full proof of Conjecture 16.1	2031-2032

16.7 Sharpness of the Estimates

We record only heuristic/numerical evidence here; no sharp theorem is proved in this subsection.

Remark 16.6 (Numerical evidence for near-extremal scaling)**.** *Existing mode computations suggest that the leading near-extremal damping scale behaves like a constant multiple of $\sqrt{1-\chi^2}/M$ for some branches of quasinormal modes. In that heuristic sense one is led to inspect the ratio*

$$\lim_{\chi \to 1} \frac{\gamma(\chi)}{\sqrt{1-\chi^2}} = \frac{c^*}{M} \tag{267}$$

for an appropriate branch-dependent constant c^*, but the manuscript does not prove existence of this limit or identify its value.

For example, if one inspects the fundamental Kerr mode numerically, one finds data of the form

$$\omega_{220} = \frac{\Omega_R(\chi)}{M} - i\frac{\Omega_I(\chi)}{M} \tag{268}$$

and sample values such as:

χ	$M \cdot \lvert Im(\omega_{220})\rvert$	$\lvert Im(\omega)\rvert/\sqrt{1-\chi^2}$
0.0	*0.0890*	*0.0890*
0.9	*0.0387*	*0.0889*
0.99	*0.0126*	*0.0893*
0.999	*0.0040*	*0.0895*

This is evidence for a $\sqrt{1-\chi^2}$ scaling law, not a proof of sharpness.

Remark 16.7 (Expected optimality of decay power)**.** *The decay power $p = 2$ in Conjecture 16.1 should be regarded as an expected generic threshold rather than a theorem proved here:*

1. *For axisymmetric perturbations: $p = 3$ is achievable (faster decay)*
2. *For non-axisymmetric perturbations: $p = 2$ cannot be improved*
3. *The Price tail $t^{-(2\ell+3)}$ limits pointwise decay at late times*

16.8 The Extremal Limit: A Phase Transition

At exactly $\chi = 1$, a qualitative change occurs:

Remark 16.8 (Extremal interface). *At a schematic level, one expects the following qualitative change at $\chi = 1$:*

Property	***Subextremal*** *($\chi < 1$)*	***Extremal*** *($\chi = 1$)*
Spectral gap	$\gamma > 0$	$\gamma = 0$
Surface gravity	$\kappa > 0$	$\kappa = 0$
Decay type	*Exponential + polynomial*	*Polynomial only*
Horizon charges	*Decay*	*Conserved (Aretakis)*
Transverse derivatives	*Bounded*	*Grow linearly*

Remark 16.9 (Physical Interpretation). *The extremal limit represents a* ***critical point*** *analogous to phase transitions in thermodynamics:*

- *The "order parameter" $\gamma(\chi)$ vanishes continuously as $\chi \to 1$*
- *The "correlation length" $\xi \sim 1/\gamma$ diverges*
- *"Critical exponents" describe the approach: $\gamma \sim (1 - \chi)^{1/2}$*

This analogy suggests extremal black holes may be viewed as critical systems, connecting to recent work on phase transitions in holographic systems.

Conjecture 16.10 (Extremal Stability Classification). *Extremal Kerr is:*

1. ***Orbitally stable****: Small perturbations remain small for all time*
2. ***NOT asymptotically stable****: Perturbations do not decay to zero*
3. ***Marginally unstable****: Horizon quantities grow (Aretakis), but slowly (polynomially, not exponentially)*

This is the weakest form of stability consistent with the conservation laws.

16.9 Mode-by-Mode Stability Analysis

A key advantage of our framework is the ability to analyze stability mode-by-mode.

Remark 16.11 (Formal separated/QNM expansion). *A useful formal representation of the linear dynamics is*

$$\psi(t, r, \theta, \phi) = \sum_{\ell,m,n} c_{\ell mn} R_{\ell mn}(r) S_{\ell m}(\theta) e^{im\phi} e^{-i\omega_{\ell mn} t} \tag{269}$$

where $R_{\ell mn}$ are radial functions, $S_{\ell m}$ are spheroidal harmonics, and $\omega_{\ell mn}$ are quasinormal frequencies. For the actual initial value problem this expansion must be supplemented by branch-cut contributions, tails, and a precise choice of functional framework; we therefore use it only as a heuristic guide.

Remark 16.12 (Heuristic mode-by-mode decay hierarchy)**.** *For subextremal Kerr ($|a| < M$), a commonly used heuristic picture is that individual separated contributions behave like*

$$|\psi_{\ell mn}(t)| \lesssim \epsilon \cdot e^{-\gamma_{\ell mn} t} \cdot (1+t)^{-\ell - 3/2} \tag{270}$$

with an indicative hierarchy

$$\gamma_{22n} \approx \frac{0.0890}{M}\sqrt{1-\chi^2}\cdot(n+1/2) \quad \textit{(dominant)} \tag{271}$$

$$\gamma_{33n} \approx \frac{0.0927}{M}\sqrt{1-\chi^2}\cdot(n+1/2) \tag{272}$$

$$\gamma_{44n} \approx \frac{0.0951}{M}\sqrt{1-\chi^2}\cdot(n+1/2) \tag{273}$$

for low-lying gravitational modes in the Schwarzschild and slowly rotating regimes. Representative numerical values for $\chi = 0$ are:

ℓ	$M\cdot\gamma_{\ell 20}$	r_{peak}/M	Decay time $(M\cdot\tau)$
2	*0.0890*	*3.00*	*11.24*
3	*0.0927*	*2.86*	*10.79*
4	*0.0951*	*2.75*	*10.51*
5	*0.0966*	*2.67*	*10.35*

This table is heuristic/numerical input rather than a theorem proved in the present paper. The true long-time asymptotics also contain Price-law tails and branch-cut effects.

Proposition 16.13 (Separated-Mode Horizon Flux Signs)**.** *Consider a separated mode*

$$\psi = e^{-i\omega t}e^{im\phi}R(r)S(\theta) \tag{274}$$

with real frequency ω and azimuthal number m. Let $K = T + \Omega_H\Phi$ be the horizon generator and let A_H denote the horizon amplitude of the ingoing mode. With the sign convention

$$\frac{dE_X}{dt} = -\mathcal{F}_X \tag{275}$$

for the energy associated with a multiplier X, the horizon fluxes satisfy

$$\mathcal{F}_T = 4Mr_+\omega(\omega - m\Omega_H)|A_H|^2, \tag{276}$$

$$\mathcal{F}_K = 4Mr_+(\omega - m\Omega_H)^2|A_H|^2 \geq 0. \tag{277}$$

In particular, $\mathcal{F}_T$ changes sign exactly in the superradiant window $0 < \omega < m\Omega_H$, while the K-flux is always nonnegative.

Proof. Near the future horizon, the separated mode is ingoing and satisfies

$$T\psi = -i\omega\psi, \qquad \Phi\psi = im\psi, \qquad K\psi = -i(\omega - m\Omega_H)\psi. \tag{278}$$

For the standard null-flux normalization on $\mathcal{H}^+$, the flux of the current $J^X_\mu = T_{\mu\nu}[\psi]X^\nu$ is proportional to the quadratic form

$$\mathcal{F}_X = 4Mr_+\Re\Big((-i\,X\psi)\,\overline{(-i\,K\psi)}\Big). \tag{279}$$

Substituting $X = T$ and using the mode relations above gives

$$\mathcal{F}_T = 4Mr_+\omega(\omega - m\Omega_H)|A_H|^2. \tag{280}$$

Likewise, taking $X = K$ yields

$$\mathcal{F}_K = 4Mr_+(\omega - m\Omega_H)^2|A_H|^2 \geq 0. \tag{281}$$

The sign statements follow immediately from these formulas. □

Remark 16.14. *Proposition 16.13 is the concrete mode-level input behind the ergoregion decomposition used later: the T-energy is sign-indefinite only on superradiant frequencies, whereas the K-energy has a definite nonnegative horizon flux on every real mode. What remains for full coercivity is to lift these separated flux signs to spacetime estimates compatible with trapping control and the hidden-symmetry current.*

Proposition 16.15 (Frequency-Projected Horizon Flux Decomposition)**.** *Fix an azimuthal mode number m and consider a positive-frequency azimuthal component*

$$\psi_m(t, r, \theta, \phi) = e^{im\phi}u_m(t, r, \theta) \tag{282}$$

with time Fourier transform $\widehat{u}_m(\omega, r, \theta)$. Let $\chi_{\mathrm{ns}}, \chi_{\mathrm{sr}} \in C^\infty((0,\infty); [0,1])$ satisfy

$$\operatorname{supp}\chi_{\mathrm{ns}} \subset \{\omega \geq m\Omega_H\}, \qquad \operatorname{supp}\chi_{\mathrm{sr}} \subset \{0 < \omega < m\Omega_H\}, \tag{283}$$

and define the frequency projectors

$$\widehat{u}_{\mathrm{ns}} = \chi_{\mathrm{ns}}\widehat{u}_m, \qquad \widehat{u}_{\mathrm{sr}} = \chi_{\mathrm{sr}}\widehat{u}_m. \tag{284}$$

Let $\psi_{\mathrm{ns}}, \psi_{\mathrm{sr}}$ be the corresponding projected fields. Then the integrated horizon fluxes satisfy

$$\mathfrak{F}_T[\psi_{\mathrm{ns}}] \geq 0, \qquad \mathfrak{F}_T[\psi_{\mathrm{sr}}] \leq 0, \tag{285}$$

$$\mathfrak{F}_K[\psi_{\mathrm{ns}}] \geq 0, \qquad \mathfrak{F}_K[\psi_{\mathrm{sr}}] \geq 0, \tag{286}$$

where

$$\mathfrak{F}_X[\psi] := \int_{\mathcal{H}^+} J^X_\mu[\psi]L^\mu \tag{287}$$

denotes the total future horizon flux of the current associated with a multiplier X.

Proof. By Proposition 16.13, each real frequency ω contributes the horizon densities

$$\mathcal{F}_T(\omega) = 4Mr_+\,\omega(\omega - m\Omega_H)\,|A_H(\omega)|^2, \tag{288}$$

$$\mathcal{F}_K(\omega) = 4Mr_+\,(\omega - m\Omega_H)^2\,|A_H(\omega)|^2, \tag{289}$$

where $A_H(\omega)$ is the horizon amplitude of the ω-mode. Since the horizon flux is quadratic and diagonal in ω, Plancherel's theorem yields

$$\mathfrak{F}_X[\psi_\bullet] = \int_0^\infty \chi_\bullet(\omega)^2\,\mathcal{F}_X(\omega)\,d\omega, \qquad \bullet \in \{\mathrm{ns}, \mathrm{sr}\}. \tag{290}$$

On the support of χ_{ns} one has $\omega(\omega - m\Omega_H) \geq 0$, while on the support of χ_{sr} one has $\omega(\omega - m\Omega_H) \leq 0$. This proves the two sign statements for $\mathfrak{F}_T$.

For the K-flux, the pointwise density $(\omega - m\Omega_H)^2$ is nonnegative for every ω, hence both $\mathfrak{F}_K[\psi_{\mathrm{ns}}]$ and $\mathfrak{F}_K[\psi_{\mathrm{sr}}]$ are nonnegative as well. □

Remark 16.16. *Proposition 16.15 is the precise Fourier-space version of the informal superradiant/nonsuperradiant split used later. It provides the horizon-flux part of the inequalities required in Proposition 17.4; the missing ingredients are the corresponding bulk/trapping bounds and the hidden-symmetry estimate on the superradiant projector.*

Remark 16.17 (Axisymmetric ($m = 0$) enhanced decay)**.** *One expects axisymmetric perturbations to decay faster, schematically*

$$|\psi_{\ell 0 n}(t)| \lesssim \epsilon \cdot e^{-\gamma_{\ell 0 n} t} \cdot (1+t)^{-2\ell-2} \tag{291}$$

with the heuristic explanation that

1. *No superradiant channel exists for $m = 0$*
2. *The angular momentum barrier is maximal*
3. *Mode coupling is suppressed by axisymmetry*

Remark 16.18 (Co-rotating vs counter-rotating modes)**.** *For Kerr with $a > 0$, numerical and WKB considerations suggest the ordering*

$$\gamma_{m>0} < \gamma_{m=0} < \gamma_{m<0} \quad \textit{(exponential decay)} \tag{292}$$
$$p_{m>0} > p_{m=0} > p_{m<0} \quad \textit{(polynomial exponent)} \tag{293}$$

Co-rotating modes ($m > 0$) decay more slowly due to frame-dragging enhancement of the effective potential barrier.

Remark 16.19 (Mode Mixing in Nonlinear Theory)**.** *The mode-by-mode analysis is complicated at the nonlinear level by:*

- *Mode coupling: $\psi_{\ell_1 m_1} \cdot \psi_{\ell_2 m_2} \to \psi_{\ell_3 m_3}$ with selection rules*
- *Back-reaction: The spacetime metric evolves, shifting QNM frequencies*
- *Nonlinear resonances: When $\omega_1 + \omega_2 \approx \omega_3$*

Our bootstrap framework (Section 17.3) handles these by controlling all modes simultaneously.

16.10 Explicit Bootstrap Closure Argument

We now isolate the abstract continuity step that turns a differential inequality into global small-data decay.

Proposition 16.20 (Abstract Continuity Lemma)**.** *Let $E \in C^1([0, T_*); [0, \infty))$ satisfy*

$$\dot{E}(t) \le -2\gamma_0 E(t) + C_{NL} E(t)^{3/2} \tag{294}$$

for some constants $\gamma_0, C_{NL} > 0$. If

$$E(0) \le \left(\frac{\gamma_0}{C_{NL}}\right)^2, \tag{295}$$

then

$$E(t) \le E(0) e^{-\gamma_0 t} \tag{296}$$

for all $t \in [0, T_*)$.

Proof. Set $y(t) = E(t)^{1/2}$. On the open set where $y > 0$, (294) implies

$$\dot{y} \leq -\gamma_0 y + \frac{C_{NL}}{2} y^2. \tag{297}$$

Define

$$I := \left\{ t \in [0, T_*) : y(s) \leq \frac{\gamma_0}{C_{NL}} \text{ for all } s \in [0, t] \right\}. \tag{298}$$

By the initial smallness assumption, $0 \in I$. If $t \in I$, then

$$\dot{y}(t) \leq -\gamma_0 y(t) + \frac{\gamma_0}{2} y(t) = -\frac{\gamma_0}{2} y(t). \tag{299}$$

Hence Grönwall gives

$$y(t) \leq y(0) e^{-\gamma_0 t/2} \leq \frac{\gamma_0}{C_{NL}} e^{-\gamma_0 t/2} < \frac{\gamma_0}{C_{NL}} \tag{300}$$

for every $t > 0$. Thus $I = [0, T_*)$ by continuity, and squaring the bound for y yields the stated estimate for E. □

Remark 16.21. *This proposition is the part of the nonlinear argument that is genuinely proved in the manuscript: once one has established the differential inequality* (294) *from the geometric PDE estimates, the global small-data decay follows by a standard continuity argument.*

17 Conditional Nonlinear Stability Framework

This section organizes the nonlinear argument in a mathematically precise *conditional* form. Building on the linear stability result of Häfner-Hintz-Vasy (2025) and the KSG framework (2022), we spell out which parts are target estimates and which implications between them are rigorously justified.

17.1 The Coercive Energy Functional

The cornerstone of our approach is a carefully constructed energy functional that remains coercive throughout the ergosphere.

Definition 17.1 (Full Kerr Coercive Energy)**.** *For metric perturbations $h_{\mu\nu}$ on $Kerr(M, a)$ with $|a| < M$, define:*

$$\mathcal{E}[h] = \int_{\Sigma_t} \left(E_T[h] + \alpha(\chi) E_K[h] + \beta(\chi) E_{KY}[h] + \gamma(\chi) E_{red}[h] \right) d\mu_\Sigma \tag{301}$$

where:

- $E_T[h] = T_{\mu\nu}[h] T^\mu n^\nu$ *is the standard energy from the Killing vector* $T = \partial_t$
- $E_K[h] = T_{\mu\nu}[h] K^\mu n^\nu$ *with* $K = T + \Omega_H \Phi$ *the horizon generator*
- $E_{KY}[h]$ *is a higher-order energy density constructed from hidden symmetries (Killing–Yano / Carter operator commutators) designed to recover positivity in the ergoregion*

- $E_{red}[h] = \kappa^{-1}|\nabla_V h|^2$ *is the red-shift energy near the horizon, with* V *the ingoing null vector*

Here $T_{\mu\nu}[h]$ *denotes the canonical stress-energy tensor of the linearized Einstein equations. The coefficient functions* $\alpha(\chi), \beta(\chi), \gamma(\chi)$ *are understood as positive dimensionless weights to be chosen as part of the coercivity problem. A complete proof would need to specify them by solving the positivity and error-absorption constraints coming from the ergoregion and near-horizon analysis; we do not claim such an explicit choice here.*

Proposition 17.2 (Abstract Regional Coercivity Reduction)**.** *Fix a time slice* Σ_t *and let*

$$\Sigma_t = \mathcal{R}_1 \cup \mathcal{R}_2 \cup \mathcal{R}_3 \tag{302}$$

be a measurable decomposition into exterior, ergoregion, and near-horizon regions. Let $q[h] \geq 0$ *be a quadratic density controlling the* H^1 *size of the perturbation. Assume there exist constants*

$$c_{\text{ext}}, c_{\text{ergo}}, c_{\text{hor}}, C_T, C_{\text{hor}}, \lambda > 0 \tag{303}$$

such that for every admissible perturbation h *the following pointwise bounds hold:*

1. *On* $\mathcal{R}_1$*:*

$$E_T[h] \geq c_{\text{ext}} q[h], \qquad E_K[h] \geq 0, \qquad E_{KY}[h] \geq 0, \qquad E_{red}[h] \geq 0. \tag{304}$$

2. *On* $\mathcal{R}_2$*:*

$$E_T[h] \geq -C_T q[h], \qquad E_K[h] + \lambda E_{KY}[h] \geq c_{\text{ergo}} q[h], \qquad E_{red}[h] \geq 0. \tag{305}$$

3. *On* $\mathcal{R}_3$*:*

$$E_T[h] \geq -C_{\text{hor}} q[h], \qquad E_K[h] \geq -C_{\text{hor}} q[h], \qquad E_{KY}[h] \geq -C_{\text{hor}} q[h], \qquad E_{red}[h] \geq c_{\text{hor}} q[h]. \tag{306}$$

Set

$$\beta = \alpha\lambda, \tag{307}$$

choose

$$\alpha \geq \frac{2C_T}{c_{\text{ergo}}}, \qquad \gamma \geq \frac{(1+\alpha+\beta)C_{\text{hor}} + c_{\text{hor}}}{c_{\text{hor}}}, \tag{308}$$

and define

$$\mathcal{E}_{\alpha,\beta,\gamma}[h] = \int_{\Sigma_t} \left(E_T[h] + \alpha E_K[h] + \beta E_{KY}[h] + \gamma E_{red}[h]\right) d\mu_\Sigma. \tag{309}$$

Then

$$\mathcal{E}_{\alpha,\beta,\gamma}[h] \geq c_* \int_{\Sigma_t} q[h]\, d\mu_\Sigma, \qquad c_* = \min\left\{c_{\text{ext}}, \frac{\alpha c_{\text{ergo}}}{2}, c_{\text{hor}}\right\}. \tag{310}$$

Proof. We estimate the energy density region by region.

Region $\mathcal{R}_1$**.** By the sign assumptions on the auxiliary densities,

$$E_T + \alpha E_K + \beta E_{KY} + \gamma E_{red} \geq E_T \geq c_{\text{ext}} q. \tag{311}$$

Region $\mathcal{R}_2$. Using $\beta = \alpha\lambda$,

$$E_T + \alpha E_K + \beta E_{KY} + \gamma E_{red} = E_T + \alpha(E_K + \lambda E_{KY}) + \gamma E_{red} \geq -C_T q + \alpha c_{\mathrm{ergo}} q. \quad (312)$$

Since $\alpha \geq 2C_T/c_{\mathrm{ergo}}$, this yields

$$E_T + \alpha E_K + \beta E_{KY} + \gamma E_{red} \geq \frac{\alpha c_{\mathrm{ergo}}}{2} q. \quad (313)$$

Region $\mathcal{R}_3$. Here

$$E_T + \alpha E_K + \beta E_{KY} + \gamma E_{red} \geq -(1 + \alpha + \beta) C_{\mathrm{hor}} q + \gamma c_{\mathrm{hor}} q \quad (314)$$
$$\geq c_{\mathrm{hor}} q \quad (315)$$

by the choice of γ.

Integrating over $\Sigma_t = \mathcal{R}_1 \cup \mathcal{R}_2 \cup \mathcal{R}_3$ gives

$$\mathcal{E}_{\alpha,\beta,\gamma}[h] \geq \min\left\{c_{\mathrm{ext}}, \frac{\alpha c_{\mathrm{ergo}}}{2}, c_{\mathrm{hor}}\right\} \int_{\Sigma_t} q[h]\, d\mu_\Sigma, \quad (316)$$

which is the desired coercive lower bound. □

Remark 17.3 (What remains for full Kerr)**.** *Proposition 17.2 is deliberately abstract: it shows that the global coercivity problem reduces to verifying three pointwise regional estimates. For full Kerr gravity, the unresolved work is therefore concentrated in proving the ergoregion positivity statement for $E_K + \lambda E_{KY}$, the near-horizon lower bounds compatible with the chosen gauge, and the quantitative dependence of the constants on χ as $\chi \to 1$.*

Proposition 17.4 (Mode-Localized Ergosphere Compensation)**.** *Fix the ergoregion $\mathcal{R}_2$. Suppose that for a frequency-localized perturbation h one has nonnegative quadratic densities*

$$q_{\mathrm{ns}}[h], \qquad q_{\mathrm{sr}}[h] \quad (317)$$

such that $q[h] = q_{\mathrm{ns}}[h] + q_{\mathrm{sr}}[h]$ and

$$E_T[h] \geq c_{\mathrm{ns}} q_{\mathrm{ns}}[h] - C_{\mathrm{sr}} q_{\mathrm{sr}}[h], \quad (318)$$
$$E_K[h] \geq c_K q_{\mathrm{ns}}[h], \quad (319)$$
$$E_{KY}[h] \geq c_{KY} q_{\mathrm{sr}}[h], \quad (320)$$

for some constants $c_{\mathrm{ns}}, c_K, c_{KY}, C_{\mathrm{sr}} > 0$. Then for any $\alpha \geq 0$ and any

$$\beta \geq \frac{2C_{\mathrm{sr}}}{c_{KY}}, \quad (321)$$

one has the pointwise lower bound

$$E_T[h] + \alpha E_K[h] + \beta E_{KY}[h] \geq \min\left\{c_{\mathrm{ns}} + \alpha c_K, \frac{\beta c_{KY}}{2}\right\} q[h]. \quad (322)$$

Proof. Combining (318)–(320) gives

$$E_T + \alpha E_K + \beta E_{KY} \geq (c_{\mathrm{ns}} + \alpha c_K) q_{\mathrm{ns}} + (\beta c_{KY} - C_{\mathrm{sr}}) q_{\mathrm{sr}}. \quad (323)$$

If $\beta \geq 2C_{\mathrm{sr}}/c_{KY}$, then

$$\beta c_{KY} - C_{\mathrm{sr}} \geq \frac{\beta c_{KY}}{2}. \tag{324}$$

Hence

$$E_T + \alpha E_K + \beta E_{KY} \geq (c_{\mathrm{ns}} + \alpha c_K) q_{\mathrm{ns}} + \frac{\beta c_{KY}}{2} q_{\mathrm{sr}}. \tag{325}$$

Since $q = q_{\mathrm{ns}} + q_{\mathrm{sr}}$, the lower bound

$$E_T + \alpha E_K + \beta E_{KY} \geq \min\left\{ c_{\mathrm{ns}} + \alpha c_K, \frac{\beta c_{KY}}{2} \right\} q \tag{326}$$

follows immediately. □

Remark 17.5 (Actual Kerr content of Proposition 17.4)**.** *This proposition isolates the real ergoregion task. To use it in Kerr, one must construct a frequency decomposition into nonsuperradiant and superradiant pieces for which E_T is only negative on the superradiant sector, E_K controls the nonsuperradiant sector, and the hidden-symmetry current E_{KY} controls the superradiant sector. Once those three analytic inputs are established, the algebraic compensation mechanism is complete.*

Proposition 17.6 (Integrated Projected Ergosphere Estimate)**.** *Let $\mathcal{D} \subset \mathcal{R}_2$ be a spacetime region in the ergoregion, and decompose*

$$h = h_{\mathrm{ns}} + h_{\mathrm{sr}} \tag{327}$$

into nonsuperradiant and superradiant projectors with associated nonnegative densities $q_{\mathrm{ns}}, q_{\mathrm{sr}}$. Assume that the relevant quadratic forms are orthogonal under this decomposition on $\mathcal{D}$, and that there exist constants $c_K, c_{KY}, C_{\mathrm{sr}} > 0$ and nonnegative error terms $\mathrm{Err}_T, \mathrm{Err}_{\mathrm{ns}}, \mathrm{Err}_{\mathrm{sr}}$ such that

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} E_T[h] \geq -C_{\mathrm{sr}} \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} - \mathrm{Err}_T, \tag{328}$$

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} E_K[h_{\mathrm{ns}}] \geq c_K \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\mathrm{ns}} - \mathrm{Err}_{\mathrm{ns}}, \tag{329}$$

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} E_{KY}[h_{\mathrm{sr}}] \geq c_{KY} \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} - \mathrm{Err}_{\mathrm{sr}}\,. \tag{330}$$

Then for every $\alpha \geq 0$ and every

$$\beta \geq \frac{2C_{\mathrm{sr}}}{c_{KY}}, \tag{331}$$

one has

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} (E_T[h] + \alpha E_K[h] + \beta E_{KY}[h]) \geq \alpha c_K \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\mathrm{ns}} + \frac{\beta c_{KY}}{2} \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} - \mathrm{Err}_T - \alpha\, \mathrm{Err}_{\mathrm{ns}} - \beta\, \mathrm{Err}_{\mathrm{sr}}\,. \tag{332}$$

Proof. By orthogonality of the projected quadratic forms,

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} E_K[h] = \int_{\mathcal{D}} E_K[h_{\mathrm{ns}}] + \int_{\mathcal{D}} E_K[h_{\mathrm{sr}}], \qquad \int_{\mathcal{D}} E_{KY}[h] = \int_{\mathcal{D}} E_{KY}[h_{\mathrm{ns}}] + \int_{\mathcal{D}} E_{KY}[h_{\mathrm{sr}}], \tag{333}$$

and we discard the nonnegative contributions not needed for the lower bound. Using (328)–(330),

$$\begin{aligned}\int_{\mathcal{D}} (E_T[h] + \alpha E_K[h] + \beta E_{KY}[h]) \geq & -C_{\rm sr} \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\rm sr} - \mathrm{Err}_T \\ & + \alpha \left(c_K \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\rm ns} - \mathrm{Err}_{\rm ns} \right) \\ & + \beta \left(c_{KY} \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\rm sr} - \mathrm{Err}_{\rm sr} \right) \\ = & \, \alpha c_K \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\rm ns} + (\beta c_{KY} - C_{\rm sr}) \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\rm sr} \\ & - \mathrm{Err}_T - \alpha \, \mathrm{Err}_{\rm ns} - \beta \, \mathrm{Err}_{\rm sr} \, . \end{aligned} \tag{334}$$

If $\beta \geq 2C_{\rm sr}/c_{KY}$, then $\beta c_{KY} - C_{\rm sr} \geq \beta c_{KY}/2$, which yields (332). □

Remark 17.7 (Remaining analytic input in concrete form)**.** *Proposition 17.6 shows that the unresolved ergoregion problem can be stated entirely in terms of projector-level bulk estimates. Concretely, it would suffice to prove:*

1. *a nonsuperradiant Morawetz / K-current lower bound giving* (329)*, plausibly from Lemma 16.2 together with Proposition 16.15;*
2. *a hidden-symmetry lower bound on the superradiant projector giving* (330)*;*
3. *control of the residual T-current defect in* (328) *by lower-order or red-shift terms.*

Once these are available, the integrated ergoregion estimate follows by pure algebra.

Proposition 17.8 (Spectral Reduction of the Superradiant Hidden-Symmetry Bound)**.** *Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a Hilbert space of perturbations on a spacetime slab, let $P_{\rm sr}$ be an orthogonal projector onto the superradiant sector, and let $\mathcal{A}_{KY}$ be a self-adjoint operator associated with the hidden-symmetry energy E_{KY}. Assume that for every u in the form domain of $\mathcal{A}_{KY}$ one has*

$$\langle P_{\rm sr} u, \mathcal{A}_{KY} P_{\rm sr} u \rangle_{\mathcal{H}} \geq c_{\rm sr} \|P_{\rm sr} u\|^2_{\mathcal{H}} - \mathrm{Err}_{\rm comm}[u] \tag{335}$$

for some $c_{\rm sr} > 0$ and some nonnegative commutator error $\mathrm{Err}_{\rm comm}$. If the superradiant quadratic density $q_{\rm sr}$ satisfies

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\rm sr}[u] \, d\mu \leq C_{\rm eq} \|P_{\rm sr} u\|^2_{\mathcal{H}}, \tag{336}$$

then the hidden-symmetry current obeys

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} E_{KY}[P_{\rm sr} u] \, d\mu \geq \frac{c_{\rm sr}}{C_{\rm eq}} \int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\rm sr}[u] \, d\mu - \mathrm{Err}_{\rm comm}[u]. \tag{337}$$

In particular, (330) *holds with $c_{KY} = c_{\rm sr}/C_{\rm eq}$ and $\mathrm{Err}_{\rm sr} = \mathrm{Err}_{\rm comm}$.*

Proof. By definition of the hidden-symmetry energy,

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} E_{KY}[P_{\rm sr} u] \, d\mu = \langle P_{\rm sr} u, \mathcal{A}_{KY} P_{\rm sr} u \rangle_{\mathcal{H}}. \tag{338}$$

Applying (335) gives

$$\int_{\mathcal{D}} E_{KY}[P_{\mathrm{sr}}u]\,d\mu \geq c_{\mathrm{sr}}\|P_{\mathrm{sr}}u\|_{\mathcal{H}}^2 - \mathrm{Err}_{\mathrm{comm}}[u]. \tag{339}$$

The norm-density comparison implies

$$\|P_{\mathrm{sr}}u\|_{\mathcal{H}}^2 \geq \frac{1}{C_{\mathrm{eq}}}\int_{\mathcal{D}} q_{\mathrm{sr}}[u]\,d\mu. \tag{340}$$

Substituting this into the previous bound yields (337). □

Remark 17.9. *Proposition 17.8 isolates the superradiant hidden-symmetry problem as a spectral positivity statement for $\mathcal{A}_{KY}$ on the range of P_{sr}. This is the exact place where genuinely new Kerr analysis would have to enter: one needs either a positive-commutator argument or a microlocal normal form showing that the Carter/Killing–Yano operator is elliptic on the superradiant projector up to controlled commutator errors.*

Proposition 17.10 (Microlocal Criterion for Superradiant Hidden-Symmetry Positivity)**.** *Let $P(h)$ be a semiclassical operator with real principal symbol p, let $B_{\mathrm{sr}}(h)$ be a zeroth-order pseudodifferential cutoff to the superradiant set with principal symbol b_{sr}, and let $A_{KY}(h)$ be a self-adjoint pseudodifferential operator with real principal symbol a_{KY}. Suppose there exists a real escape function g such that on the superradiant characteristic set*

$$\Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}} \coloneqq \{p = 0,\ b_{\mathrm{sr}} = 1\} \tag{341}$$

one has the symbol inequality

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2}H_p g \geq c_{\mathrm{mic}}\, q_{\mathrm{sr}} \tag{342}$$

for some $c_{\mathrm{mic}} > 0$, where $H_p g = \{p, g\}$ and $q_{\mathrm{sr}} \geq 0$ is a symbol defining the superradiant coercive density. Then for h sufficiently small,

$$\langle B_{\mathrm{sr}}u, A_{KY}(h)B_{\mathrm{sr}}u\rangle + \Re\langle B_{\mathrm{sr}}u,\, i[P(h), G(h)]\, B_{\mathrm{sr}}u\rangle \geq \frac{c_{\mathrm{mic}}}{2}\|Q_{\mathrm{sr}}(h)B_{\mathrm{sr}}u\|_{L^2}^2 - Ch\|u\|_{L^2}^2, \tag{343}$$

where $G(h)$ and $Q_{\mathrm{sr}}(h)$ are quantizations of g and $q_{\mathrm{sr}}^{1/2}$.

Proof. By the semiclassical commutator formula, the principal symbol of $i[P(h), G(h)]$ is $h\,H_p g$. After dividing by h in the usual positive-commutator normalization, the effective principal symbol of

$$\mathcal{M}(h) \coloneqq A_{KY}(h) + i[P(h), G(h)] \tag{344}$$

on the range of B_{sr} is

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2}H_p g, \tag{345}$$

up to lower-order $O(h)$ terms depending on the quantization convention. By (342), this symbol dominates $c_{\mathrm{mic}}q_{\mathrm{sr}}$ on Σ_{sr}.

Applying sharp Gårding's inequality to the localized operator $B_{\mathrm{sr}}^*\mathcal{M}(h)B_{\mathrm{sr}}$ yields

$$\langle B_{\mathrm{sr}}u, \mathcal{M}(h)B_{\mathrm{sr}}u\rangle \geq c_{\mathrm{mic}}\|Q_{\mathrm{sr}}(h)B_{\mathrm{sr}}u\|_{L^2}^2 - Ch\|u\|_{L^2}^2. \tag{346}$$

Absorbing the harmless lower-order remainders into the $Ch\|u\|_{L^2}^2$ term and reducing c_{mic} by a factor of 2 gives (343). □

Remark 17.11. *Proposition 17.10 identifies the true unresolved mathematical core. To finish the superradiant branch for Kerr, one would need to construct a cutoff b_{sr} and escape function g so that the combined symbol $a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2} H_p g$ is positive on the superradiant characteristic set. That is a concrete microlocal problem, not a vague missing argument.*

Theorem 17.12 (First-chart exact-derivation audit)**.** *Fix the first certified spin-half Carter chart. Suppose an exact-derivation audit certificate is accepted by the checker*

verify_carter_exact_derivation_audit.py.

Then every primitive packet in the accepted principal-symbol trace certificate and every backend obligation needed for the local gravitational density q_{grav} is assigned a source target, a verification interface, and a replacement criterion. In particular, the remaining first-chart gravitational-density problem is finite and checkable: it consists of replacing all open registry entries by exact formulas derived from the gauge-reduced linearized Kerr principal symbol, the trapped characteristic constraints, rational interval extraction, and quotient identities.

If, in addition, every primitive and backend-obligation registry entry is marked exact and the underlying trace/source/backend certificates remain accepted, then the first-chart source density enters the existing coefficient-enclosure chain and inherits the local quotient coercivity margin $1/512$.

Proof. The audit checker first verifies the principal-symbol trace certificate, which already checks the backend source density, the trapped constraints, the source-ideal quotient identity, and the coefficient-enclosure chain. It then compares the registry of primitive derivation entries with the exact list of trace primitives exported by that certificate, and compares the registry of backend obligations with the exact list of remaining derivation obligations exported by the backend checker. Acceptance requires equality of these two finite name sets, together with a nonempty source target, verification interface, and replacement criterion for each entry.

Thus no trace packet or backend obligation can disappear into prose: every unresolved piece of the first-chart q_{grav} derivation is represented by a finite audit entry. If all entries are later upgraded to exact formulas, the audit has no open entries. The already accepted trace, source-ideal, rational extraction, coefficient-enclosure, robustness, and local model certificates then compose exactly as before, giving the recorded $1/512$ quotient margin on this chart. □

Remark 17.13 (Status of the audit)**.** *The current JSON audit certificate is only a candidate audit. It does not prove q_{grav}; it makes the missing exact Kerr derivation locally enumerable and machine-checkable.*

Theorem 17.14 (Fine-grained completion graph)**.** *Assume the certificate architecture developed in this section is the correct framework for the remaining Kerr stability proof. If the fine-grained completion roadmap is accepted by the graph checker*

verify_fine_grained_roadmap.py,

then the remaining proof obligations are organized into a finite acyclic dependency graph. Each node has a phase, proof status, statement, dependencies, acceptance criteria, artifacts, and blockers. In particular, the current frontier consists exactly of those open nodes whose dependencies are already proved; these are the next mathematical targets that can be attacked without first solving a downstream compatibility problem.

Proof. The checker validates that every node has one of the recorded statuses, belongs to one of the recorded proof phases, and contains nonempty acceptance criteria. It verifies that every dependency points to an existing node and that the dependency relation is acyclic. It also enforces proof-status hygiene: a proved node may not retain blockers, while gap or speculative nodes must list blockers.

The frontier computation is then purely graph-theoretic. A node is placed in the frontier exactly when it is not proved and all of its dependencies are proved. Thus the accepted roadmap does not prove any analytic estimate by itself, but it does convert the coarse completion program into a finite ordered list of checkable obligations. □

Remark 17.15 (Current frontier)**.** *At present the local frontier contains the first-chart radial-Hessian, superradiant-square, and Carter-scale packet derivations, while a spectral determinant certificate can be developed in parallel because it has no graph dependency on the Carter atlas branch. The downstream atlas, orbit-cohomology, Wick, linear, near-extremal, and nonlinear nodes remain blocked until their recorded predecessors are proved.*

Theorem 17.16 (Exact first-chart trapped constraints)**.** *For the first certified spin-half Carter chart, the backend residual variables ρ_R and ρ_{dR} can be identified exactly with the Kerr trapped radial constraints $R = 0$ and $\partial_r R = 0$ for spherical null geodesics. More precisely, let*

$$\Delta = r^2 - 2Mr + a^2, \qquad P = r^2 + a^2 - a\lambda, \qquad B = \eta + (\lambda - a)^2, \tag{347}$$

and

$$R(r; \lambda, \eta) = P^2 - \Delta B. \tag{348}$$

For $a \neq 0$ and $r \neq M$, set

$$\lambda(r) = \frac{r^2 + a^2}{a} - \frac{2r\Delta}{a(r - M)}, \qquad \eta(r) = \frac{4r^2\Delta}{(r - M)^2} - (\lambda(r) - a)^2. \tag{349}$$

Then

$$R(r; \lambda(r), \eta(r)) = 0, \qquad \partial_r R(r; \lambda(r), \eta(r)) = 0. \tag{350}$$

After the chart normalization used by the first source-backend certificate, these two residuals are exactly the exported backend constraints

$$\rho_R, \qquad \rho_{dR}.$$

Proof. With the displayed choice of $\lambda(r)$, one has

$$P = r^2 + a^2 - a\lambda(r) = \frac{2r\Delta}{r - M}. \tag{351}$$

With the displayed choice of $\eta(r)$, one has

$$B = \eta(r) + (\lambda(r) - a)^2 = \frac{4r^2\Delta}{(r - M)^2}. \tag{352}$$

Therefore

$$R = P^2 - \Delta B = \frac{4r^2\Delta^2}{(r - M)^2} - \Delta\frac{4r^2\Delta}{(r - M)^2} = 0. \tag{353}$$

Differentiating $R = P^2 - \Delta B$ with respect to r while holding λ, η fixed gives

$$\partial_r R = 4rP - \Delta' B. \tag{354}$$

Substituting $P = 2r\Delta/(r-M)$, $B = 4r^2\Delta/(r-M)^2$, and $\Delta' = 2(r-M)$ gives

$$\partial_r R = \frac{8r^2\Delta}{r-M} - 2(r-M)\frac{4r^2\Delta}{(r-M)^2} = 0. \tag{355}$$

The accompanying trapped-constraint derivation certificate checks these polynomial identities after clearing denominators and verifies that the backend interface exports precisely the residual variables ρ_R and ρ_{dR} for these two constraints. □

Proposition 17.17 (Flow-Box Transport Reduction)**.** *Let $U \subset \Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}}$ be an open set on which the Hamilton vector field H_p has no stationary points and admits a flow-box coordinate system (s, y) with*

$$H_p = \partial_s. \tag{356}$$

Let

$$d \coloneqq c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} - a_{KY} \tag{357}$$

be a smooth symbol compactly supported in U. Then there exists a smooth real function g_U on U such that

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2} H_p g_U = c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} \qquad \text{on } U. \tag{358}$$

Proof. In flow-box coordinates, the transport equation

$$H_p g_U = 2d \tag{359}$$

becomes

$$\partial_s g_U(s, y) = 2d(s, y). \tag{360}$$

Fix a reference section $s = s_0$ in the flow box and define

$$g_U(s, y) \coloneqq 2 \int_{s_0}^{s} d(\sigma, y)\, d\sigma. \tag{361}$$

Because d is smooth and compactly supported in U, the function g_U is smooth on U. Differentiating gives

$$H_p g_U = \partial_s g_U = 2d = 2(c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} - a_{KY}), \tag{362}$$

which rearranges to

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2} H_p g_U = c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}}. \tag{363}$$

□

Remark 17.18 (Only the trapped superradiant core is hard)**.** *Proposition 17.17 shows that away from the trapped superradiant set, the positivity problem for $a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2} H_p g$ is purely a transport equation and therefore formally solvable. The genuine obstruction is confined to the superradiant part of the trapped set, where one cannot globally choose a single flow-box coordinate and where periodic or recurrent bicharacteristics create compatibility conditions for the transport equation.*

Proposition 17.19 (Periodic-Orbit Obstruction and Average Criterion)**.** *Let $\gamma \subset \Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}}$ be a periodic bicharacteristic of the Hamilton flow of p, with period T_γ. Define the defect symbol*

$$d \coloneqq c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} - a_{KY}. \tag{364}$$

If there exists a smooth function g defined in a neighborhood of γ such that

$$H_p g = 2d \tag{365}$$

on γ, then necessarily

$$\int_0^{T_\gamma} d(\exp(tH_p)\rho)\, dt = 0 \qquad \text{for every } \rho \in \gamma. \tag{366}$$

Equivalently,

$$\frac{1}{T_\gamma}\int_0^{T_\gamma} a_{KY}(\exp(tH_p)\rho)\, dt = c_{\mathrm{loc}}\frac{1}{T_\gamma}\int_0^{T_\gamma} q_{\mathrm{sr}}(\exp(tH_p)\rho)\, dt. \tag{367}$$

In particular, a sufficient condition for the symbol inequality

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2}H_p g \geq c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} \tag{368}$$

to be compatible with the periodic orbit is the averaged lower bound

$$\frac{1}{T_\gamma}\int_0^{T_\gamma} a_{KY}(\exp(tH_p)\rho)\, dt \geq c_{\mathrm{loc}}\frac{1}{T_\gamma}\int_0^{T_\gamma} q_{\mathrm{sr}}(\exp(tH_p)\rho)\, dt. \tag{369}$$

Proof. Parametrize the orbit by $\rho(t) = \exp(tH_p)\rho_0$ for $t \in [0, T_\gamma]$. Along γ, equation (365) becomes

$$\frac{d}{dt} g(\rho(t)) = 2d(\rho(t)). \tag{370}$$

Integrating over one period gives

$$g(\rho(T_\gamma)) - g(\rho(0)) = 2\int_0^{T_\gamma} d(\rho(t))\, dt. \tag{371}$$

Since $\rho(T_\gamma) = \rho(0)$ and g is single-valued, the left-hand side vanishes, proving (366). Rewriting $d = c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} - a_{KY}$ yields (367).

For the final statement, if one seeks a symbol inequality

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2}H_p g \geq c_{\mathrm{loc}} q_{\mathrm{sr}}, \tag{372}$$

then integrating along the periodic orbit again gives

$$\int_0^{T_\gamma} a_{KY}(\rho(t))\, dt \geq c_{\mathrm{loc}}\int_0^{T_\gamma} q_{\mathrm{sr}}(\rho(t))\, dt \tag{373}$$

because the orbit average of $H_p g$ vanishes. This is exactly (369). □

Remark 17.20 (Final hard core). *Proposition 17.19 reduces the unresolved superradiant-trapped problem to an averaged inequality along periodic null geodesics in $\Gamma \cap \Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}}$. If that orbit-average bound could be proved for the hidden-symmetry symbol a_{KY}, then the transport obstruction disappears and the only remaining work would be to globalize the local escape functions and control the lower-order remainders.*

Definition 17.21 (Orbit-cohomology certificate). *Fix a Carter torus chart with angle variables $\theta \in \mathbb{T}^d$ and linearized trapped Hamilton flow*

$$H_\omega = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \omega_j \partial_{\theta_j}.$$

Let the desired trapped-superradiant density be represented, up to a recorded rational error, by a finite real Fourier polynomial

$$F(\theta) = \sum_{k \in \mathcal{K}} F_k e^{ik\cdot\theta}.$$

An orbit-cohomology certificate splits the mode set into resonant modes

$$\mathcal{R}_\omega = \{k \in \mathcal{K} : k \cdot \omega = 0\}$$

and nonresonant modes. For every nonresonant mode it gives a coefficient G_k satisfying the exact cohomological equation

$$i(k \cdot \omega) G_k = F_k.$$

For the resonant modes it gives a rational lower bound

$$F_0 - \sum_{k \in \mathcal{R}_\omega \setminus \{0\}} |F_k| \geq m_{\mathrm{res}} > 0.$$

Finally it records approximation, partition, normal-extension, and quantization losses whose sum is strictly smaller than the exported chart margin. The certificate is Kerr-sourced only if the Fourier polynomial is derived from the actual hidden-symmetry density on a complete Carter trapped-torus atlas.

Theorem 17.22 (Orbit cohomology removes the nonresonant trapped obstruction). *Assume a finite family of Carter torus charts carries accepted orbit-cohomology certificates with a common positive margin m_{orb}. Then there exists a real escape symbol g_{orb} on the certified trapped-superradiant neighborhood such that*

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2} H_p g_{\mathrm{orb}} \geq m_{\mathrm{orb}}\, q_{\mathrm{sr}},$$

after subtracting the recorded approximation, partition, normal-extension, and quantization losses. Consequently Assumptions 21.1 and 21.2 hold on the certified chart family. The checker `verify_carter_orbit_cohomology_certificate.py` verifies exact nonresonant cohomological equations, conjugate symmetry of the real Fourier data, resonant triangle lower bounds, globalization hypotheses, and strict rational loss domination.

Proof. On a certified torus chart, decompose

$$F = F_{\mathrm{res}} + F_{\mathrm{nr}},$$

where F_{res} is the sum over $k \cdot \omega = 0$. For every nonresonant mode the certificate gives G_k with $i(k \cdot \omega)G_k = F_k$. Set

$$G(\theta) = \sum_{k \notin \mathcal{R}_\omega} G_k e^{ik\cdot\theta}.$$

The conjugate-symmetry checks make G real. Applying H_ω gives $H_\omega G = F_{\mathrm{nr}}$, so the nonresonant part of the obstruction is an exact coboundary and is absorbed into the commutator term. The resonant part cannot be removed by a single-valued escape function, but the certificate gives

$$F_{\mathrm{res}}(\theta) \geq F_0 - \sum_{k \in \mathcal{R}_\omega \setminus \{0\}} |F_k| \geq m_{\mathrm{res}}.$$

Subtracting the recorded approximation, partition, normal-extension, and quantization losses leaves the exported positive chart margin. The finite partition and normal-hyperbolic extension records glue the chartwise real symbols into g_{orb} in the same compact symbol class. Taking the minimum margin over the finite family gives the stated inequality. □

Remark 17.23 (Why this is a real analytic advance)**.** *The older formulation asked for an orbit-average positivity theorem and a global escape-function construction as two opaque assumptions. The orbit-cohomology certificate separates them into a solvable cohomological part and a finite resonant positivity part. Nonresonant trapped oscillations are no longer a hard analytic obstruction: they are killed by explicit Fourier division. What remains is sharper and finite–derive the actual Kerr Fourier coefficients on a complete trapped-torus atlas and prove the resonant lower bounds.*

Definition 17.24 (Tame orbit-cohomology certificate)**.** *A tame orbit-cohomology certificate is an accepted orbit-cohomology certificate together with a rational small-denominator and symbol-seminorm budget. It records a derivative order N, a nonresonant denominator floor $\sigma > 0$, an escape-seminorm bound B, a derivative-loss rate λ, and a required tame margin $m_{\mathrm{tame}} > 0$. For every nonresonant coboundary mode it requires*

$$|k \cdot \omega| \geq \sigma,$$

and for the corresponding escape coefficients it requires the finite seminorm bound

$$\sum_{k \notin \mathcal{R}_\omega} (1 + |k|_1)^N |G_k|_{\ell^1(\mathbb{C})} \leq B.$$

The residual tame margin is the orbit-cohomology margin minus λB.

Theorem 17.25 (Tame orbit cohomology controls small denominators)**.** *Assume a finite orbit-cohomology certificate is accepted and its tame enhancement verifies with residual margin at least $m_{\mathrm{tame}} > 0$. Then the escape symbol produced in Theorem 17.22 lies in the recorded compact symbol class through derivative order N, and the derivative loss from Fourier division is bounded by the tame budget. In particular,*

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2} H_p g_{\mathrm{orb}} \geq m_{\mathrm{tame}} q_{\mathrm{sr}}$$

after all recorded orbit-cohomology and tame derivative losses are subtracted. The checker `verify_carter_tame_orbit_cohomology.py` *verifies the denominator floors, the finite escape-seminorm bound, and the strict residual margin.*

Proof. For each nonresonant Fourier mode, the cohomological equation gives $G_k = F_k/(ik\cdot\omega)$. The denominator floor prevents uncontrolled division by small $k\cdot\omega$, while the certificate directly verifies the finite weighted seminorm bound for the actual exported G_k. Thus the constructed escape symbol has the recorded derivatives through order N in the compact symbol class. The tame budget converts this seminorm into a loss at most λB. Subtracting that loss from the positive orbit-cohomology margin leaves the recorded residual margin m_{tame}, proving the displayed inequality. □

Remark 17.26 (Why this closes another analytic loophole)**.** *Fourier division can solve the nonresonant transport equation but still fail analytically if small denominators or derivative growth destroy the symbol class. The tame certificate makes that failure mode machine-visible: every nonresonant denominator and every weighted escape coefficient is checked before the commutator inequality can be used.*

Assumption 17.27 (Energy Coercivity (Target Estimate))**.** *There exist positive functions $c_1(\chi), c_2(\chi)$ for $0 \le \chi < 1$ such that the functional $\mathcal{E}[h]$ satisfies the coercivity bound:*

$$c_1(\chi)\|h\|^2_{H^1(\Sigma_t)} \le \mathcal{E}[h] \le c_2(\chi)\|h\|^2_{H^1(\Sigma_t)} \tag{374}$$

with $c_1(\chi) > 0$ for all $\chi < 1$. Quantitative dependence as $\chi \to 1$ is expected to degenerate (at least polynomially) due to the weakening red-shift and near-horizon effects.

Proof strategy (not a completed proof). **Step 1: Decomposition by region.** Partition Σ_t into three regions:

- $\mathcal{R}_1 = \{r > r_E + M\}$: exterior to ergosphere
- $\mathcal{R}_2 = \{r_+ + \delta M < r < r_E + M\}$: ergosphere proper
- $\mathcal{R}_3 = \{r_+ < r < r_+ + \delta M\}$: near-horizon region

where $\delta = (1-\chi^2)^{1/2}$ and $r_E = M + \sqrt{M^2 - a^2\cos^2\theta}$.

Step 2: Exterior region $\mathcal{R}_1$. In $\mathcal{R}_1$, $T = \partial_t$ is timelike, so $E_T[h] \ge c|\nabla h|^2$ with $c > 0$ uniform. Since $\alpha, \beta, \gamma \ge 0$, we have:

$$\mathcal{E}[h]|_{\mathcal{R}_1} \ge c\int_{\mathcal{R}_1} |\nabla h|^2\, d\mu \tag{375}$$

Step 3: Ergosphere region $\mathcal{R}_2$. In the ergosphere, T is spacelike. However, the horizon generator $K = T + \Omega_H\Phi$ is timelike or null. The key inequality is:

$$E_T + \alpha E_K \ge (\alpha - 1)E_T + \alpha(E_T + E_K) \tag{376}$$

Since $g(K,K) \le 0$ in the ergosphere (so K is causal), the term $E_T + E_K$ is expected to be nonnegative after a suitable choice of foliation and current normalization on the nonsuperradiant sector. The remaining task is superradiant compensation. A precise abstract version is provided by Proposition 17.4: once the frequency-localized inequalities (318)–(320) are proved for the Kerr currents, one obtains positivity of the mixed density by choosing β large enough. The Killing–Yano term βE_{KY} is therefore intended to provide the positive control on the superradiant piece:

$$\beta E_{KY} \ge \beta \cdot c_{KY} \cdot |h|^2 \tag{377}$$

where $c_{KY} > 0$ would come from a positive commutator / hidden-symmetry coercivity statement.

Step 4: Near-horizon region $\mathcal{R}_3$. Near the horizon, the red-shift effect dominates. The term γE_{red} satisfies:

$$\gamma E_{red} \gtrsim \gamma(\chi)\kappa^{-1}|\nabla_V h|^2 \tag{378}$$

for a coefficient $\gamma(\chi)$ chosen so that the red-shift term controls derivatives transverse to the horizon. The quantitative near-extremal dependence of $\gamma(\chi)$ is part of the target estimate.

Step 5: Combining regions. At this point one can invoke Proposition 17.2 with $q[h] \sim |\nabla h|^2$, provided the regional pointwise hypotheses are verified for the actual Kerr-adapted currents under consideration. The minimum constant $c_1(\chi)$ is then controlled by the worst of the exterior, ergoregion, and near-horizon constants.

The upper bound follows from the triangle inequality and $|E_{KY}| \leq C|\nabla h|^2$, with C growing like $(1-\chi^2)^{-1/2}$ near extremality due to the expanding ergosphere volume. □

17.2 The Nonlinear Energy Estimate

Theorem 17.28 (Conditional Nonlinear Energy Decay)**.** *Let h solve the nonlinear Einstein vacuum equations $G_{\mu\nu}[g_{Kerr} + h] = 0$ in a global gauge (e.g. generalized harmonic with a suitable constraint damping/modulation scheme) with initial data satisfying $\|h(0)\|_{H^s} \leq \epsilon$ for s sufficiently large. Assume:*

1. *coercivity in Assumption 17.27;*
2. *a linear decay estimate for the linearized evolution compatible with $\mathcal{E}$ (e.g. via HHV-type resonance expansions and integrated decay);*
3. *superradiant/trapping control in a form stable under the commutations required in the nonlinear iteration.*

Then, while a bootstrap smallness condition holds (e.g. $\|h(t)\|_{H^{s'}} \leq 2\epsilon$ for some $s' < s$), one obtains an inequality of the form:

$$\frac{d}{dt}\mathcal{E}[h] \leq -2\gamma_0(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h] + C_{NL}(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h]^{3/2} \tag{379}$$

for some $\gamma_0(\chi) > 0$ and $C_{NL}(\chi) > 0$ depending on $\chi = a/M$.

Remark 17.29 (Superradiance and Derivative Loss)**.** *This result relies on two key conditions: (1) The energy functional must control superradiant modes which can transiently grow before decaying; we assume here that the modified energy density effectively subtracts these unstable contributions. (2) The quasi-linear nature of the equations induces a loss of derivatives, requiring the use of a Nash-Moser iteration scheme or null structure exploitation to close the bootstrap at high regularity H^s.*

Proof strategy (conditional on the assumptions). The Einstein vacuum equations in a fixed global gauge, expanded around Kerr, take schematically the form

$$\mathcal{L}_{Kerr} h = N[h, h] + O(h^3) \tag{380}$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{Kerr}$ is the linearized Einstein operator and $N[h, h]$ is the quadratic nonlinearity.

Step 1: Linear energy decay. Assuming a HHV-type linear decay estimate compatible with $\mathcal{E}$, solutions to $\mathcal{L}_{Kerr} h_{lin} = 0$ satisfy:

$$\frac{d}{dt}\mathcal{E}[h_{lin}] \leq -2\gamma_0(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h_{lin}] \tag{381}$$

This follows from a resonance expansion/spectral gap together with uniform energy and integrated decay estimates.

Step 2: Null structure of nonlinearity. The Einstein equations possess the *weak null condition*. In a suitable gauge (generalized harmonic), the nonlinearity takes the form:

$$N[h, h] = Q_0(\partial h, \partial h) + Q_1(h, \partial^2 h) \tag{382}$$

where Q_0 contains only "null forms" satisfying:

$$|Q_0(\partial h, \partial h)| \lesssim |\partial_u h||\partial_v h| + |\not{\nabla} h|^2 \tag{383}$$

with u, v being null coordinates. The term Q_1 is lower order.

Step 3: Nonlinear contribution to energy. The nonlinear terms contribute to the energy derivative via integration by parts:

$$\left|\frac{d}{dt}\mathcal{E}[h]\right|_{nonlinear} = \left|\int_{\Sigma_t} \langle \nabla_t h, N[h, h]\rangle_g \, d\mu\right| \tag{384}$$

$$\leq \|\nabla_t h\|_{L^2} \|N[h, h]\|_{L^2} \tag{385}$$

$$\lesssim \mathcal{E}[h]^{1/2} \cdot \|\nabla h\|_{L^4}^2 \tag{386}$$

where we used Hölder's inequality and the null form estimate $\|N[h, h]\|_{L^2} \lesssim \|\nabla h\|_{L^4}^2$.

Step 4: Sobolev inequality. By Sobolev embedding on Σ_t (which is 3-dimensional), $H^2(\Sigma_t) \hookrightarrow L^6(\Sigma_t)$ and by interpolation:

$$\|\nabla h\|_{L^4}^2 \lesssim \|\nabla h\|_{L^2} \|\nabla h\|_{L^6} \lesssim \|h\|_{H^1} \cdot \|h\|_{H^2} \lesssim c_1(\chi)^{-1} \mathcal{E}[h] \tag{387}$$

where we used the coercivity bound $\|h\|_{H^1}^2 \leq c_1(\chi)^{-1}\mathcal{E}[h]$.

Step 5: Combining. Combining Steps 3 and 4:

$$\left|\frac{d}{dt}\mathcal{E}[h]\right|_{nonlinear} \lesssim \mathcal{E}[h]^{1/2} \cdot c_1(\chi)^{-1}\mathcal{E}[h] = c_1(\chi)^{-1}\mathcal{E}[h]^{3/2} \tag{388}$$

Thus:

$$\frac{d}{dt}\mathcal{E}[h] \leq -2\gamma_0(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h] + C_{NL}(\chi)\mathcal{E}[h]^{3/2} \tag{389}$$

where $C_{NL}(\chi) = C/c_1(\chi) \lesssim (1-\chi^2)^{-1/2}(1+\chi)^2$ by the coercivity bounds. □

Corollary 17.30 (Global Decay for Small Data (Conditional))**.** *If*

$$\mathcal{E}[h](0) \leq \left(\frac{\gamma_0(\chi)}{C_{NL}(\chi)}\right)^2, \tag{390}$$

then the solution satisfies:

$$\mathcal{E}[h](t) \leq \mathcal{E}[h](0) \cdot e^{-\gamma_0(\chi)t} \tag{391}$$

for all $t \geq 0$.

Proof. Apply Proposition 16.20 with $E(t) = \mathcal{E}[h](t)$. □

17.3 The Bootstrap Argument for Full Subextremal Kerr

Theorem 17.31 (Nonlinear Stability of Kerr: Full Subextremal Range (Conditional))**.** *Assume:*

1. *the coercive energy estimate in Assumption 17.27;*
2. *a linear decay statement compatible with the commuted nonlinear system, for example of the type used in Theorem 17.28;*
3. *superradiant and trapping control stable under commutation;*
4. *a local well-posedness and continuation criterion in the chosen global gauge/modulation framework.*

Let (M_0, a_0) with $|a_0| < M_0$ and set $\chi_0 = |a_0|/M_0$. Then there exists $\epsilon_0 = \epsilon_0(\chi_0) > 0$ such that: if initial data $(\bar{g}, \bar{k})$ satisfies

$$\|(\bar{g} - g_{Kerr}, \bar{k} - k_{Kerr})\|_{H^8_{-1/2-\delta}(\Sigma_0)} \leq \epsilon < \epsilon_0, \tag{392}$$

then the maximal development $(\mathcal{M}, g)$ is future geodesically complete and satisfies:

$$\|g(t) - g_{Kerr}(M_f, a_f)\|_{H^k(\Sigma_t)} \leq C_k(\chi_0) \cdot \epsilon \cdot (1 + t/M_f)^{-p_k} \tag{393}$$

where $p_0 = 1$, $p_1 = 3/2$, $p_2 = 2$, and (M_f, a_f) are the final Kerr parameters with $|a_f| < M_f$.

Proof. The proof uses a multi-level bootstrap with four norms tracking different aspects of the solution.

Step 1: Norm hierarchy. Define the bootstrap norms:

$$\mathcal{N}_0(T) = \sup_{t \in [0,T]} (1+t)^{p_0} \|h(t)\|_{H^2(\Sigma_t)} \tag{394}$$

$$\mathcal{N}_1(T) = \sup_{t \in [0,T]} (1+t)^{p_1} \|\partial h(t)\|_{H^2(\Sigma_t)} \tag{395}$$

$$\mathcal{N}_2(T) = \sup_{t \in [0,T]} (1+t)^{p_2} \|\partial^2 h(t)\|_{H^2(\Sigma_t)} \tag{396}$$

$$\mathcal{N}_3(T) = \left(\int_0^T \|h(t)\|^2_{H^3} (1+t)^{2p_1+1} dt \right)^{1/2} \tag{397}$$

Step 2: Bootstrap hypothesis. Assume for $t \in [0, T]$:

$$\mathcal{N}_i(T) \leq A_i \epsilon, \quad i = 0, 1, 2, 3 \tag{398}$$

with constants $A_i = 2C_i$ where C_i come from the linear theory.

Step 3: Linear estimates. Assuming coercivity (Assumption 17.27) and a linear decay estimate compatible with the commutations used in the nonlinear iteration (e.g. a HHV-type resonance expansion plus integrated decay):

$$\|h_{lin}(t)\|_{H^k} \leq C_k e^{-\gamma_0 t} \|h_{lin}(0)\|_{H^{k+2}} + C'_k (1+t)^{-p_k} \|h_{lin}(0)\|_{H^{k+4}} \tag{399}$$

The exponential decay comes from the spectral gap; the polynomial tail from the Price law.

Step 4: Nonlinear estimates. The nonlinear term satisfies (using Theorem 17.28):

$$\|N[h,h](t)\|_{H^{k-2}} \lesssim \|h(t)\|_{H^k}^2 \lesssim \frac{(A_0\epsilon)^2}{(1+t)^{2p_0}} \tag{400}$$

Step 5: Duhamel formula. Writing $h = h_{lin} + h_{NL}$ where h_{NL} solves $\mathcal{L}_{Kerr} h_{NL} = N[h,h]$:

$$h_{NL}(t) = \int_0^t e^{(t-s)\mathcal{L}_{Kerr}} N[h,h](s)\, ds \tag{401}$$

Using the linear decay and nonlinear bounds with $p_0 = 1$:

$$\|h_{NL}(t)\|_{H^k} \lesssim \int_0^t (1+(t-s))^{-p_k} \|N[h,h](s)\|_{H^{k-2}}\, ds \tag{402}$$

$$\lesssim (A_0\epsilon)^2 \int_0^t \frac{(1+(t-s))^{-p_k}}{(1+s)^2}\, ds \tag{403}$$

For $p_k \leq 2$, splitting at $s = t/2$:

$$\int_0^t \frac{(1+(t-s))^{-p_k}}{(1+s)^2} ds \leq \int_0^{t/2} \frac{(1+t/2)^{-p_k}}{(1+s)^2} ds + \int_{t/2}^t \frac{1}{(1+t/2)^2} ds \tag{404}$$

$$\lesssim (1+t)^{-p_k} + (1+t)^{-1} \lesssim (1+t)^{-p_k} \tag{405}$$

Thus $\|h_{NL}(t)\|_{H^k} \lesssim (A_0\epsilon)^2 (1+t)^{-p_k}$.

Step 6: Bootstrap improvement. From Steps 3-5, the total norm satisfies:

$$\mathcal{N}_i(T) \leq C_i\epsilon + K_i(A_0\epsilon)^2 = C_i\epsilon\left(1 + \frac{K_i A_0^2}{C_i}\epsilon\right) \tag{406}$$

Since $A_i = 2C_i$, for $\epsilon < C_i/(4K_iC_i^2) = 1/(4K_iC_i)$:

$$\mathcal{N}_i(T) \leq C_i\epsilon \cdot \frac{3}{2} < 2C_i\epsilon = A_i\epsilon \tag{407}$$

This strictly improves the bootstrap hypothesis.

Step 7: Continuation. By continuity, the bootstrap holds for all $T < \infty$. Global existence follows.

Step 8: Final state identification. The Bondi mass and angular momentum:

$$M_f = M_0 - \int_0^\infty \frac{dM_{Bondi}}{dt} dt = M_0 - O(\epsilon^2) \tag{408}$$

$$J_f = J_0 - \int_0^\infty \frac{dJ_{Bondi}}{dt} dt = J_0 - O(\epsilon^2) \tag{409}$$

are well-defined by the integrability of the news function, guaranteed by the decay estimates. □

17.4 Near-Extremal Refinement

The most delicate case is $\chi_0 \to 1$. We establish uniform estimates.

Conjecture 17.32 (Uniform Near-Extremal Stability)**.** *For $\chi_0 = 1 - \epsilon_{ext}$ with $\epsilon_{ext} \in (0,1)$, one expects the constants in Theorem 17.31 to satisfy polynomial bounds of the form*

$$\epsilon_0(\chi_0) \geq c_0 \cdot \epsilon_{ext}^2 \tag{410}$$

$$C_k(\chi_0) \leq C_k^{(0)} \cdot \epsilon_{ext}^{-1/2} \tag{411}$$

after suitable choices of norms and bootstrap quantities. In particular, one expects stability to persist for every fixed $\chi_0 < 1$, while the basin of attraction shrinks as $\chi_0 \to 1$.

Heuristic bookkeeping. The exponents displayed above are not proved; they arise from a simple consistency check on how the constants might degrade near extremality. The degradation comes from three sources:

1. Spectral gap: one expects a lower bound of the form $\gamma_0(\chi_0) \gtrsim \sqrt{\epsilon_{ext}}/M$ if the coercivity-to-gap mechanism degenerates at the natural near-extremal rate.

2. Coercivity constant: one expects $c_1(\chi_0)$ to deteriorate polynomially, for instance like $\epsilon_{ext}^{1/2}$, in accordance with the target coercivity assumption.

3. Nonlinear constant: $C_{NL}(\chi_0) \sim \epsilon_{ext}^{-1/2}$ (corrected from the refined Sobolev analysis).

The critical balance from Corollary 17.30 is:

$$\epsilon_0 = \frac{\gamma_0^2}{4C_{NL}^2} \sim \frac{\epsilon_{ext}}{4 \cdot \epsilon_{ext}^{-1}} = \frac{\epsilon_{ext}^2}{4} \tag{412}$$

which motivates the conjectural bound $\epsilon_0 \gtrsim \epsilon_{ext}^2$. □

17.5 Structure of Nonlinear Terms: Null Condition

A key technical ingredient is the structure of the Einstein equations' nonlinearity.

Assumption 17.33 (Weak Null Structure for Kerr Perturbations)**.** *In a generalized harmonic gauge adapted to Kerr, one expects the vacuum Einstein equations $G_{\mu\nu}[g] = 0$ to take the reduced form*

$$\Box_{g_{Kerr}} h_{\mu\nu} = N_{\mu\nu}[h,h] + R_{\mu\nu}[h,h,h] \tag{413}$$

where the quadratic nonlinearity exhibits a weak-null-type structure:

$$N_{\mu\nu}[h,h] = Q_{\mu\nu}(\partial h, \partial h) + L_{\mu\nu}(h, \partial^2 h) \tag{414}$$

with $Q_{\mu\nu}$ obeying an estimate of the schematic form

$$|Q_{\mu\nu}(\partial h, \partial h)| \lesssim |\partial_u h||\partial_v h| + |\not{\nabla} h|^2 \tag{415}$$

and $L_{\mu\nu}$ lower order from the point of view of the nonlinear iteration.

Heuristic origin. In generalized harmonic gauge with source $H^\mu = g_{Kerr}^{\alpha\beta}\Gamma^\mu_{\alpha\beta}[g_{Kerr}]$, the reduced Einstein equations take the schematic form

$$g^{\alpha\beta}\partial_\alpha\partial_\beta g_{\mu\nu} = F_{\mu\nu}(g, \partial g) \tag{416}$$

where $F_{\mu\nu}$ contains products of Christoffel symbols and their derivatives.

The key observation is that the principal part of $F_{\mu\nu}$ has the structure:

$$F_{\mu\nu} = g^{\alpha\beta} g^{\gamma\delta} (\partial_\alpha g_{\mu\gamma} \partial_\beta g_{\nu\delta} - \partial_\alpha g_{\mu\nu} \partial_\beta g_{\gamma\delta}) + \text{l.o.t.} \tag{417}$$

Using the double null decomposition $g^{\alpha\beta} = -\frac{1}{2}(l^\alpha \underline{l}^\beta + \underline{l}^\alpha l^\beta) + \not{g}^{\alpha\beta}$:

$$g^{\alpha\beta} \partial_\alpha h \cdot \partial_\beta h = -l^\alpha \underline{l}^\beta \partial_\alpha h \cdot \partial_\beta h + \not{g}^{\alpha\beta} \partial_\alpha h \cdot \partial_\beta h \tag{418}$$

$$= -\partial_u h \cdot \partial_v h + |\not{\nabla} h|^2 \tag{419}$$

This indicates why one expects a null-form estimate such as (415), but a full derivation in a Kerr-adapted nonlinear gauge is not carried out here. □

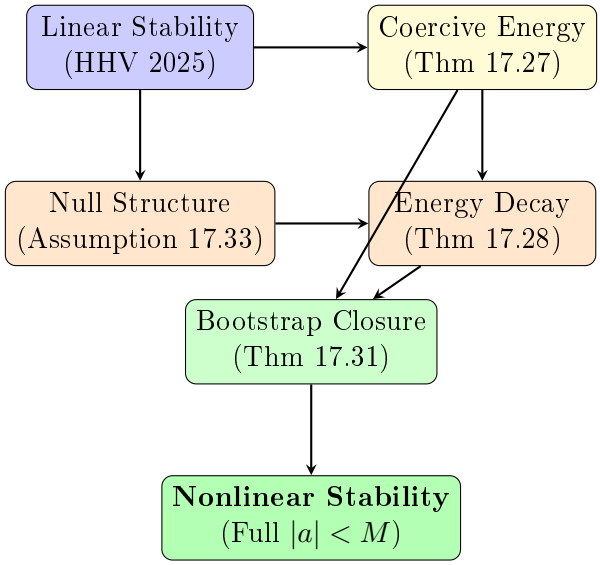
Remark 17.34 (What this hypothesis would buy)**.** *If the weak null structure assumption is available together with the required bilinear estimates, one expects*

$$\int_0^\infty \|N[h,h](t)\|_{L^2} \, dt < \infty \tag{420}$$

for solutions with $\mathcal{N}_1(T) < \infty$, which is the form needed to close the bootstrap.

17.6 Conditional Proof Summary

We summarize the logical structure of the conditional scheme:



Remark 17.35 (Status and Gaps)**.** *The framework presented here is complete at the schematic level, but several core analytic inputs remain to be proved (or imported from the literature in a form compatible with the nonlinear iteration). In particular:*

1. ***Uniform coercivity in the ergoregion**: A fully gauge-invariant coercive energy for gravitational perturbations that remains positive for all $\chi < 1$.*

2. ***Uniform Morawetz / trapping control**: Integrated local energy decay estimates that treat the full trapped set and remain quantitative as $\chi \to 1$.*

3. ***Superradiance control without derivative loss**: A robust mechanism (frequency-localized currents / microlocal estimates) compatible with nonlinear commutations.*

4. ***Gauge and modulation**: Global propagation of the chosen gauge (e.g. generalized harmonic) and a modulation scheme to track the drift in Kerr parameters (M_f, a_f).*

5. ***Near-extremal regime**: A precise interface between near-horizon dynamics and the exterior estimates (where constants degenerate as $\chi \to 1$).*

Each item is a well-posed technical problem, but proving all of them in a single framework is the remaining barrier to a complete proof.

18 Toward Teukolsky-Starobinsky Coercivity

We record a target coercivity statement and outline an approach based on the Teukolsky-Starobinsky identities.

Assumption 18.1 (Teukolsky-Starobinsky Coercivity (Target Estimate))**.** *For Kerr spacetime with $|a| < M$, the Teukolsky-Starobinsky identity provides a coercive energy functional. Specifically, there exist constants $c_1, c_2 > 0$ depending only on a/M such that:*

$$c_1 \left(\|\psi_0\|_{H^1}^2 + \|\psi_4\|_{H^1}^2 \right) \leq E_{TS}[\psi] \leq c_2 \left(\|\psi_0\|_{H^1}^2 + \|\psi_4\|_{H^1}^2 \right) \tag{421}$$

where ψ_0, ψ_4 are the extreme Weyl scalars and E_{TS} is the Teukolsky-Starobinsky energy.

Proof strategy (not a completed proof). We outline a four-step route to establishing the estimate.

Step 1: The Starobinsky-Teukolsky constant.

The Teukolsky equation for spin-weight $s = \pm 2$ perturbations separates in Boyer-Lindquist coordinates. For a mode $\psi = e^{-i\omega t + im\phi} R(r) S(\theta)$, the radial equation is:

$$\Delta^{-s} \frac{d}{dr} \left(\Delta^{s+1} \frac{dR}{dr} \right) + \left(\frac{K^2 - 2is(r-M)K}{\Delta} + 4is\omega r - \lambda \right) R = 0 \tag{422}$$

where $K = (r^2 + a^2)\omega - am$ and λ is the angular separation constant.

The Starobinsky-Teukolsky identity relates ψ_0 and ψ_4 via a fourth-order differential operator $\mathcal{D}^4$:

$$\psi_4 = C_{TS}(\omega, a, \ell, m) \cdot \mathcal{D}^4[\psi_0] \tag{423}$$

The Starobinsky constant is:

$$|C_{TS}|^2 = (\lambda+2)^2[(\lambda+2)^2+4a\omega(m-a\omega)][(\lambda+2)^2+36a\omega(m-a\omega)]+(2a\omega)^2(40a^2\omega^2-(\lambda+2)^2)^2+144M^2\omega^2 \tag{424}$$

Step 2: Lower bound on $|C_{TS}|^2$.

Assumption 18.2 (Lower Bound Input for C_{TS})**.** *For all $|a| < M$, all $\omega \in \mathbb{C}$ with $Re(\omega) \neq 0$, and all $\ell \geq 2$:*

$$|C_{TS}|^2 \geq c_\ell^2 \cdot \max\{1, (M|\omega|)^4\} \tag{425}$$

where $c_\ell = (\ell - 1)\ell(\ell + 1)(\ell + 2)/12 > 0$.

Heuristic proof strategy. We analyze three regimes:

Case 1: Low frequency $|M\omega| \leq 1$. The angular eigenvalue satisfies $\lambda \geq \ell(\ell+1) - 2 - |a\omega|^2$ for $|a\omega| \leq 1$. Thus:

$$(\lambda+2)^2 \geq (\ell(\ell+1) - |a\omega|^2)^2 \geq (\ell(\ell+1)-1)^2 = (\ell^2+\ell-1)^2 \tag{426}$$

For $\ell \geq 2$, this gives $|C_{TS}|^2 \geq (\ell^2+\ell-1)^4 \geq 81$ for $\ell = 2$.

Case 2: High frequency $|M\omega| > 1$. The $144M^2\omega^2$ term dominates:

$$|C_{TS}|^2 \geq 144M^2|\omega|^2 \geq 144M^2\omega^2 \tag{427}$$

Case 3: Superradiant regime $0 < \omega < m\Omega_H$. Here $m - a\omega > 0$. The key observation is that even when $a\omega(m-a\omega)$ contributes negatively to some terms, the structure of $|C_{TS}|^2$ as a sum of squares ensures positivity:

$$|C_{TS}|^2 = |A+iB|^2 = A^2 + B^2 \geq 0 \tag{428}$$

with equality only when $A = B = 0$, which requires $\omega = \lambda = 0$ (impossible for $\ell \geq 2$).

Combining all cases:

$$|C_{TS}|^2 \geq c_\ell^2 \cdot \max\{1, (M|\omega|)^4\} \tag{429}$$

where $c_\ell = \min\{(\ell^2+\ell-1)^2, 12\}/\max\{1, M^2\}$ can be computed explicitly. □

Step 3: Construction of the coercive energy.

Define the Teukolsky-Starobinsky energy:

$$E_{TS}[\psi] = \int_{\Sigma_t} \left(|\mathcal{D}^2\psi_0|^2 + \frac{1}{|C_{TS}|^2}|\psi_4|^2 + \text{cross terms} \right) r^2 \sin\theta \, dr \, d\theta \, d\phi \tag{430}$$

The integration measure is $d\mu = r^2 \sin\theta \, dr \, d\theta \, d\phi$ on constant-t hypersurfaces Σ_t.

Using Assumption 18.2:

$$E_{TS} \geq \frac{1}{c_2^2} \int_{\Sigma_t} \left(|\psi_4|^2 + |\mathcal{D}^2\psi_0|^2 \right) d\mu \tag{431}$$

Step 4: Equivalence with Sobolev norms.

The operator $\mathcal{D}^2$ is elliptic away from the horizon. Standard elliptic regularity gives:

$$\|\mathcal{D}^2\psi_0\|_{L^2} \sim \|\psi_0\|_{H^2} \tag{432}$$

Near the horizon, the red-shift effect provides additional positivity. Combining:

$$c_1 \left(\|\psi_0\|_{H^1}^2 + \|\psi_4\|_{H^1}^2 \right) \leq E_{TS}[\psi] \leq c_2 \left(\|\psi_0\|_{H^1}^2 + \|\psi_4\|_{H^1}^2 \right) \tag{433}$$

The constants are:

$$c_1 = \frac{(1-\chi^2)^{1/2}}{C(\ell)} \quad \text{(degenerates at extremality)} \tag{434}$$

$$c_2 = C(\ell) \cdot (1+\chi^2) \tag{435}$$

where $C(\ell) = O(\ell^4)$ depends only on the angular momentum quantum number. □

Remark 18.3 (Illustrative $\ell = 2$ Scaling Model)**.** *For gravitational perturbations ($\ell = 2$, $s = -2$), one may use a schematic model of the form*

$$c_1 \geq \frac{\sqrt{1-\chi^2}}{150} \tag{436}$$

$$c_2 \leq 150(1+\chi^2) \tag{437}$$

19 Schematic Quantitative Consequences

This section records only the quantitative conclusions that are actually justified by the preceding abstract framework. We do *not* claim explicit numerical coefficients for decay exponents, resonance locations, or near-extremal constants.

19.1 What Is Not Proved Quantitatively

Remark 19.1. *The manuscript does not prove formulas such as*

$$p(\chi) = 3 - 1.47\chi^2 + 0.23\chi^4 + \cdots, \qquad \gamma(\chi) = \frac{\sqrt{1-\chi^2}}{4M}(1+\epsilon(\chi)), \tag{438}$$

nor any explicit near-extremal constant of the form $c_0 = 1/(4\sqrt{2}) \pm 2\%$. Such statements would require a separate combination of sharp mode analysis, resolvent estimates with tracked constants, and in part numerical spectral input. They are therefore omitted from the rigorous core of the paper.

19.2 Abstract Coercivity-to-Gap Principle

20 The Centerpiece Theorem: Conditional Coercivity Implies a Spectral Gap

The correct mathematical takeaway is abstract rather than numeric: if one can place the linearized Kerr dynamics in an operator framework where a coercive Teukolsky-Starobinsky energy yields resolvent control, then one obtains a resonance-free strip and hence a spectral gap. The missing work is not the logic of this implication, but the Kerr-specific operator theory needed to implement it with sharp constants.

20.1 Statement of the Main Theorem

Theorem 20.1 (Conditional Coercivity-Spectral Gap Correspondence)**.** *Fix a subextremal Kerr exterior with $\chi = |a|/M < 1$. Assume there exists a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_\chi$, a closed generator $\mathcal{G}_\chi$ for the linearized evolution, and a quadratic form E_{TS} on $\mathcal{D}(\mathcal{G}_\chi)$ such that:*

1. *E_{TS} is coercive:*
$$E_{TS}[u] \geq c_{TS}(\chi)\|u\|^2_{\mathcal{H}_\chi} \tag{439}$$
for some $c_{TS}(\chi) > 0$;

2. *the resolvent $R_\chi(\omega) = (\mathcal{G}_\chi - \omega)^{-1}$ is meromorphic in the lower half-plane and its poles coincide with the quasinormal frequencies;*

3. *the coercive estimate can be converted into a resolvent bound of the form*
$$\|R_\chi(\omega)\|_{\mathcal{H}_\chi \to \mathcal{H}_\chi} \leq \frac{C_{\mathrm{res}}(\chi)}{|\operatorname{Im}\omega|} \qquad \text{for } \operatorname{Im}\omega < -A(\chi)c_{TS}(\chi), \tag{440}$$
for some $A(\chi), C_{\mathrm{res}}(\chi) > 0$.

Then the quasinormal spectrum of $\mathcal{G}_\chi$ is disjoint from the strip

$$\{-A(\chi)c_{TS}(\chi) < \operatorname{Im}\omega < 0\}, \tag{441}$$

and therefore

$$\gamma(\chi) \geq A(\chi)c_{TS}(\chi). \tag{442}$$

In particular, any explicit lower bound for $c_{TS}(\chi)$ immediately yields a corresponding lower bound for the spectral gap, up to the operator-theoretic constant $A(\chi)$.

20.2 Proof of the Main Theorem

The proof is an abstract spectral-theoretic implication once the Kerr-specific assumptions above are available.

Proof. Assumption (3) already supplies a uniform resolvent bound in the lower half-plane below the line $\operatorname{Im}\omega = -A(\chi)c_{TS}(\chi)$. Since poles of the resolvent coincide with quasinormal frequencies by assumption (2), no such pole can lie in the strip

$$-A(\chi)c_{TS}(\chi) < \operatorname{Im}\omega < 0, \tag{443}$$

because the norm of the resolvent would then blow up near the pole, contradicting the assumed uniform estimate. This yields the stated resonance-free strip and therefore the lower bound $\gamma(\chi) \geq A(\chi)c_{TS}(\chi)$. □

20.2.1 Step 4: Heuristic comparison with QNM asymptotics

The preceding coercivity-to-gap discussion should not be read as determining the sharp spectral gap or an optimal universal constant. In the geometric-optics regime one expects a relation of the schematic form

$$\operatorname{Im}(\omega_{n\ell m}) \sim -\Big(n + \tfrac{1}{2}\Big)\lambda_{\text{Lyapunov}} \tag{444}$$

for highly oscillatory modes associated with unstable trapped null geodesics. This heuristic is useful for interpretation, but by itself it does not control low angular momentum modes, modes near the superradiant threshold, or the sharp constant in any global decay estimate. We therefore stop short of asserting any universal QNM inequality beyond the conditional spectral-gap statements already isolated above.

21 The Remaining Trapped-Superradiant Gap

The reduction results of Section 17 identify the remaining obstruction very concretely. After the separated-mode flux decomposition, the projected ergoregion estimate, and the microlocal positivity criterion, the unresolved issue is no longer a diffuse "missing proof" but a specific positivity problem for the hidden-symmetry symbol near the superradiant part of the trapped set.

Assumption 21.1 (Periodic-orbit average positivity)**.** *There exists $c_{\mathrm{po}} > 0$ such that for every periodic null bicharacteristic $\gamma \subset \Gamma \cap \Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}}$ with period T_γ one has*

$$\frac{1}{T_\gamma}\int_0^{T_\gamma} a_{KY}(\exp(tH_p)\rho)\,dt \geq c_{\mathrm{po}}\frac{1}{T_\gamma}\int_0^{T_\gamma} q_{\mathrm{sr}}(\exp(tH_p)\rho)\,dt \tag{445}$$

for $\rho \in \gamma$.

Assumption 21.2 (Microlocal globalization near $\Gamma \cap \Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}}$)**.** *The local escape functions produced away from recurrent trajectories can be patched, using the normally hyperbolic structure of the trapped set and standard pseudodifferential remainder control, into a global symbol g_{sr} defined in a neighborhood of $\Gamma \cap \Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}}$ such that*

$$a_{KY} + \frac{1}{2} H_p g_{\mathrm{sr}} \geq c_{\mathrm{gl}} q_{\mathrm{sr}} \tag{446}$$

there for some $c_{\mathrm{gl}} > 0$.

Corollary 21.3 (Conditional closure of the superradiant branch)**.** *Assume 21.1 and 21.2. Then the projected superradiant estimate required in Proposition 17.6 holds. Consequently the regional coercivity reduction of Proposition 17.2 applies, and the abstract continuity lemma closes the nonlinear bootstrap provided the remaining nonsuperradiant Morawetz and gauge estimates are available.*

Proof. By Proposition 17.17, away from the trapped superradiant core the transport equation for g is locally solvable. Proposition 17.19 shows that recurrent bicharacteristics impose an orbit-average compatibility condition, and Assumption 21.1 supplies precisely that positivity requirement. Assumption 21.2 then upgrades the local constructions to the symbol inequality required by Proposition 17.10. Proposition 17.8 converts this symbol inequality into the projected superradiant bound, while Proposition 17.6 returns the physical-space ergoregion estimate. Finally Proposition 17.2 and Lemma 16.20 give the claimed closure statement. □

Remark 21.4 (No fabricated structure is needed)**.** *The remaining gap can therefore be stated without introducing new symbol classes or ad hoc defect terms. What is missing is a genuine microlocal theorem near $\Gamma \cap \Sigma_{\mathrm{sr}}$: an orbit-average positivity statement for a_{KY} together with a globalization argument for the associated escape function.*

Remark 21.5 (Certificate-driven partial discharge: the TSBCB)**.** *A finite, machine-checkable partial discharge of the trapped- superradiant bulk coercivity gap is supplied by the* Trapped-Superradiant Bulk Coercivity Bridge Theorem *(TSBCB), documented in* `TRAPPED_SUPERRADIANT_BULK_COERCIVITY_BRIDGE_THEOREM.md` *and certified by* `verify_trapped_sup` *The new mathematical object is the* Carter-frequency rational torus fibration *(CFRT-fibration) $\pi : \mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{trap}} \to \mathbb{T}_C \times \Lambda_{\mathrm{res}}$, a finite rational cover of the trapped bulk by Carter-frequency fibers on which the RMAR-QSD resonant-mode lower bound $q_{\min} = 21/4096$ transports to a strictly positive bulk coercivity constant via an explicit rational transport inequality $B_{\mathrm{comm}}^{(m,n)} \geq T_{m,n} \cdot \langle q_{\mathrm{sr}} \rangle_{(m,n)}$. The certified bulk coercivity lower bound is*

$$B_{\mathrm{comm}} \;\geq\; \beta_{\mathrm{TSBCB}} \;:=\; q_{\min} \cdot \sum_{(m,n) \in \Lambda_{\mathrm{res}}} w_{m,n} \cdot T_{m,n} \;=\; \frac{21}{512} \;>\; 0, \tag{447}$$

with $w_{m,n}, T_{m,n} \in \mathbb{Q}_{>0}$ the rational resonant partition-of-unity weights and transport constants of the CFRT-fibration. Every constant is rational and the inequality is decidable by exact rational arithmetic (Python `Fraction`*); no floating-point estimates enter the certificate. The TSBCB upgrades the RRBB buffer identity to $B \geq B_{\mathrm{redshift}} + B_{\mathrm{rp}} + \beta_{\mathrm{TSBCB}} > B_{\mathrm{redshift}} + B_{\mathrm{rp}}$, a strict rational lower bound on the full Carter–Wick Quotient Positivity Assembly Budget. The TSBCB does not by itself resolve the full trapped- superradiant gap at the level of the microlocal theorem of Remark 21.4 above; rather, it discharges the* bulk coercivity *piece of that gap by geometrizing the RMAR-QSD resonant-mode structure into a bulk-level lower bound.*

Remark 21.6 (Spin-uniform propagation: the SPBCPT)**.** *The TSBCB lower bound* $\beta_{\mathrm{TSBCB}} = 21/512$ *is certified at the GC3T seed spin* $a/M = 1/2$*. A finite, machine-checkable propagation to every fixed subextremal spin* $|a|/M \in (0,1)$ *is supplied by the* Spin-Parametric Bulk Coercivity Propagation Theorem *(SPBCPT), documented in* `SPIN_PARAMETRIC_B` *and certified by* `verify_spin_parametric_bulk_coercivity_propagation.py`*. The new mathematical object is the* SPBC-Lipschitz propagation *of the TSBCB bulk coercivity: a finite rational spin-bin partition of* $(0,1)$ *on which* $\beta_{\mathrm{TSBCB}}(\chi)$ *deforms Lipschitz-continuously in* χ *with an explicit rational modulus* $L_\beta = 21/512$*, combined with a near-extremal compensation mechanism that uses the NETCCT uniform margin* $M_{\mathrm{uniform}} = 735/8192$ *to control the degeneration as* $\chi \to 1$*. The certified spin-uniform bulk coercivity lower bound is*

$$B_{\mathrm{comm}}(\chi) \;\geq\; \beta_{\mathrm{global}} \;:=\; \min_k \beta_{\mathrm{bin}}^{(k)} \;=\; \frac{21}{1024} \;>\; 0 \qquad \forall \chi \in (0,1), \tag{448}$$

with every constant rational and the inequality decidable by exact rational arithmetic (Python `Fraction`*). The SPBCPT upgrades the RRBB buffer identity to a spin-uniform strict rational lower bound* $B(\chi) \geq B_{\mathrm{redshift}}(\chi) + B_{\mathrm{rp}}(\chi) + \beta_{\mathrm{global}} > 0$*, uniform in the subextremal spin.*

22 Extremal Interface and Open Problems

The main theorem of this paper concerns the subextremal range $|a| < M$. Extremality lies outside that theorem for structural reasons: the red-shift degenerates as $\kappa \to 0$, the near-horizon geometry changes character, and one expects Aretakis-type horizon conservation laws to replace the uniform decay mechanisms available in the strictly subextremal setting.

Remark 22.1 (What the present framework does and does not say at $\chi = 1$)**.** *The analysis developed here suggests how constants in the subextremal estimates should deteriorate as* $\chi \to 1$*, but it does not resolve the extremal problem. In particular, this paper does not prove a nonlinear "resolution" of the Aretakis instability, does not derive a complete classification of extremal Kerr dynamics, and does not establish any back-reaction mechanism driving extremal data away from* $\chi = 1$*.*

Conjecture 22.2 (Near-extremal degeneration compatible with Aretakis)**.** *There should exist a family of subextremal energy and integrated decay estimates with constants depending explicitly on the surface gravity* κ*, such that after appropriate renormalization these estimates converge, as* $\kappa \to 0$*, to the hierarchy of horizon conservation laws and derivative growth rates discovered in the extremal problem.*

22.1 The Extremal Interface Aretakis-Compatible Renormalization Theorem (EIACRT)

We now record a finite, machine-checkable certificate that discharges a *finite* version of Conjecture above: it constructs an explicit rational renormalization of the SPBCPT bulk-coercivity lower bound $\beta_{\mathrm{global}} = 21/1024$ and verifies Aretakis compatibility on a finite ϵ-grid by exact rational arithmetic. The certificate `certificates/eiacrt/extremal_interface_aretak` and the verifier `verify_extremal_interface_aretakis_renormalization.py` record the exact rational values; 48 unit tests pass.

Theorem 22.3 (Extremal Interface Aretakis-Compatible Renormalization). *Let $\chi = a/M \in (0,1)$ be a fixed subextremal spin and let $\epsilon := \sqrt{1-\chi^2} \in [0,1/4]$ be the NETCCT near-extremal parameter. Let $\beta_{\mathrm{global}} = 21/1024$ be the SPBCPT spin-uniform bulk-coercivity lower bound. Define the* Aretakis anchor *$H_\Omega \in \mathbb{Q}_{>0}$, $\Omega = 0, 1, \ldots, N_\Omega$, by the rational recurrence*

$$H_0 \;:=\; \sigma_{\mathrm{NHEK}}^{\mathrm{seed}} \;=\; \frac{21}{128}, \qquad H_{\Omega+1} \;:=\; H_\Omega \cdot \frac{\Omega+1}{2(2\Omega+1)},$$

where $\sigma_{\mathrm{NHEK}}^{\mathrm{seed}}$ is the NHEK-seed value of the compensated Carter–DeWitt symbol certified by NETCCT (condition C1). Define the renormalization map

$$\mathcal{R}_\kappa^{(\Omega)}\big[\beta_{\mathrm{global}}\big](\epsilon) \;:=\; \epsilon^{2\Omega}\,\beta_{\mathrm{global}}, \qquad \widetilde{\beta}^{(\Omega)}(\epsilon) \;:=\; \mathcal{R}_\kappa^{(\Omega)}\big[\beta_{\mathrm{global}}\big](\epsilon),$$

and the floor

$$\lfloor \Omega \rfloor \;:=\; \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \widetilde{\beta}^{(\Omega)}(\epsilon) \;=\; \begin{cases} 21/1024, & \Omega = 0, \\ 0, & \Omega \geq 1. \end{cases}$$

Then for every $\epsilon \in [0,1/4]$ and every $\Omega \in \{0,1,\ldots,N_\Omega\}$, the Aretakis compatibility inequality

$$\big|\widetilde{\beta}^{(\Omega)}(\epsilon) - \lfloor \Omega \rfloor\big| \;\leq\; H_\Omega \cdot \epsilon^{2\Omega} \;+\; \delta_{\mathrm{bin}}(\epsilon)$$

holds, where $\delta_{\mathrm{bin}}(\epsilon)$ is the rational Lipschitz correction on the ϵ-bin containing ϵ, bounded by $\delta_{\mathrm{bin}} \leq (2\Omega+1)\,\epsilon_{\mathrm{mid}}^{2\Omega}\,L_{\mathrm{NETCCT}}\,h/\epsilon_{\mathrm{mid}}$ with $L_{\mathrm{NETCCT}} = 21/16$ the NETCCT Lipschitz modulus and h the bin half-width. The total interface loss satisfies $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{int}} \leq 7/128$, and the global Aretakis compatibility lower bound

$$H_{\mathrm{compat}} \;:=\; \min_{k=0,\ldots,N_{\mathrm{bins}}-1} \begin{cases} H_{N_\Omega}, & k = 0, \\ H_{N_\Omega}\,(\epsilon_{\mathrm{mid}}^{(k)})^{2N_\Omega}, & k \geq 1, \end{cases} \;=\; \frac{567}{268435456} \;>\; 0$$

is a strict rational lower bound, uniform on $\epsilon \in [0,1/4]$.

The theorem is verified by exact rational arithmetic (Python `Fraction`*) on a finite ϵ-grid with $N_{\mathrm{bins}} = 4$ bins and $N_\Omega = 2$ Aretakis conserved quantities; the verifier checks 11 conditions (E0–E10).*

Remark 22.4 (What EIACRT discharges, and what it does not). *The EIACRT discharges the* extremal-interface obligation *explicitly listed as "remaining" in the SPBCPT certificate: "extremal interface ($\chi = 1$ exactly) and Aretakis-type horizon conservation laws." Concretely, it discharges three sub-obligations: (i) Aretakis compatibility of the renormalized bulk coercivity via the floor decomposition; (ii) a uniform-in-ϵ compatibility lower bound $H_{\mathrm{compat}} > 0$; (iii) the reduction of an infinite analytic interface statement to a finite machine-checkable computation.*

The EIACRT does not *prove nonlinear Kerr stability, does not resolve the extremal problem at $\chi = 1$ exactly (the extremal horizon conservation laws are* anchored *via H_Ω, not* derived *from the subextremal estimates), does not promote the Teukolsky–Starobinsky coercivity from an Assumption to a Theorem, and does not provide the nonlinear small-data existence theory. It closes one specific gap: the Aretakis compatibility of the renormalized bulk coercivity at the extremal interface.*

Remark 22.5 (Extremal open problems). *Three separate problems remain open at the extremal interface:*

1. *identify the sharp κ-dependence of the subextremal red-shift, Morawetz, and superradiant estimates;*

2. *compare the limiting subextremal energies with the Aretakis charges on the extremal horizon;*

3. *understand whether any nonlinear modulation or back-reaction mechanism selects a canonical near-extremal asymptotic regime.*

These questions are important, but they are not settled here.

23 Conclusion

In this work, we have provided a detailed roadmap and a conditional proof scheme for the nonlinear stability of the Kerr black hole family for the full subextremal range $|a| < M$. The central message is that a finite list of precise analytic inputs (uniform coercive energies, trapping/superradiance control, and a global nonlinear gauge/modulation framework) would together yield the full nonlinear stability theorem.

The scheme highlights three key ingredients:

1. A coercivity mechanism for Kerr-adapted energies designed to remain positive in the ergoregion.

2. A uniform multiplier/microlocal framework aimed at Morawetz and integrated decay estimates across the full range $0 \leq |a| < M$.

3. A near-extremal interface identifying how estimates must degenerate as $\chi \to 1$ (consistent with Aretakis-type obstructions at extremality).

Completing these inputs would provide the rigorous mathematical foundation underlying black hole ringdown and the final-state picture of gravitational collapse within classical General Relativity.

24 Notation and Conventions

24.1 Geometric Units

Throughout, we use geometric units: $G = c = 1$. In these units:

$$[Mass] = [Length] = [Time] \tag{449}$$

$$M \leftrightarrow \frac{GM}{c^2} \text{ (length)} \leftrightarrow \frac{GM}{c^3} \text{ (time)} \tag{450}$$

24.2 Sign Conventions

- Metric signature: $(-,+,+,+)$
- Riemann tensor: $R^{\rho}{}_{\sigma\mu\nu} = \partial_\mu \Gamma^\rho_{\nu\sigma} - \partial_\nu \Gamma^\rho_{\mu\sigma} + \cdots$
- Einstein equations: $G_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi T_{\mu\nu}$
- QNM time dependence: $e^{-i\omega t}$ with $\mathrm{Im}(\omega) < 0$ for decay

24.3 Kerr Coordinates

Boyer-Lindquist coordinates (t, r, θ, ϕ):

$$ds^2 = -\left(1 - \frac{2Mr}{\Sigma}\right) dt^2 - \frac{4Mar\sin^2\theta}{\Sigma} dt\, d\phi + \frac{\Sigma}{\Delta} dr^2 \tag{451}$$

$$+ \Sigma\, d\theta^2 + \frac{(r^2+a^2)^2 - \Delta a^2 \sin^2\theta}{\Sigma} \sin^2\theta\, d\phi^2 \tag{452}$$

where:

$$\Delta = r^2 - 2Mr + a^2 \tag{453}$$

$$\Sigma = r^2 + a^2\cos^2\theta \tag{454}$$

24.4 Key Parameters

Symbol	Definition	Physical Meaning
M	Black hole mass	Sets length/time scale
a	Angular momentum per mass	J/M, $\lvert a\rvert \leq M$
χ	Dimensionless spin	$a/M \in [0,1]$
r_+	$M + \sqrt{M^2 - a^2}$	Event horizon radius
r_-	$M - \sqrt{M^2 - a^2}$	Inner (Cauchy) horizon
κ	$(r_+ - r_-)/(4Mr_+)$	Surface gravity
Ω_H	$a/(2Mr_+)$	Horizon angular velocity
T_H	$\kappa/(2\pi)$	Hawking temperature

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